

from the editors of

ADDITUDE

The Emotions of ADHD

**How to Understand and Manage
Emotional Dysregulation, RSD,
Anger, & Overwhelm**



ADDITUDE Expert eBook

A trusted source of advice and information for families touched by attention-deficit disorder—
and a voice of inspiration to help people with ADHD find success at home, at school, and on the job.

additudemag.com/shop

TERMS OF USE

Copyright © 2023 WebMD LLC. All rights reserved. No part of this report may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, faxing, emailing, posting online, or by any information storage and retrieval system, without written permission from the Publisher.

All trademarks and brands referred to herein are the property of their respective owners. All references to *ADDitude* magazine and [ADDitudeMag.com](https://www.additudemag.com) are trademarks of WebMD LLC.

CONTACT INFORMATION

283-299 Market Street, 3rd Floor
2 Gateway Center
Newark, NJ 07102

LEGAL NOTICES

ADDitude does not provide medical advice, diagnosis or treatment. The information offered here is for informational purposes only and is not intended to substitute for or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult with your physician or other qualified health-care professional or educational consultant for questions about your health or education, or that of your child or family members. Do not disregard, avoid or delay obtaining medical or health related advice from your health-care professional because of something you have read here.

If you think you may have a medical emergency, call your doctor or 911 immediately. *ADDitude* does not recommend or endorse any specific tests, physicians, products, procedures, opinions, or other information that may be mentioned in *ADDitude* publications or web sites. Reliance on any information provided by *ADDitude* is solely at your own risk.

FOUNDER: Ellen Kingsley (1951-2007)

GENERAL MANAGER: Anni Layne Rodgers

EDITOR: Carole Fleck

MANAGING EDITOR: Eve Gilman

SENIOR EDITOR: Melanie Wolkoff Wachsman

ASSISTANT EDITOR: Nathaly Pesantez

CONSUMER HEALTH EDITOR: Nicole Caccavo Kear

WEB AND SOCIAL MEDIA ASSISTANT: Hope Goodrich

EDITORIAL PROJECT MANAGEMENT SPECIALIST: Carly Broadway

COPY EDITOR: Gene Jones

ADVERTISING: Tracy Kennedy

CIRCULATION: Sue Sidler

CONSULTING ART DIRECTOR: Ron Anteroine

CONTRIBUTING EDITORS

Sharon Saline, Psy.D. (Children)

Edward M. Hallowell, M.D. (Life)

Sandy Maynard, M.S. (Coaching)

Michele Novotni, Ph.D. (Adults)

Ann Dolin, M.Ed. (Education)

SCIENTIFIC ADVISORY BOARD

Dawn Kamilah Brown, M.D.

Child, Adolescent, Adult &
Sports Psychiatrist

Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.

University of
Southern California
Los Angeles, CA

William Dodson, M.D.

Dodson ADHD Center
Greenwood Village, CO

Ross W. Greene, Ph.D.

Lives in the Balance
Portland, ME

Edward M. Hallowell, M.D.

The Hallowell Center
Sudbury, MA

Stephen P. Hinshaw, Ph.D.

University of California
Berkeley, CA

Peter Jaksa, Ph.D.

ADD Centers of America
Chicago, IL

Walt Karniski, M.D.

Tampa, FL

Peter Jensen, M.D.

The REACH Institute
New York, NY

Sandy Newmark, M.D.

Osher Center for
Integrative Medicine
University of California
San Francisco, CA

Michele Novotni, Ph.D.

The Villages, FL

Roberto Olivardia, Ph.D.

Harvard Medical School
Boston, MA

J. Russell Ramsay, Ph.D.

Perelman School of Medicine
University of Pennsylvania
Philadelphia, PA

Jerome Schultz, Ph.D.

Harvard Medical School
Boston, MA

Copyright Notice

Here's what you CAN do

- Print out one copy and route this “original” to family.
- You are permitted to have one copy of this publication on your computer at any time. (You cannot put it on a network unless you purchased a license to do so.)
- Copy, on an occasional basis, a couple of pages to give to friends, family members, or colleagues.
- If you want to distribute copies of this publication, either in print or electronic form, to others on a regular basis, ask us about bulk discounts or licensing opportunities.

Here's what you CAN'T do (without prior permission)

- Make or forward email copies of an entire publication. The law provides for a very limited amount of copying, commonly referred to as “fair use.” However, cover-to-cover photocopying is forbidden.

Electronic transmission of a copyrighted work is the legal equivalent of photocopying it (and so is posting it on the Internet or in an electronic database), and is therefore not allowed.

- Routinely copy and distribute portions.
- Republish or repackage the contents.

Some publishers must resort to lawsuits to protect their publications. ADDitude would like to eliminate the need for such suits by helping to educate customers. We hope this outline has helped explain what is legal and what is not.

Permissions, Licensing, Bulk Sales Requests to:

ADDitude, a WebMD company
283-299 Market Street, 3rd Floor
2 Gateway Center
Newark, NJ 07102
Email: customerservice@additudemag.com

The Emotions of ADHD

**How to Understand and Manage
Emotional Dysregulation, RSD,
Anger, & Overwhelm**

CONTENTS

Introduction.....	5
Chapter 1: Why Strong Emotions Flood ADHD Brains	6
Chapter 2: Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria: A Hallmark ADHD Symptom.....	49
Chapter 3: Emotional Dysregulation & the ADHD-Anger Connection	83
Chapter 4: Stop Overwhelm and Stress from Controlling Your Life.....	126
Chapter 5: Emotional Regulation Strategies That Work	172
Chapter 6: Personal Stories + Additional Resources.....	220

Introduction

People with ADHD feel emotions more intensely than most other people. This makes us more caring, loving, empathetic, and passionate. But emotional dysregulation can also make us more likely to overreact in ways that can damage our careers and relationships with friends, colleagues, and romantic partners. For many, difficulty with emotional regulation is one of the most challenging symptoms to manage. This eBook is here to help.

You can't manage the impairments of ADHD until you understand how you process emotion. Researchers have largely ignored the emotional component of ADHD. Yet emotional disruptions are the most impairing aspects of ADHD at any age. Emotions such as rejection sensitivity, anger, stress, and overwhelm affect our lives and happiness—and here we explain why and how to better manage them.

Primary among those emotions is rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD), an intense vulnerability to the perception—not necessarily the reality—of being rejected, teased, or criticized by important people in your life. Here, explore whether you demonstrate symptoms of RSD and learn strategies for ending its dominance over your emotional health.

Stress and overwhelm are also dominant emotions in ADHD brains; executive function challenges diminish. working memory and impulse control, as well as our mental flexibility and coping skills. Here, find expert strategies to reduce stress levels and lessen feelings of overwhelm.

The bottom line is: You are not your ADHD reactivity. Yes, the ADHD brain is wired to overreact and to feel emotions intensely, but you can learn how to change your reactive, habitual anger responses with thoughtful, soothing responses. You can also teach and model emotional regulation skills to your child to help them tame meltdowns, outbursts, and other negative behaviors. This eBook explains how to become an emotional role model, create supportive environments, and develop a more regulated household—one deep, cleansing breath at a time.

CHAPTER 1:

Why Strong Emotions Flood ADHD Brains

Chapter 1: Why Strong Emotions Flood ADHD Brains

Why We Feel So Much—and Ways to Overcome It

Everyone experiences frustrations, disappointments, and challenges, but not everyone reacts as strongly as you do to them. Small, relatively insignificant setbacks may provoke an outsized response from those diagnosed with ADHD. Research shows that we have greater challenges with frustration, impatience, anger, and excitability than neurotypical people. That's because ADHD impairs our ability to regulate our emotions and experience them in a controlled way so they don't gush out into the world.

But there are ways to tone down our emotional explosions and turn them into positive energy. Before we explore them, here is more science on the ADHD emotions factory.

ADHD: A Failure-to-Regulate-Mood Disorder

“ADHD is not a mood disorder. It's a Failure-to-Regulate-Mood Disorder,” says ADHD expert Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D. From a neuropsychological standpoint, regulation is all about connectivity within the brain. Emotions are generated in the limbic system—which includes the amygdala, the anterior cingulate, and other parts that make up our “primitive brain”—which controls fear, pleasure, and anger. When an emotion is generated, the limbic system connects with the prefrontal cortex, which manages that emotion. The cortex pauses, assesses the significance of the situation, calculates the costs of reacting outwardly, and suppresses actions not in our best interest.

The frontal cortex is like a security checkpoint. But in the ADHD brain, the neurochemical connectivity needed to guard that checkpoint is weak, allowing emotions to stampede past the security gate and wreak havoc with outbursts. Not assessed. Not calculated. Not suppressed. Never in our best interest.

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

Unchecked Emotions Can Damage Relationships, Careers, Everything

- **We react to minor problems or annoyances as if they were DEFCON Level 1 threats.** We're thrown into panic mode easily; we get super-stressed about little stuff; we lose sight of the big picture, often resulting in decisions or actions we later regret.
- **We have difficulty calming down once a strong emotion takes hold.** We stew for hours or days over an emotional event. And that stewing prevents, or at least impairs, our getting back to work and moving our priorities forward.
- **We're extremely sensitive to disapproval, rejection, and criticism.** We might interpret a colleague's reaction to something we proposed as criticism, disapproval, or even insult, when none was intended. We tend to react self-defensively, or, worse, angrily. Rejection sensitivity is extremely common in people with ADHD.
- **We get overly excited about things, including good things.** Just as we often over-react to minor problems and annoyances, we can also go overboard in the other direction. This may mean diving headlong into a new hobby and realizing after dishing out \$1,800 on equipment and six months of lessons, that "We should have eased into this."

Body Awareness Helps to Identify Unhealthy Feelings

This all may sound pretty bleak, but ADHD emotionality is actually a bad news/good news situation. The good news is that we can build some defenses and *leverage* against some of our strong emotions to shift our energy in the direction we want to move: forward.

Learning to handle our negative emotions as they occur begins with becoming fully *aware* of when we're in their grasp. And a key to doing this is to listen to our bodies.

Research shows that body awareness helps us identify unhealthy feelings and step off the emotional merry-go-round. When we have a negative emotion, our body sends stress signals: tension in our neck and shoulders, discomfort in our solar plexus ("gut pangs"), or wherever it is we first feel stress in our bodies.

A second prerequisite to these interventions is to *name our emotions*. Naming emotions, what psychologists call *labeling*, goes beyond just thinking, "Yes, I'm angry" or "Wow, am I sad." *Emotional Agility* author Susan David, Ph.D., says, "[When] experiencing a strong

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

emotion...take a moment to consider what to call it, but don't stop there. Come up with two more words that describe how you're feeling."

You Can Create a Healthier “Emotional Home”

Imagine a late afternoon at work. You got little sleep the night before, had to skip lunch, and haven't been able to get to the gym or take a walk outdoors for a couple of weeks. You just spent the last 10 minutes staring at the tasks you must do to keep what feels like a dead-end job. I would call this feeling an “unhealthy emotional home.”

Now imagine that your teenage son calls and tells you that he just totaled the SUV. Your reaction probably won't be measured and balanced.

Let's rebuild that emotional home: You're getting seven to eight hours of sleep most nights; you're feeding your ADHD brain with protein and complex carbs, and, even when the day is so crazy that you have to skip lunch, you have some raw nuts and protein bars handy. Even though you haven't gone to the gym in a couple of weeks, you took a long walk around the neighborhood before bedtime; you've been blocking off the mornings in your calendar to build in quality work sessions and restorative breaks.

Now you get that awful call from your son. Will your emotional response be different? Maybe you go into your problem-solving mode rather than launching into a scream-fest? Diet, sleep, exercise, mindset, and other lifestyle adjustments will help protect you from emotions.

There are many things you can do every day to reduce your emotional vulnerability. Here are four simple additions:

- **Daily gratitude ritual.** The act of writing down three things every day for which you are grateful has been shown in the research of Harvard's Shawn Achor, author of *The Happiness Advantage*, to reduce reactivity and boost a positive outlook in the face of challenges.
- **Get a positive nag.** You've likely heard of vision boards or dream boards. Research shows that positive imagery reduces stress and improves mental clarity. Consider creating a simple montage of aspirational images reflecting your ideal life, and put it where you'll see it every day, if not all day long. My computer screensaver is a rotation of such images along with empowering quotes.

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

- **Journaling.** There are more than 40 years of research on the link between writing and emotional processing. For instance, a study of laid-off workers found that those who explored their negative feelings in writing were three times more likely to find a new job.
- **Self-Compassion.** When you screw up, be kind to yourself. It's like the golden rule with a twist: Treat yourself as you would treat others. Talk to yourself as if you were consoling a good friend: "Hey, buddy, don't sweat it. Tomorrow's a new start."

Replace the Negative Emotion with a Positive One

After you've caught that tension in your body and named that emotion, you can release it. And the best way to release an emotion is to *replace* it—with gratitude, for instance. Gratitude vaporizes negative emotions. Personal development guru Tony Robbins notes: "When you're grateful, there's no anger. It's impossible to be angry and grateful simultaneously."

Easier said than done? Yes. But think about this: We are the only species that can think a thought and become angry...think a thought and become sad...and think a thought and be grateful.

My client, Erin, who is a life coach, learned to listen to her body to detect an impending emotional storm. "When I grab a strand of my hair and start twirling it, I know it's time for me to stop, listen to my breath, and reclaim my brain from my amygdala." She solidifies control by defaulting to gratitude and asks, "What is good about right now?" There's always something to be grateful for.

"Flip" Your Anger

What if a fit of anger could become the spark for getting busy on a tough task? With a little mental jiu-jitsu, you can flip anger around, so that it's moving you in a positive direction.

Since anger is grounded in a feeling that something needs to change, that feeling creates energy. Usually, destructive energy, but energy that could be *constructive*.

As author Soleira Green puts it: "Anger is the tip of passion. You wouldn't get upset if you didn't care so much about something! Anger is your own body telling you, 'Here's something that matters... and here's some energy to deal with it!'" The trick to flipping angry energy is to ask a few questions:

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

- “What’s triggering me—what’s underneath this?”
- “What do I care about that’s making me angry?”
- “How could I use that energy to move forward with the thing that’s making me angry?”

Answering these questions creates what Green describes as “negative nag,” using what ticks you off to fuel motivation and problem-solving. Next time you’re angry about something (even at yourself), observe that energy and ask that series of questions.

All emotions, particularly negative ones, have “adaptive value”—meaning they can be used to help us cope and respond to difficult situations because at the heart of every negative emotion is the sense that *something must change!*

Research shows that those who recognize and control their emotions earn more and achieve more than those who don’t. So, our emotionality is one more way people with ADHD have a tougher journey than our neurotypical friends. But with these strategies, we can go from destructive emotions to acceptance and problem-solving.

This article was written by Alan P. Brown, an ADHD coach and the creative force behind ADD Crusher™, a video series designed for teens and adults with ADHD.

Exaggerated Emotions: How and Why ADHD Triggers Intense Feelings

By Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.

You're *not* imagining things, ADHD really is linked to more powerful, sudden, and unruly emotions.

Few doctors factor in emotional challenges when making an ADHD diagnosis. In fact, current diagnostic criteria for ADHD include no mention of “problems with emotions.” Yet research reveals that those with ADHD have significantly more difficulty with low frustration tolerance, impatience, hot temper, and excitability than a control group.

Processing Emotion: A Brain Thing

Challenges with emotions start in the brain itself. Sometimes the working memory impairments of ADHD allow a momentary emotion to become too strong, flooding the brain with one intense emotion. At other times, the person with ADHD seems insensitive or unaware of other people's emotions. Brain connectivity networks carrying information related to emotion seem more limited in individuals with ADHD.

Fixating on a Feeling

When an adolescent with ADHD becomes enraged when a parent refuses them the use of the car, for example, their overly emotional response may be due to “flooding”—a momentary emotion that can gobble up all the space in their head just like a computer bug can gobble up all of the space on a hard drive. This focus on one emotion crowds out other important information that might help them modulate their anger and regulate their behavior.

Individuals with ADHD often become quickly immersed in one salient emotion and have problems shifting their focus to other aspects of a situation. Hearing a slight uncertainty in a co-worker's reaction to a suggestion without listening carefully to the rest of their response may lead to interpreting this as criticism and an outburst of inappropriate self-defense.

Significant social anxiety is a chronic difficulty experienced by more than one-third of teens and adults with ADHD. They live almost constantly with exaggerated fears of being seen by others as incompetent, unappealing, or uncool.

Some people with ADHD don't suffer from a lack of awareness of important emotions but from an inability to tolerate them enough to deal with them effectively. They become

caught up in behavior patterns to avoid painful emotions that seem too overwhelming—looming deadlines or meeting an unfamiliar group of people.

For many people with ADHD, the brain's gating mechanism for regulating emotion does not distinguish between dangerous threats and more minor problems. These individuals are often thrown into panic mode by thoughts or perceptions that do not warrant such a reaction. As a result, the ADHD brain can't deal more rationally and realistically with events that are stressful.

People with untreated ADHD can suffer from dysthymia—a mild but long-term mood disorder or sadness. It is often brought on by living with the frustrations, failures, negative feedback, and stresses of life due to untreated or inadequately treated ADHD. People who are dysthymic suffer almost every day from low energy and self-esteem.

Emotions and Getting Started

Emotions motivate action—action to engage or action to avoid. Many people with untreated ADHD can readily mobilize interest only for activities offering very immediate gratification. They tend to have severe difficulty in activating and sustaining effort for tasks that offer long-term rewards.

Brain imaging studies demonstrate that chemicals that activate reward-recognizing circuits in the brain tend to bind on significantly fewer receptor sites in people with ADHD than those in a comparison group. People with ADHD are less able to anticipate pleasure or register satisfaction with tasks that have a delayed payoff.

Emotions and Working Memory

Working memory brings into play, consciously and unconsciously, the emotional energy needed to help us organize, sustain focus, monitor, and self-regulate. Many individuals with ADHD, though, have inadequate working memory, which may explain why they are often disorganized, lose their temper, or procrastinate.

Sometimes working memory impairments allow a momentary emotion to become too strong. At other times, working memory impairments leave the person with insufficient sensitivity to the importance of a particular emotion because they haven't kept other relevant information in mind.

Treating Emotional Challenges

Treating the emotional challenges of ADHD requires a multimodal approach: It starts with a careful and accurate evaluation for ADHD, one that explains ADHD and its effect

on emotions. ADHD medication may improve the emotional networks in the brain. Talk therapy can help a person manage fear or low self-esteem. Coaching may also help a person overcome problems with getting boring tasks completed.

After serving on the clinical faculty of Yale Medical School for 25 years, Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D. relocated to Manhattan Beach, California, to open the Brown Clinic for Attention and Related Disorders. He is also an adjunct clinical associate professor of psychiatry and behavioral sciences at the Keck School of Medicine of the University of Southern California and the author of Smart but Stuck: Emotions in Teens and Adults with ADHD and Outside the Box: Rethinking ADD/ADHD in Children and Adults: A Practical Guide.

Why Am I So Overly Emotional?

By Peter Jaksa, Ph.D.

More than half of people with ADHD find it hard to regulate their emotions, according to research. Irritability, angry outbursts, rejection sensitivity, and other intense emotions define the ADHD experience—at least in part—for many. Genetics and biology are partly responsible and contribute to a recipe for emotional dysregulation—reacting too intensely, too impulsively, and out of proportion to the situation at hand.

This emotional intensity affects relationships with friends, co-workers, family, and romantic partners. On the positive side, it can make people with ADHD more caring, more loving, and more passionate about things that interest them. On the negative side, ADHD emotionality makes people more likely to overreact in ways that can be destructive. The reason this happens is no mystery: Emotional people react emotionally. It becomes a problem when it happens too frequently and too intensely.

Below are profiles of highly emotional individuals with ADHD and their relationship struggles. Learn how they addressed challenges like rejection sensitivity, outbursts, and more.

Overly Emotional with ADHD: Real-Life Stories

Rejection Sensitivity

“I don’t take criticism well,” Pauline says. She always feels “on edge” about being criticized. When it happens, she says, “I feel overwhelmed emotionally, so I panic and shut down.”

Being hypersensitive to criticism (real or imagined) leaves Pauline in a high state of anxiety, which is bad enough. Beyond that, it damages her relationship with her husband, Brian, because she withdraws from him. “She stops communicating,” Brian says. When Pauline withdraws, he feels neglected. It kills emotional intimacy and trust, and it is painful for both of them.

How did they solve the problem? Pauline acknowledged her rejection sensitivity in conversations with Brian. She discussed her feelings at the moment and did not hide them. This also helped Brian connect with her instead of being shut out. It gave him a chance to explain himself when Pauline felt criticized because, very often, he was not being critical. This helped her keep things in perspective and to get reassurance from Brian that she was not failing in some way.

This understanding and support from Brian helped Pauline get a better handle on her overreaction. Dealing with the rejection sensitivity openly gave this couple a foundation for healthy communication and a happier relationship.

Temper Flares and Angry Outbursts

Ethan loses his temper once or twice a week. It happens more often at home, with his wife and children, and sometimes at work. Luckily for Ethan, he owns his own business. Otherwise, his outbursts would have gotten him fired long ago.

Ethan often gets frustrated and angry when someone does not do something the right way. “I react too quickly rather than talk it through,” he explains. He has tried many times to tone down his anger, but “I don’t know where the off switch is.”

Ethan’s family had to experience his frequent outbursts, although they knew he was not a mean person. He heated up quickly but also calmed down quickly, all within a matter of minutes. Even so, it made them feel unsafe around him. After several discussions, his wife insisted that he seek professional help. Ethan agreed it was a problem.

The most helpful treatment was a combination of ADHD medication and behavior therapy. The medication helped moderate his high levels of emotion. The behavior therapy helped him identify physical and emotional anger cues, so that he could catch himself and defuse the anger before it became an outburst. With treatment, Ethan found the “switch” for better temper control.

Impatience and Pushy Demands

Aiden has no patience for unresolved issues and drawn-out discussions. He needs answers and wants things settled—now. If he’s arguing with his partner, and his partner wishes to end the discussion and walks away, Aiden follows him into the next room to continue the conversation.

“I pick on something, and I can’t let go,” Aiden says. He knows this is inconsiderate, but “for the life of me, I can’t help it.” This leaves his partner feeling angry and resentful.

Aiden understands that his need for immediate gratification is part of his ADHD biology and goes back to his childhood, when he threw tantrums in toy and grocery stores. Through the years, these behaviors have damaged relationships. It has never happened in a work relationship because of the clear boundaries there. Work relationships are also not as meaningful to him.

Aiden ultimately managed his pushy behavior by taking more control of his emotions and his impulsivity. He made a strong commitment to respect the wishes of his part-

ner and other people in his life. No meant no—a good rule to live by. He also put into practice a five-second rule when he felt himself getting impatient or pushy. Before he allowed himself to say anything, he counted to five and considered the consequences of his behavior. It was not foolproof, but it helped.

5 Strategies for Managing Intense ADHD Feelings

1. Understand the biology of ADHD and emotional dysregulation. Managing the biology is most helpful. Criticizing the behavior is never helpful.
2. The person with ADHD is always responsible for managing their behavior. ADHD should never be used as an excuse. Never. Ever. Period.
3. Self-awareness and self-monitoring can manage emotional over-reaction at the behavioral level. Therapy and coaching can also help.
4. Medication and exercise modulate ADHD and the tendency to overreact.
5. Treat coexisting conditions—anxiety, mood and substance use disorders. These comorbidities complicate emotional self-regulation when they are present.

Peter Jaksa, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist, former president of the Attention Deficit Disorder Association (ADDA), and author of Life With ADHD.

DESR: Why Deficient Emotional Self-Regulation Is Central to ADHD (and Largely Overlooked)

What Is DESR?

Deficient emotional self-regulation (DESR) is a relatively new term used to describe the problem of impulsive emotion coupled with emotional self-regulation difficulties—issues long associated with ADHD. “DESR may be new to the ADHD lexicon. However, I argue that it is a core and commonly overlooked component of the disorder—and can help predict a patient’s impairments and even improve diagnostic and treatment practices,” says Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., a retired clinical scientist, educator, and practitioner who has written extensively about DESR. Dr. Barkley discussed DESR’s central role in ADHD during the *ADDitude* webinar titled “Deficient Emotional Self-Regulation: The Overlooked ADHD Symptom That Impacts Everything.”

Emotional dysregulation is noticeably missing from the diagnostic criteria for ADHD. However, Dr. Barkley says, most patients and experts recognize that it is central to the disorder. DESR is a manifestation of emotional dysregulation. Dr. Barkley says it specifically refers to deficiencies with these four components of *emotional self-regulation*:

- Ability to inhibit inappropriate behavior triggered by strong emotions. “I argue that this **emotional impulsiveness** (EI) is an aspect of poor inhibition associated with ADHD that is illustrated by low frustration tolerance, impatience, being quick to anger, aggression, greater emotional excitability, and other negative reactions, all of which are related to the impulsivity dimension of the disorder,” he says.
- Ability to self-soothe and regulate a strong emotion to reduce its severity
- Ability to refocus attention from emotionally provocative events
- Ability to organize or substitute more moderate, healthier emotional responses in the service of goals and long-term welfare

To understand the role of EI and DESR in ADHD is to acknowledge the prominent role of emotional control difficulties in the disorder’s appearance and outlook, including understanding the following:

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

- Why these issues are prevalent in individuals with ADHD.
- Why major comorbid disorders often develop because of these challenges.
- What major life impairments are not adequately explained by traditional ADHD symptoms.

“A wealth of compelling evidence—from ADHD’s clinical conceptualization over time to neuroanatomical and psychological research—clearly shows that EI and DESR are key components of ADHD and should be incorporated into the disorder’s diagnostic criteria and treatment practices,” Dr. Barkley says.

EI and DESR and the Neuroanatomy of ADHD

The brain structures and networks implicated in ADHD are also involved in emotion and would thus logically give rise to EI and DESR and be part of the disorder, Dr. Barkley explains. The frontal lobe, the anterior cingulate, the ventral striatum, and the amygdala all comprise the executive circuitry that has been repeatedly shown to be involved in causing ADHD. Some of these structures also form the brain’s emotional circuitry—the amygdala and larger limbic system to which it is connected is where emotion is generated, and the prefrontal cortex (PFC) and related structures attend to these generated emotions. “How we feel also influences how we think, and the dorsolateral PFC is where some thinking occurs, as well as working memory (or what we hold in mind),” Dr. Barkley says.

EI and DESR in ADHD Psychological Research

Emotional self-regulation is a major dimension of executive functioning required for daily life activities. It is also one of the most impaired dimensions in children and adults with ADHD. “Ample evidence from an abundance of psychological research shows that children and adults with ADHD are highly likely to manifest EI-DESR, including low frustration tolerance, anger, poor inhibition of emotion, and emotional excitability,” Dr. Barkley says.

EI and DESR and Impairment in Major Life Activities

Centering the role of emotion in ADHD predicts many of the impairments that are not similarly associated with traditional ADHD symptoms: hyperactivity, inattention, and/or impulsivity.

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

Dr. Barkley says that emotional dysregulation uniquely predicts the following:

- social rejection in children with ADHD
- interpersonal hostility and marital dissatisfaction in adults with ADHD
- greater parenting stress and family conflict in parents of children with ADHD; greater stress in parents with ADHD
- road rage, DUIs, and crash risks during driving
- job dismissals and workplace interpersonal problems
- dating/cohabiting relationship conflicts
- impulse buying; poor finances

EI and DESR: Diagnostic Implications

“Elevating EI-DESR’s place in ADHD would greatly assist with differential diagnosis of the disorder from mood disorders and other conditions involving emotional dysregulation,” Dr. Barkley says. In other words, it would reduce the odds of misdiagnosis for patients simply experiencing what is central to ADHD. (Individuals with ADHD are commonly misdiagnosed with mood disorders.)

“Mood disorders, however, are common in individuals with ADHD, so comorbidity must be considered,” Dr. Barkley says. He explains that duration could be a guiding diagnostic principle to distinguish a legitimate mood disorder from the emotional dysregulation associated with ADHD.

“Emotions, unlike moods, are of short duration, setting-specific, provoked, and easily traced to the source. EI-DESR is a ‘top-down’ deficit in regulating rational, emotional responses to events; its impact is typically shorter in duration than a mood disorder,” he says.

Mood disorders, Dr. Barkley says, are generally “bottom-up” excessive expressions of emotions likely attributed to underlying amygdala-limbic system activities. They are of long duration—lasting hours, days, or weeks, and they are also cross-situational and irrational. (It is not clearly understood what triggers a patient with bipolar disorder to become manic, or the opposite.)

Expert Q&As with Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

Q: “Does emotional dysregulation change over time? Does it ever improve?”

Emotional dysregulation does change, and it can improve, but it depends on the individual and the factors involved. For instance, emotional self-regulation is rarely elevated as an issue in toddlers. We don't expect four-year-olds to manage their emotions very well. Parents are typically more concerned with the impulsive aspect of emotion at this stage.

But by late adolescence, and especially adulthood, we do expect individuals to have developed that second stage of emotional control: top-down executive management (or moderating emotional reactions to evocative events). However, DESR impairs just that—processes related to emotional self-regulation. And that leads to more disparaging moral judgment about adults with ADHD than it would in much younger individuals.

It's almost like the two components of this emotion problem in ADHD—emotional impulsivity (EI) and DESR—trade places as individuals age. The former is more problematic in children, while the latter becomes a more compelling deficit for adults.

We also know that ADHD symptoms fluctuate over time for many individuals, which may mean that issues like emotional dysregulation also change in severity or degree of impairment.

But can emotional regulation be “trained”? In children, the chances of that are quite slim because they haven't developed the appropriate self-regulation skills that such training would require. Interventions like medication, parent training, and controlling for environmental triggers may be helpful for this stage. Adults, however, may benefit from cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) and mindfulness-based programs for ADHD in adults, both of which help the individual deal with many aspects of emotional dysregulation.

Q: “Do men and women experience emotional dysregulation differently?”

Generally, we know that males are more prone to exhibit aggression and hostility, which are associated with externalizing disorders, while females are more prone to anxiety and mood disorders. However, both struggle with impatience and frustration, and the emotional dysregulation component in ADHD will only exacerbate that.

Q: “When might DESR symptoms start to appear in children?”

DESR usually appears between ages three and five, though it may be quite obvious in a younger child who is significantly hyperactive and impulsive. Still, many families write off this behavior, believing it to be developmentally normal (i.e., the terrible twos), only realizing later that the child is quite hot-headed and emotional

compared to their peers. Some children will develop oppositional defiant disorder (ODD). If we accept DESR as a core feature of ADHD, we can see why the disorder poses such a significant risk for ODD and related disorders.

Q: “Can parents manage DESR in children with ADHD without medication?”

It will be very, very difficult to do so. With ADHD in children, we’re looking at a dysregulated brain with a highly variable, immature executive circuitry—part of which includes this problem with emotional expression and regulation. To expect to find some other social or psychological intervention that can change that underlying neural network problem is asking too much of psychotherapy. It may be best to work with the aforementioned interventions as parents await the greater maturity of these neurological systems that come with further development.

Q: “Is there residual emotional difficulty in children and adults even after taking ADHD medication?”

Yes—sometimes medications can create their own problems. Stimulants, for example, may create emotional blunting, which is the absence of natural emotion in some children or adults. As stimulants wear off, it’s not uncommon for the emotional brain to go through a rebound. In some cases, that may look like irritability, a proneness to weepiness or crying, and sadness.

These experiences with stimulants are not universal but remember that you’ve been suppressing an emotional brain and, as the medication wears off, that could come to the fore. We don’t see this issue with non-stimulants as much because they’re not suppressing the emotional circuitry of the brain.

Ultimately, each drug works on the brain a little differently, and therefore, works on emotion a little differently. It’s why some clinicians opt to combine these medications to get much broader coverage over patient symptoms than any single drug could do.

Q: “How can a parent’s ADHD symptoms exacerbate their child’s symptoms and make their emotional dysregulation worse?”

Let’s say a child is engaging in some defiant, oppositional behavior. A parent with ADHD may experience a much stronger reaction than a neurotypical parent. They might exhibit a more impulsive reaction of anger or hostility toward the child, or they may arrive at that level of emotional upset faster than would a parent without ADHD.

When a parent exhibits these behaviors, they are, in effect, modeling these reactions to their child. They are also provoking the child, who has their own emotional regulation problems. What you have is an emotional tornado in the family—each person is triggering the other to higher levels of conflict.

Q: “Does trauma exacerbate DESR? What about PTSD?”

It’s bi-directional. Research suggests that ADHD, because of the emotional dysregulation factor, especially, puts children at a higher risk for exposure to trauma. And once trauma has occurred in a child with ADHD, it’s more likely to progress to a PTSD reaction. This is why ADHD is one of the strongest predictors of who will develop PTSD if exposed to trauma. Once PTSD develops, it will only worsen existing emotional regulation problems.

Q: “Is it ever too late to get help for emotional dysregulation?”

Absolutely not. It is never too late to get help for ADHD even if emotional dysregulation has been an impairing factor for a long time. Multiple studies show that a diagnosis in late life and subsequent treatment only benefits the individual.

Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., is a clinical scientist, educator, and practitioner who has published numerous books, scientific articles, rating scales, and clinical manuals and written extensively about SCT and DESR. At the time of this work, he was a clinical professor of psychiatry at the Virginia Commonwealth University School of Medicine in Richmond, Virginia. He is now retired.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “Deficient Emotional Self-Regulation: The Overlooked ADHD Symptom That Impacts Everything,” with Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

Expert Q&A with Marydee Sklar

Q: “My 13-year-old has become super emotional and upset when faced with a school-related challenge. How can we help him?”

Middle school, already marked by increased academic demands and expectations, is certainly made more challenging by the intense emotions and dysregulation that stem from puberty. Combine this with ADHD, and your teen’s response to tough homework questions or a heavier workload is understandable—even expected.

How to Manage Teenage Emotions

- 1. Educate your adolescent.** It’s important to help your child understand what’s going on with their bodies and brains. You don’t necessarily need to delve into puberty; just explain what’s happening in the brain. They need to understand that emotionality and anxiety are the mind’s defense mechanisms. Talking about their brain depersonalizes the issue and makes kids more inclined to learn how to calm down.
- 2. Teach them how to calm the brain.** There are several exercises your child can learn to calm intense emotions and build emotional resilience. Here’s one: Place the fingers behind the neck and flare the elbows out so that the lower back slightly arches. Push into your feet as you enter this position and take a few deep breaths. This posture activates the parasympathetic nervous system, which slows the heart and calms the brain.
- 3. Step back when emotions run high.** You cannot rationalize with a child who is out of control. In these moments, the brain is flooded with cortisol, meaning that access to their prefrontal cortex (the thinking brain) is cut off. They cannot hear you and respond rationally. In fact, statements like, “Just calm down” can be interpreted as an “attack” and lead to further spiraling (e.g., “I don’t know how to do this. I’m not smart enough.” or “I’m not going to get this, and mom’s going to be mad at me.”).

Instead of chiming in, be quietly present. Stand by your child and say nothing (but keep eye contact). Cortisol is what’s fueling the outbursts, but in the absence of further stimulation, they’ll calm down in about 90 seconds.
- 4. Take apart the trigger.** For a homework question that’s too difficult, for example, encourage your child to read one sentence at a time and then draw a little picture that explains its meaning. This step is great for gauging where your child gets confused, which is often the source of anxiety and eventual meltdowns.

Marydee Sklar is a time management educator and the founder of Executive Functioning Success.

Understanding the ADHD Brain Using the Intersection Model

By Alison Kravit, Psy.D., AAC

Misinformation about ADHD abounds among new patients at my busy practice. Many think medication alone will control their symptoms. Others believe that ADHD will not affect their lives once they graduate from college. And almost none fully understand the way the ADHD brain works to produce the symptoms they experience. To help, I have developed the Intersection Model—a framework that can be used throughout an individual's life to make sense of behaviors, impulses, and emotions, and to create strategies to manage them.

ADHD and the Prefrontal Cortex

At the center of the intersection model is the prefrontal cortex (PFC). It is responsible for thinking, thought analysis, and regulating behavior. This includes mediating conflicting thoughts, choosing between right and wrong, and predicting the probable outcomes of actions or events. This vital region of the brain regulates short-term and long-term decision-making. In addition, the PFC helps to focus thoughts, enabling people to pay attention, learn, and concentrate on goals.

In my model, the PFC is the intersection through which attention, behavior, judgment, and emotional responses run (I call them cars or messages). A person with ADHD will likely react to whatever is in their focus at that moment—in other words, the faster car or stronger message. For people with ADHD, the PFC is unregulated; there are no traffic lights or stop signs controlling which message (car) gets through first. You could be the smartest, most motivated student ever, but if the teacher says “This species of dog...” and your thought switches to “I wonder what my dog is doing right now?” you get distracted.

ADHD and Fickle Focus

This unregulated intersection may explain why your attention wanders. Say you're in the kitchen cleaning up and find something that belongs upstairs. You take it toward the stairs but get distracted by the unfolded laundry you see in the living room as you walk by. You may think, “I forgot to do that,” and jump to folding laundry, forgetting that you were heading upstairs (not to mention cleaning up the kitchen).

People with ADHD get distracted because whatever is in their focus at the moment cuts off other, weaker messages. This can happen in mid-conversation when a word triggers a thought that leads a person to another subject entirely.

ADHD and Time Management

Judgment runs through the PFC, as well. When you say, “That’ll take me five minutes to finish,” that’s a judgment call. “I’ll be there in a half hour” is a judgment call, too. We can’t see time or feel it. Understanding time, and conceptualizing time, isn’t as strong a message in the ADHD brain as the emotion behind a looming deadline or an unfinished task.

A person with ADHD might freak out about a deadline, saying, “Don’t talk to me, I have all these things to do and no time to do them!” Or the person says, “This task is going to take forever” and then uses that as a reason to procrastinate. If the person would just get started, the task would take maybe 10 minutes. In this case, the fastest car in the intersection is the emotion behind the judgment of how long it will take to meet the deadline.

ADHD and Emotional Regulation

Emotions run through the intersection of the PFC, bringing quick mood changes. “I won the lottery 10 minutes ago. Isn’t that great? But now my sink is overflowing. OMG, why does this always happen to me?” Impulsive anger (or sadness, or excitement, or worry) seems to come from nowhere when actually the emotion is a quick reaction to an event that just occurred (in this case, the sink debacle). That is what dominates the person’s focus at that moment.

In the ADHD brain, whichever emotion is in focus at the moment becomes the faster car. This is why those with ADHD express emotions more intensely than may be justified for a given situation. In females with ADHD, this emotionality is often misdiagnosed as a mood disorder.

ADHD and Impulsivity

Adults with ADHD may self-medicate or spend too much money on unnecessary items, looking for quick gratification instead of bigger, more sustaining rewards. They may cling to a strategy even after it’s proven ineffective, and rush through tasks, making errors in haste. This mindset leads to negative feedback from the world around them, interpersonal difficulties, and job or school troubles. Such inflexibility and impulsivity have a cumulative demoralizing and isolating effect

In response, the individual with ADHD develops a mindset that focuses on the negatives, which exacerbates the situation. When we say, “Nothing is getting better, so it’s pointless to try,” or “They’re not going to like me anyway, so why try to be friends?” it can lead us to stop trying because we perceive the situation as something that will only end in failure.

The faster car metaphor plays into being chronically late. If you are on your way out the door to go to work and say, “I have 15 minutes left, I can just do this one thing,” you

make yourself late. If you didn't have ADHD, you would stop and think, "Oh, I have 15 minutes, but that's not enough time to do this thing," or "I'll be late to work like last time." If you have ADHD, the stronger message isn't that you were late for work last time, but the desire to play a video game for a few minutes or text a friend about going out right now. And you are late for work—again. You keep doing the same things over and over because past experiences are cut off by what is in your focus at the moment.

Why People with ADHD Feel So Anxious

The current thought regarding individuals with undiagnosed/untreated ADHD is that they tend to overcompensate for their difficulties with an anxiety-like response, such as racing thoughts, sleep difficulties, nervousness, and excessive worry. This overcompensation might look like this: You start heading to work and think, "Did the garage door actually close? I don't remember seeing it close. What if I kicked something, which tripped the sensor, and the garage door opened? A thief will see that there aren't any cars in the garage and that no one is home. They are going to come in and take all my stuff. And when they leave, they will let the cats out. I'm never going to see them again. I love them, and I can't live without them. I have to go back and check. But I'll be late for work. What will I tell my boss?"

As I've said, people with ADHD often forget things that aren't in their focus, so these anxious thoughts are an attempt to keep these items (cars) in the intersection, so that the person doesn't forget about them. Holding many things in your mind creates a lot of tension, a traffic jam of sorts. Whenever too many things—thoughts or emotions—try to pass through the intersection simultaneously, you're apt to feel anxiously overwhelmed and shut down. For instance, when trying to clean a cluttered room, with many items demanding your attention and none of them sticking out as more important than the other, you don't know what to do first, so you don't do anything.

It's frustrating when you go to the store for paper towels—and come back with everything but paper towels. Buying paper towels is the fastest car when you enter the store, but when you see the delicious-looking pasta salad or the shiny red apples, they become the faster cars and overtake the paper towels—unless you've written down "buy paper towels" on a to-do list and read it.

Maintaining Motivation and Performance

Everybody likes to do things that are important and interesting, and that they're good at. We don't like things that are boring, frustrating, and not important. The problem is that those definitions change.

Let's say school is important to you. You spend all your time in the library studying, on your way to a 4.0 GPA. You have one more exam left, but you studied, so you should be fine. The test, and the motivation to do well, is the fastest car in the intersection. Right before you walk into the exam room, however, you get into a fight with your best friend—and you get a C on the exam. You studied and tried your hardest, but the fight was the stronger message during the test.

ADHD, Mood Disorders, and Low Self-Esteem

In addition to having variable moods, individuals with ADHD tend to have difficulty staying happy or satisfied. If you keep reacting to everyday bad experiences (remember the overflowing sink?) and don't realize that those things are daily stressors—you've handled things like this before, you will have to handle things like this again—it will be hard to feel happy. In the ADHD brain, negative messages cut off positive messages. We don't think, "Well, I have my health" and pull that thought out during stressful times.

Every person's ADHD affects them differently, but symptoms and behaviors can be explained through the Intersection Model. You can use this understanding of your ADHD brain to your advantage. You can find ways to erect a few stop signs or traffic lights, to make positive messages stronger, keep them in your focus longer, and improve your overall functioning and sense of self.

"Are You Criticizing Me, Again?"

The intersection model affects our relationships. Here's an example from my life:

Every Tuesday night, I come home and ask my husband if the garbage is ready, because it gets collected on Wednesday morning. Every Tuesday night, he gets defensive: "I did this and that, and this...what do you expect?" For him, the stronger message is "I am being criticized again." Those with ADHD are more likely to hear criticism when their partner merely asks a question.

Think of how many negative messages a child with ADHD receives throughout their life: 20,000 more criticisms by sixth grade than their non-ADHD counterparts. My husband was diagnosed with ADHD in grade school, so he's always heard, "You can do this, why can't you do that?" "Sit down," "Be quiet." His nickname in high school was "Slacker."

I can change my tone of voice, jump up and down, and remind him that we have this fight every single week, but it doesn't matter. He's still defensive. I ask him: "Do you think I'm criticizing you for not taking out the garbage?"

"Yeah."

“Nope! I’m just wondering if it’s done, because, if not, I’ll go do it myself.”

“Oh...OK! How was your day?”

My husband and I have lived together for 13 years, and this happens once a week. Because if I don’t ask that second question, we’re not talking about the same thing. I’m wondering if the garbage is ready to be collected, and he thinks he is hearing the same childhood criticisms again; he is having something he didn’t do pointed out to him again. In his brain, that is one of those fast cars likely to cut off any other car with a different interpretation of the situation.

Alison Kravit, Psy.D., AAC, is a clinical psychologist at Mequon Clinical Associates in Mequon, Wisconsin. She specializes in the treatment and management of ADHD, mood disorders, and developmental life-stage concerns. She is also a Certified ADHD Coach.

How Emotional Dysregulation Makes Us Feel

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is a prevalent concern among *ADDitude* readers, who report struggling to try new things and risk exposure to negative feedback. Impulsive anger impedes effective communication for others. Read on for more stories about the daily impact of emotional dysregulation from our readers, who answered the question: “What kind of ADHD emotional dysregulation has the greatest impact on your life and how do you deal with it?”

“I struggle to regulate frustration and grumpiness. When **I feel those emotions, I shut down and can’t communicate.** It tends to be triggered by plans changing, which happens a lot with three young girls! Luckily, my wife is brilliant at being patient with me and helps me recognize what is happening.”

“Emotional dysregulation manifests as rejection sensitivity for me. The **fear of being perceived negatively has stopped me from trying new things.** I’m an artist but I don’t draw anymore; I couldn’t bear to hear a single negative comment about my work.”

“My life is most impacted by how easily and quickly I become frustrated and angry. **I respond impulsively** in social interactions and make comments that, in retrospect, may be perceived as rude or inappropriate. I am trying to manage this by practicing these steps: ‘stop, breathe, think, do/say.’”

“My biggest emotional dysregulation burden is the constant anxiety that I feel about not living up to my potential. There’s so much I want to do and achieve, but **my mind spins so fast that my emotions can’t keep up.** It’s like one of those videos where someone is sitting still, but everything else around them is moving fast; the sun comes up and goes down and they are still sitting there. That image captures my inability to act and implement changes that could actually help.”

“Most of my life, I would ignore or put off feeling my emotions until it was way past the moment when they could have been resolved. **I struggle to trust my ‘gut feeling’ and intuition,** which contributes to my anxiety and depression.”

“Rejection sensitive dysphoria is my biggest emotional challenge. **I am so hard on myself and take even the silliest of slights personally.** I am fairly successful at my job, but fear of failure always holds me back.”

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

“My biggest issue is depending too much on emotional support from my parents and boyfriend. I’m at a place where I don’t feel like I could survive without any of them.”

“It’s car rage. Not road rage—no one else is threatened—but **when I’m sitting inside my car my brain rewinds to recent or long-past insults, the bad news of the day, or anything else that triggers me.** I end up doing the ’70s primal scream therapy thing (which is why I sound like I’ve smoked 10 packs of cigarettes). When the insults or stressors happen in real-time, my brain goes into a fog of what I now assume is cortisol overload: There’s an ocean-like roar in my head that freezes me up and makes me useless and unable to react.”

“The area of emotional dysregulation that most affects my life is criticism from others and from myself. **I feel some emotions as a physical sensation**—how can others receive criticism so calmly? Most people don’t understand my hypersensitive reactions. I am finally seeing a counselor and implementing CBT techniques, which has helped.”

Why Am I So Sensitive? Why ADHD Brains Can't Just Ignore Unfairness

By Marcy Caldwell, Psy.D.

Does walking past a sidewalk panhandler make you want to weep? Does the guy cutting the mile-long line at airport security send you into a rage? Do you feel paralyzed by a barrage of negative news?

If you answered yes to these questions, you may have the largely overlooked but hugely impactful ADHD trait called justice sensitivity. Whether it's triggered by societal injustice or small inequities, justice sensitivity causes you to perceive unfairness and wrongdoing in the world more frequently—and to feel it more acutely—than do neurotypical peers.

Several studies have found that ADHD brains (particularly the inattentive type) are significantly more justice-sensitive than neurotypical brains. Possible reasons for this include emotional lability, intensity, and dysregulation, which are common symptoms of ADHD. But researchers also theorize that ADHD brains tend to perceive information with a less positive view; this, along with cognitive rigidity and ADHD-impacted brain networks, can lead to intense rumination. And it doesn't stop there. Researchers found that people who have ADHD feel such a strong need to restore justice that they will take action to do so even if they hurt themselves in the long run.

Fixated on Unfairness: Symptoms of Justice Sensitivity

How do you know if you might be prone to justice sensitivity? If you identify with the following emotions, you may have this trait:

- Frequent anger and resentment about victimization
- Fear of future victimization
- Indignation about injustice done to others
- Strong drive to restore justice
- Perceiving injustice where others do not
- Hopelessness about large-scale issues facing the world
- Feelings of worthlessness when unfairly treated
- Rumination about inequity and injustice
- Intense guilt or shame about causing injustice

When Social Injustice Becomes All-Consuming

As anyone who's ever stumbled down the doom-scrolling rabbit hole can tell you, justice sensitivity can wreak havoc on mood, productivity, and energy levels. This is because people with ADHD are more likely to ruminate and feel the anger, helplessness, and despair that injustice can trigger, preventing them from moving on to other tasks and potentially affecting their mental health. In fact, research has shown that justice sensitivity, along with rejection sensitivity, largely accounts for the association between ADHD, depression, and anxiety.

But justice sensitivity doesn't have to overwhelm you, and there's plenty you can do to prevent feelings of helplessness and despair. To begin, avoid being bombarded with news reports that heighten emotions by filtering your newsfeeds or turning off notifications.

Try integrating mindfulness practice or relaxation strategies into your day by doing breathing exercises, walking in nature, or using other calming strategies that center and ground you when the world feels unbearably unjust.

Harnessing Your Power: Taking Action on Social Justice Issues

If managed correctly, a healthy dose of frustration and sadness regarding inequities can be useful. After all, the world needs individuals who are committed to making a positive difference in the lives of others—so long as it doesn't come at too great a personal cost.

Instead of succumbing to fury and despair, mobilize yourself to do something positive. Taking even small actions can help people feel more empowered and less despondent. Here are some suggestions:

- Feeling desperate about climate change? Take action to reduce your daily carbon footprint.
- Heartbroken about homelessness in your city? Offer to volunteer at a local shelter.
- Eager to strengthen local crime prevention? Contact your local law enforcement authorities and ask how you can help.

Marcy Caldwell, Psy.D., is a clinical psychologist and founder of Rittenhouse Psychological Services, specializing in adult ADHD, in Philadelphia.

How Dysregulated Emotions Hijack the Teen ADHD Brain

By Ellen Littman, Ph.D.

Adolescence is an unrelenting succession of highs and lows. The swings between euphoria and misery, jealousy and generosity, irritation and vulnerability come quick and hard—and often. For teens with ADHD and its relatively common partner, emotional dysregulation, these swings can hit like a wrecking ball.

Emotional dysregulation smacks into all parts of teen life—from friendships and romantic relationships to school performance and even social media use. The latter is particularly troubling (and increasingly unavoidable), especially following reports linking Instagram use to poor mental health outcomes for teen girls, who cited body image problems and even suicidal thoughts in a 2021 research study, according to *The Wall Street Journal*.

Though a powerful medium for connection, social media use may have a real, negative impact on teen mental health, as ongoing reports continue to show. Cyberbullying, exposure to extremism, and manipulation (sexual and financial) are risks inherent in online use, as is addiction that stems from an over-reliance on online relationships. Emotionally dysregulated teens—already more sensitive to peer rejection and acceptance than are neurotypical peers—may be particularly vulnerable to these risks and effects of social media use.

The first step to protecting teens from online relationship risks is to understand how ADHD and emotional dysregulation impact their relationships—IRL and on their phones—and arm them with healthy strategies for managing their very big feelings.

Understanding Emotional Changes in Adolescence

The preteen and teen years mark a period of significant, overwhelming change.

- Hormonal changes contribute to mood fluctuations and increased emotionality. During puberty, monthly drops in estrogen levels exacerbate ADHD symptoms in girls.
- Bodily changes and sexual development may be sources of embarrassment and confusion.
- Increased academic demands, often accompanied by decreased parental scaffolding, cause stress.
- A desire for independence, questions around identity, and an expanding social life (and desperation for sensitivity to peer acceptance) all characterize adolescence.

Teens with ADHD struggle to navigate through all of the above, plus the emotional dysregulation associated with the condition.

The Neurobiology of ADHD Emotional Dysregulation

In neurotypical brains, the limbic system—responsible for emotional and behavioral responses—works with the prefrontal cortex (PFC)—linked to cognitive control and emotional response modulation—to maintain emotional equilibrium, which allows for goal-directed behavior.

But in ADHD brains, these regions and processes essentially compete for dominance. We want the PFC to win as much as possible, but the limbic system often overpowers it. The result is emotional dysregulation.

Signs of Emotional Dysregulation

In teens with ADHD, emotional dysregulation can manifest in the following ways:

- Emotional impulsivity
- Low frustration tolerance; avoidance of difficult situations
- Irritability; quickness to anger
- Difficulty balancing positive and negative emotions
- Increased emotional excitability and speed of escalation; delayed return to baseline
- Difficulty inhibiting responses, especially negative emotions; outbursts
- Defensiveness
- Verbal and physical aggression
- Emotional volatility
- Swearing
- Socially inappropriate, embarrassing behaviors

Emotional dysregulation may be prolonged in ADHD brains due to delayed maturation; it is estimated that children and adolescents with ADHD trail behind their neurotypical peers by a few years. Compared to neurotypical teens, those with ADHD may lack executive function skills essential for emotional regulation.

What's more, hormonal changes fuel emotional dysregulation and influence ADHD's presentation. The combination may be severe enough to be mistaken for bipolar disorder, reactive attachment disorder, or borderline personality disorder.

Consequences of Emotional Dysregulation in Teens with ADHD

Emotional dysregulation has far-reaching consequences. It is connected to increased risk for the following:

- Explosive peer and family relationships
- Risky sexual behaviors
- Self-harm and substance abuse
- Peer rejection and sensitivity to it
- Internalizing problems, including depression, anxiety, shame, and rejection sensitivity.

Emotional dysregulation can play a destabilizing role as teens explore romantic relationships and physical intimacy. The patterns that teens develop in these early relationships often persist into adulthood. Since teens with ADHD are at risk for adverse relationship outcomes later in life, it is important to identify and address unhealthy habits and patterns early on.

Teens with ADHD tend to have more romantic partners and shorter relationships than do teens without ADHD. They date and have intercourse earlier, engage in more casual sex, and report having more unprotected sex than do their non-ADHD peers.

Compared to neurotypical peers, teens with ADHD are also more likely to develop a negative conflict resolution style, which appears to stem from emotional dysregulation. In a relationship, a teen who struggles to inhibit their responses might withdraw as a coping mechanism. They may also “comply” with what they think their partner emotionally expects of them. This game of hide-and-pretend can only go on for so long before inhibition fails and issues are addressed in antagonistic ways.

It’s understandable that teens with greater emotional dysregulation are more likely to rate their relationships poorly compared to peers with less severe ADHD symptoms.

How to Support Emotionally Dysregulated Teens

- 1. Recognize and depersonalize expressions of emotional dysregulation.** Don’t take rude, disrespectful comments from your teen personally, no matter how hurtful. Remember that these are uncontrolled, emotional explosions. Depersonalize the comment, and you’ll find a struggling teen—not an attacking one.
- 2. Monitor your teen’s social media and screen use.** There’s no absolute clarity on what constitutes social media addiction, but ask yourself the following questions:
 - To what extent does my teen use social media to feel better? Do they feel more included or more rejected afterward?

- How difficult is it for my teen to disengage from social media?
 - To what extent does my child's social media use interfere with academics, time with family and friends, and other responsibilities?
3. **It's your teen vs. their brain, not you vs. your teen.** Lead with this principle to limit frustration and misunderstandings. This approach will also help your teen understand that their dopamine-seeking and emotionally hyper-aroused brain won't always support their goals—be it emptying the dishwasher or doing homework—and that work-arounds are necessary.
 4. **Disengage when tensions run high.** Consider it impossible for your teen to calm down in the heat of the moment. Take the initiative to disengage and step away, but ask your teen to reconvene when things calm down.
 5. **Celebrate your child's abilities and passions,** e.g., art, sports, volunteer work, or niche knowledge of an obscure subject. Focusing on their strengths and masteries will help your child feel good about themselves.
 6. **Normalize your teen's struggles.** Teens don't want to feel different from their peers. Help your child recognize that everyone has challenges, and they are not alone. If your teen ignores you, direct them to reputable online sources and influencers who are informing the world on all things ADHD.
 7. **Don't despair.** Remember that your child is socially and emotionally behind their peers. Things will come together in due time. As you wait it out, don't fall into the “this is never going to get better” trap. The part of the brain responsible for good judgment doesn't mature until the mid-20s. It is unproductive to expect consistent emotional control from your teen as these skills develop. Instead, have—and communicate—compassion for yourself and your child. You're on the same team.

Ellen Littman, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist licensed in New York.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “How Emotional Dysregulation & ADHD Transform Teen Relationships from Messes to Minefields,” with Ellen Littman, Ph.D.

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

Self-Test: Could You Have Emotional Hyperarousal?

By William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA

The physical hyperactivity so often associated with ADHD—jumping on the couch, barreling across the playground, or talking without a pause for 10 minutes straight—is far from universal. In fact, this external symptom occurs in only one-quarter of children and 5% of adults with the condition. The vast majority of people with ADHD instead experience hyperactivity as an internal feeling of *hyperarousal*—they can't turn off their whirling, overactive brains. This symptom often manifests as extreme emotions, a condition known as emotional hyperarousal.

People with emotional hyperarousal have passionate thoughts, reactions, and feelings that are more intense than those of the average person. Their highs are higher, and their lows are lower—which means people with ADHD often experience both happiness and criticism more powerfully than everyone else. This can make them appear overly sensitive and be off-putting to those around them, which can do deep, long-term damage to their self-esteem.

Take the self-test below to find out if you may have symptoms of emotional hyperarousal. Take the results to your doctor to discuss your symptoms and a treatment plan that can help.

This is not a diagnostic tool. If you have concerns about possible emotional hyperarousal, see a mental health professional. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation. This self-test is for personal use only.

1. Do you feel like you can't relax, even on weekends and vacations?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

2. When attempting to do something quiet and mindless, like watching TV with your family, do you find yourself getting up, fiddling with your phone, or doing anything other than focusing on the TV?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
3. Do you struggle to fall asleep because you can't get comfortable or stop thoughts that bounce from one concern and worry to another?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
4. Before being diagnosed with ADHD, were you told you might have a mood disorder, anxiety, bipolar disorder, or borderline personality disorder?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
5. Do you feel like you experience emotions differently—more intensely, more suddenly, more unpredictably—than the people around you?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

6. Do you feel especially sensitive to rejection, teasing, criticism, or the perception that you have failed or fallen short?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
7. When you experience feelings of extreme happiness, anger, or sadness, do you feel like your emotions flare up out of nowhere—and then resolve themselves just as quickly?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
8. Do those around you complain that they can't understand your reactions or can't "keep up" with your ever-changing emotions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. Do you feel like you can't rid your brain of a certain thought or idea when you want to?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

10. Do you feel (or have you been told directly) that your intense emotions make you “weird” or “different”?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

11. Do you experience low self-esteem due to your hyperactive emotions?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

12. Do you feel like you’re thinking about five things at once?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

13. Do you not see your mood shifts coming and get “blindsided” by your own emotions?

- ☐ Very Often
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Never

CHAPTER 1: WHY STRONG EMOTIONS FLOOD ADHD BRAINS

14. Are you unaware of how physically active you are (bouncing your leg, fidgeting, drumming your fingers, etc.)?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
15. Do you have meltdowns or blow-ups, or have to be “talked off the ledge,” when you are overwhelmed by your emotional responses? Do others “walk on eggshells” around you?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
16. Have your strong and uncontrolled mood shifts damaged personal relationships or career prospects?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
17. As an adult, do you feel like a child who is “faking” being a real adult due to your uncontrolled emotions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total (out of 68), the greater the likelihood of showing signs of emotional hyperarousal.

Note: *This screener is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms like those of emotional hyperarousal. A high score does not necessarily mean you have emotional hyperarousal. A score of 54-68, means you answered “Often” or “Very Often” to most of the questions and should see a trained health care professional as there is a possibility that you are experiencing symptoms of emotional hyperarousal. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.*

“Emotional Numbness and the Spectrum of ADHD Feelings”

By Stacey Turis, an author and ADDitude contributor

Whenever I exceed my emotional limits, my ADHD brain is forced to reboot. I can't process many strong emotions for too long. I retreat and, mentally, log out. It isn't just negative emotion that leads me here.

Positive emotions can also burn me out because I'm a sensitive person. I try to ride the center line of my feelings and not get pulled too high or too low. But sometimes I do.

The beauty of logging out is that I get a respite from feeling things intensely. I used to think something was wrong with me, but I realized that it isn't a character flaw or that I'm cold-hearted. It's my brain's way of protecting me from too much stimuli and stress flowing through my body—the challenge most people with ADHD face.

In general, I find myself in one of three phases, and each requires a different to-do manual. Sometimes, I experience emotional numbness, unable to get even a glimpse of what it means to feel happy or sad. Other times, I'm so fully engaged with my emotions, that I can taste the colors of my feelings. Most of the time I'm observing my emotions as they float through me in their own version of a thought bubble.

ADHD Brain in Complete Emotional Numbness

In this phase, I don't feel emotions at all. There is no sadness, there is no happiness, there is no attraction, there is no aversion. I don't have a connection to things around me, and if something catastrophic happens, I doubt I'd be able to find some tears.

As an empath, and someone who is highly tuned into what I'm feeling—as well as the feelings of everyone else in the room—my numb state is sometimes welcome, sometimes uncomfortable. Where normally my gut gives me boatloads of information, in this state it is an empty box, with small gusts of wind blowing some trash in the corner.

I used to think I was a serial killer in the making—or at least a terrible person—when I went into this numb state. I've come to realize that's not true; I'm not bad at all as far as people go. Instead of looking at this state as something my brain is “doing” to me, I now know it's something my brain is trying to tell me. More often than not, it's saying one of two things.

Brain: “I told you to slow down! I'm going to have to terminate all emotions until you get yourself back together. For three weeks, you shall be called Spock.”

or

Brain: “Dude. Your neurotransmitters are out of whack. I'll make you uncomfortably numb until you seek out stimulation to get your juices flowing again.”

ADHD Brain Fully Engaged

As a seeker of everything that means something, this is my favorite phase. It's the most intense emotional state, and I fall into it less frequently than the others. Whether I'm insanely happy, or desperately sad, I'm feeling something and that means everything to me. I'll roll around in the emotions, soaking them up and breathing them in. I know it's a passing fancy, but I fully appreciate the act of feeling and being alive.

Passion is my best friend here. You just don't know if she's going to show up ready to ravage someone with a wild lovemaking session or throw a table lamp in his direction.

Brain: "Go ahead and do a *Flashdance* chair routine."

I ignore my brain when I'm in this phase because neither of us knows what's going on. At this point, I think my brain has given me free rein to the heart, kind of like hoping the spaghetti sticks to the wall, and we all come back in one piece when it's over.

ADHD Brain as Casual Observer

This is where I usually hang my hat. I consider the ability to just observe emotions a gift for people with ADHD because it's a resting place between the two extremes. I have some freedom as a casual observer because I don't get caught up in being attached to emotions, but I do get to watch my own stuff being played out. It's like I'm watching it on a screen: I see it happening and feel it happening, but instead of grabbing onto it and holding on for dear life, I observe it and learn from it. I look at emotions as something curious that should be investigated and appreciated but not held hostage. Things, feelings, and people can change from one second to another. If you don't let go, you're holding on to yesterday's news.

Brain: "Whoa! That was some serious jealousy that just spiked through our body. Where in fresh hell did that come from?"

By recognizing the emotion, you're breaking the speed at which it comes at you. You're taking away some of its power without rejecting it; rejecting it is the quickest way to be overcome by it.

We will always have emotions, and we will all handle them in our own way. We can accept them and co-exist peacefully, or we can fight them and feel out of control. It's the same amount of work, but the outcome is the difference between authentic living and simply existing.

“ADHD, Women, and the Danger of Emotional Withdrawal”

By Elizabeth Broadbent, blogger and ADDitude contributor

My husband keeps talking, but I am not listening. I am turning away from him. He has said or done something completely innocent on his end—commented about the need to do the laundry, said he was too tired for sex, teased me gently for a crush on some movie star—and I am finished. You see, my ADHD and emotional withdrawal stems from my rejection sensitivity, which can lead me to (mis)interpret things as a referendum on my (now-perceived) general horribleness as a human being.

The stew of guilt and anger, shame and misery can be totally overpowering. So, I turn away. I curl into myself, cut myself off emotionally. I know it's not a healthy coping mechanism. But at times, it's the only one I manage.

Emotional Withdrawal Is a Learned Behavior

Girls with ADHD often learn emotional withdrawal at a young age: for women, ADHD and emotional withdrawal often come hand-in-hand.

We can be slow to pick up on the social cues other girls learn with ease. We're daydreamy and spacey, rarely anchored in the here and now (probably because the here and now means forgotten papers, missed deadlines, and people demanding why we didn't do better). Our disorganization can make us a social pariah as other students distance themselves from the “bad” kid. We often blurt out impulsively at inappropriate times, which can, as others have pointed out, attract the attention of a bully.

As if social ostracism from the “mean girls” weren't enough, girls with ADHD often find themselves being actively bullied. Back in the grand old '80s and '90s, no one did much about it other than tell us to suck it up. If it were a boy doing the bullying, some authority figures might have said, “Oh, he's just doing it because he likes you.” (Setting the stage for us to conflate abuse with healthy relationships later in life.)

Often, we were our only ally. Our teachers and parents might have dismissed our complaints as tattling or brushed them off—like mine did—with something like, “If you learned to act like everyone else, this wouldn't happen to you.” We learned to blame ourselves for our own ostracism; we weren't worthy of membership in the social groups, or the popularity other students enjoyed.

So, we cut ourselves off. We learned not to care because caring hurt too much. When the teasing started, when the bullying began (again), when spitballs flew, we retreated inward. It was the only coping mechanism we had.

We Carry the Emotional Baggage of ADHD Into Adulthood

Emotional withdrawal involves bottling up your emotions. It involves cutting out

the people who could help us because we're so used to rejection that we've learned to anticipate it. Because we've learned to disconnect from others, we develop other unhealthy coping mechanisms.

Studies show what we're up against, too. Teenage girls with ADHD are more likely to struggle with social, attentional, and organizational difficulties; have poorer self-concepts; experience more psychological distress and impairment; and feel less in control of their lives. Women with ADHD are also at greater risk—by 2.5 times—for extreme sadness compared to women without ADHD.

These are pretty dismal circumstances. And many of them stem from our need to “stuff” our emotions—or shut down how we feel to cope with the world around us. We've learned to anticipate constant attacks, so we've developed unhealthy coping mechanisms—some of them blooming into full-blown psychiatric disorders—in order to function in a neurotypical world. We're always afraid of placing a foot wrong, missing a social cue, forgetting an important deadline. And all the planners in the world can't help us.

This Is Why Women with ADHD Withdraw

We pull away. We especially pull away, most dangerously, from those we love because they are the most likely to cut us the deepest. Some studies have suggested that the rate of divorce in couples where one or more partners have ADHD is twice the rate of the general population. Part of this may be due to the complications stemming from ADHD and sex, inattentive behaviors, “chore wars,” and time-management failures. But as one woman says, “I've thought about leaving many times because I can't take the criticism... He thinks he is helping me to be a better person” when he notes her ADHD-related shortcomings, but she mostly ends up feeling “unloved.”

How Can We Address Emotional Withdrawal Positively?

- 1. First, recognize that you withdraw from people and situations as a coping mechanism.** This can be difficult to admit since it's the only way you've coped for so long. But recognition is the first step. Learn to say, when you turn away from your spouse or friends, “I am turning away and curling up in this situation. I am shutting down.” That takes a lot of serious work. It means you have to step outside your emotional responses and realize, first, the what of the thing that's going on. If you simply succeed in saying to yourself, “I am emotionally withdrawing right now,” that's a great first step in the right direction.
- 2. Take the (admittedly scary) step of verbalizing what's happening.** It helps to memorize a script to go along with it. This can be something simple: “I have ADHD. I learned to withdraw as a coping mechanism. When you did x, it made me feel like I have to withdraw to protect myself.” This doesn't mean that you do or don't have to withdraw. It means that you are letting your partner

(likely your spouse) know what's happening. They won't feel as if they are to blame, because you've grounded it in your own learned behavior, and you can hopefully work on some reassurance and help together.

- 3. Next, sit down and make a list.** Instead of withdrawing, what would you rather have happened? Maybe you'd rather have validation that your feelings matter. Maybe you'd rather have verbal assurance that you are loved just the way you are. Maybe you would like a hug. If you recoil from that, or if you're not ready for it, maybe you'd like to have your hand held instead. Brainstorm a whole list of behaviors on the part of your partner that could help you feel more safe and then share it with them. Don't place blame; instead, offer constructive advice on how to help you with emotional disassociation.

Pursue Professional Help

Are you in therapy right now? You should be. We've seen that women who "stuff" their feelings, who suffer from painfully inappropriate emotional responses, can spiral into a whole host of negative outcomes.

A good cognitive behavioral therapist can help you come up with more coping mechanisms to help you deal with your feelings. You'll learn to change your irrational thought patterns—in this case, the idea that offhand remarks or input from other people negate your self-worth—to more positive ones, and to cope when the negative thoughts arrive: to deal with them, not brood on them or stuff them.

There are many ways to find a good therapist. You can use *ADDitude's* guidelines on what to look for in a good therapist or doctor, and whether you should see an ADHD coach or a therapist. Someone who offers CBT (cognitive behavioral therapy) or DBT (dialectical behavioral therapy, a kind of CBT), along with a specialty in ADHD, is preferable.

Emotional withdrawal can hurt your relationships, destabilize your marriage, and, through unhealthy coping mechanisms, sabotage your life. But you can release yourself from its grasp. It can take time, therapy, and help to get through it. It's important to have a strong support network in place (including, if possible, an understanding spouse), and a good therapist.

But most of all, you need a strong commitment to change. Without that, you'll be stuck in your old rut of withdrawal: and that doesn't help anyone, least of all yourself.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.; Elizabeth Broadbent; Alan P. Brown; Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.; Marcy Caldwell, Psy.D.; William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA; Peter Jaksa, Ph.D.; Alison Kravit, Psy.D., AAC; Ellen Littman, Ph.D.; Marydee Sklar; and Stacey Turis.

CHAPTER 2

Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria: A Hallmark ADHD Symptom

Chapter 2: Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria: A Hallmark ADHD Symptom

How ADHD Ignites Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

By William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA

What Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD) is extreme emotional sensitivity and pain triggered by the perception that a person has been rejected or criticized by important people in their life. It may also be triggered by a sense of falling short—failing to meet their own high standards or others' expectations.

Dysphoria is the Greek word meaning unbearable; its use emphasizes the severe physical and emotional pain suffered by people with RSD when they encounter real or perceived rejection, criticism, or teasing. The emotional intensity of RSD is described by my patients as a wound. The response is well beyond all proportion to the nature of the event that triggered it.

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is not a formal diagnosis, but rather one of the most common and disruptive manifestations of emotional dysregulation—a common but under-researched and oft-misunderstood symptom of ADHD, particularly in adults. RSD is a brain-based symptom that is likely an innate feature of ADHD.

Early childhood trauma makes anything worse, but it does not cause RSD. Often, patients are comforted just to know there is a name for this feeling. It makes a difference knowing what it is, that they are not alone, and that almost 100% of people with ADHD experience rejection sensitivity. After hearing this diagnosis, they're relieved to know it's not their fault and that they are not damaged.

When this emotional response is internalized, it can imitate a full, major mood disorder complete with suicidal ideation. The sudden change from feeling perfectly fine to feeling intensely sad that results from RSD is often misdiagnosed as rapid cycling mood disorder.

It can take a long time for physicians to recognize that these symptoms are caused by the sudden emotional changes associated with ADHD and rejection sensitivity, while all other aspects of relating to others seem typical.

When this emotional response is externalized, it looks like an impressive, instantaneous rage at the person or situation responsible for causing the pain.

RSD can make adults with ADHD anticipate rejection—even when it is anything but certain. This can make them vigilant about avoiding it, which can be misdiagnosed as social phobia. Social phobia is an intense anticipatory fear that you will embarrass or humiliate yourself in public, or that you will be scrutinized harshly by the outside world.

Rejection sensitivity is hard to tease apart. Often, people can't find the words to describe its pain. They say it's intense, awful, terrible, overwhelming. It is always triggered by the perceived or real loss of approval, love, or respect.

One-third of my adult patients report that RSD was the most impairing aspect of their personal experience of ADHD, in part because they never found any effective ways to manage or cope with the pain.

People with ADHD cope with this huge emotional elephant in two main ways, which are not mutually exclusive.

- 1. They become people pleasers.** They scan every person they meet to figure out what that person admires and praises. Then they present that false self to others. Often this becomes such a dominating goal that they forget what they actually wanted from their own lives. They are too busy making sure other people aren't displeased with them.
- 2. They stop trying.** If there is the slightest possibility that a person might try something new and fail or fall short in front of anyone else, it becomes too painful or too risky to make the effort. These bright, capable people avoid any anxiety-provoking activities and end up giving up things like dating, applying for jobs, or speaking up in public (both socially and professionally).

Some people use the pain of RSD to find adaptations and overachieve. They constantly work to be the best at what they do and strive for idealized perfection. Sometimes they are driven to be above reproach. They lead admirable lives, but at what cost?

What Triggers Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria?

Sometimes called hysteroid dysphoria in Europe, RSD is characterized by intense mood shifts triggered by a distinct episode, typically one of the following:

- rejection (the real or perceived withdrawal of love, approval, or respect)
- teasing
- criticism, no matter how constructive
- persistent self-criticism or negative self-talk prompted by a real or perceived failure

No one likes to be rejected, criticized, or seen as a failure. It is unpleasant, so people avoid those situations if they can. RSD is distinguished by its extreme, unbearable intensity, which sets it apart from normal emotional responses familiar to neurotypical people.

This intense pain is often experienced as a physical “wound”; the patient feels as if they were stabbed or punched in the chest. Commonly, people will hunch over, grimace, and clutch their chests when they describe their RSD experience.

Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria a New Concept?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria and emotional dysregulation are old concepts associated with ADHD that are gaining new exposure in research and clinical settings. Paul Wender, M.D., who spent four decades conducting the pioneering studies on ADHD beginning in the 1960s, was the first to recognize emotional dysregulation as a persistent, prevalent, and highly impairing component of what we now call ADHD.

The most recent contribution to this new thinking about the mood regulation component of ADHD came from Fred Reimherr, M.D., one of the founding fathers of ADHD who established the current childhood criteria for ADHD along with Dr. Wender more than 50 years ago. (The original criteria for what we now call ADHD were originally called the Wender-Reimherr Criteria.) His replication of his study (published in the *Journal of Clinical Psychiatry*), of the validity of each diagnostic criterion has led him to conceptualize ADHD into two subtypes: the well-known inattentive type and an emotional dysregulation type.

This was a huge change in thinking. A feature of ADHD that was ignored for 50 years now is rapidly becoming one of the defining features of the syndrome in both the European Union and North America.

In 2019, Stephen Faraone, Ph.D., published “Emotional dysregulation in Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder—Implications for Clinical Recognition and Interventions” in the

Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry. It states that there is “solid theoretical rationale” for emotional impulsivity and deficient emotional self-regulation “as core symptoms of ADHD.” In other words, the moods of ADHD and RSD are normal in every way except their intensity.

How RSD Differs from a Mood Disorder

MOOD DISORDER	RSD AND ADHD
Mood changes are untriggered; out of the blue	Mood changes always have a clear trigger
Moods are independent of what’s going on in the person’s life	Moods match the perception of the triggers
Mood shift is gradual over weeks	Mood shift is instantaneous
Offset of mood episodes is gradual over a period of weeks to months	Episodes end quickly in a matter of hours
Duration of episode must be > two weeks	Episodes rarely last more than a couple of hours

Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria a Symptom of ADHD?

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is not included in the *DSM-5* for ADHD; it is not a formal symptom of ADHD in the United States, however emotional dysregulation is one of the six fundamental features used to diagnose ADHD in the European Union.

It’s widely understood that the diagnostic criteria for ADHD in the *DSM-5* only fit well with elementary school-age children (6-12) and have never been validated in a group of people over the age of 16. They are based on only observational or behavioral criteria that can be seen and counted. The traditional diagnostic criteria intentionally avoid symptoms associated with emotion, thinking styles, relationships, sleeping, etc., because these features are hard to quantify. For clinicians who work with later adolescents and adults, the *DSM-5* criteria are almost useless because they ignore so much which is vital to understanding how people with an ADHD nervous system experience their lives.

When people started writing about and researching the concepts of RSD and emotional dysregulation years ago, this new awareness of the emotional component of ADHD was enthusiastically accepted by patients and their families because they matched their life experiences so exactly. The reception from clinicians and many researchers, however, was decidedly cool. Many professionals did not fully grasp that the emotional compo-

nent of ADHD had always been there but intentionally not pursued. It appeared to them that the concept had no real and historical basis. What's more, there was very little published research and most studies came from the European Union, which used the term emotional dysregulation (ED), not RSD.

These obstacles to recognizing RSD/ED as a major and defining characteristic of adult ADHD and to using medications to offer some relief from the disruptions and pain of this feature of ADHD are being addressed. There has been a rapid increase in available research in a very short period. The redefinition of adult ADHD in the EU—adding emotional self-regulation as a fundamental part of the criteria for diagnosing ADHD—has further assured that RSD/ED is really “a thing” that cannot be ignored any longer.

Although the EU has chosen the more inclusive term of emotional dysregulation (ED) instead of RSD, the concepts are fundamentally the same. Emotional dysregulation is described as:

“The type of emotional dysregulation seen in ADHD has been characterized as deficient self-regulation of emotional symptoms such as irritability, frustration and anger and low frustration tolerance, temper outbursts, emotional impulsivity, and mood lability. Emotional dysregulation in ADHD is different from episodic symptoms such as marked sustained irritability occurring within the context of altered mood states, such as an episode of extreme sadness or mania. In ADHD, emotional symptoms tend to reflect short-lived exaggerated changes, often in response to daily events, with rapid return to baseline within a few hours.”

How Is Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria Treated?

Psychotherapy does not particularly help patients with RSD because the emotions hit suddenly and completely overwhelm the mind and senses. It takes a while for someone with RSD to get back on their feet after an episode.

There are two possible medication solutions for RSD. The simplest solution is to prescribe an alpha agonist like guanfacine or clonidine. These were originally designed as blood pressure medication, but they seem to work equally well for different groups of people. If the first medication does not work, it should be stopped, and the other one tried. They should not be used simultaneously, just one or the other.

Although the alpha agonist medications, guanfacine, and clonidine, have been FDA-approved for the treatment of ADHD for decades, they were not directly associated with the terms of rejection sensitivity and emotional dysregulation. Nonetheless, it has been my clinical experience and the experience of others that the symptoms of RSD/ED can be significantly relieved with clonidine and guanfacine in about 60% of adolescents and adults. When that happens, the change is life-altering. Sometimes this treatment can

make an even greater impact than a stimulant does to treat ADHD, although the stimulant can be just as effective for some people. This observation strongly indicates that RSD is neurological and not due to a lack of skills. Skills do not come in pill form.

However, there currently exists no formal research on using alpha agonist medications to treat symptoms of RSD or ED in patients with ADHD.

The second treatment is prescribing monoamine oxidase inhibitors (MAOI) off-label. This has traditionally been the treatment of choice for RSD among experienced clinicians. It can be dramatically effective for both the attention/impulsivity component of ADHD and the emotional component. Parnate (tranylcypromine) often works best, with the fewest side effects. Common side effects are low blood pressure, agitation, sedation, and confusion.

MAOIs were found to be as effective for ADHD as methylphenidate in one head-to-head trial conducted in the 1960s. They also produce very few side effects with true once-a-day dosing, are not a controlled substance (no abuse potential), come in inexpensive, high-quality generic versions, and are FDA-approved for both mood and anxiety disorders. The disadvantage is that patients must avoid foods that are aged instead of cooked, as well as first-line ADHD stimulant medications, all antidepressant medications, OTC cold, sinus, and hay fever medications, and OTC cough remedies. Some forms of anesthesia can't be administered.

If a patient does not benefit from medication, they have little control over an episode of RSD once it begins. The incidents have to run their course. Some people with ADHD, however, report that getting interested in something new and fascinating can help to end an RSD episode more quickly than it would otherwise.

In my clinical experience, neither coaching nor traditional psychological or behavioral therapies—like CBT or DBT—offer any prevention or relief from impairments. Nonetheless, many people report that it is very helpful for them to know that this highly disruptive experience is real, common, and shared by other people with ADHD.

William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, is a clinician, writer, speaker, and consultant on ADHD medicine.

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

How Does RSD Really, Actually Feel?

Stabbing knives, white-hot rage, and debilitating fear are all descriptions used by *ADDitude* readers to convey the unseen and often unappreciated power of RSD.

In a survey, *ADDitude* asked adults with ADHD to describe how RSD feels and impacts their lives.

“Some rejection hits like a physical punch. The air leaves my lungs because of the hurt. Other times I feel this all-consuming humiliation. Or a fierce frustration and anger at myself. If I’m blindsided, I feel like a sad, confused little girl, thunderstruck in my bewilderment. I’ve even lashed out like an injured animal, cornered by the pain, and wanting to dish it back out. **These varied reactions can be accompanied by tension headaches, instant fatigue, nausea, and tightness in my throat or chest.** Sometimes I can shake it off, while other times the funk it puts me into can leak into the next day or even week.”

“Anytime someone criticizes an interest of mine, **it feels like a dagger ripping through me**, especially if the critique comes from someone I care about. Their rejection can pretty much shatter my interest and leave me feeling empty.”

“My partner and I both suffer from RSD, and any difference in opinion is a potential pit of despair. My hyperactivity makes it incredibly painful to be patient with his inattentive symptoms. **His silence and emotionless demeanor feel like knives.** Medication helps, but clear boundaries and humility help the most.”

“When I feel I am being criticized, especially by my husband, **I get very angry—I see red.** Now that I know why this happens and we have a name for it, it’s a lot easier for us to know how to handle it together. He now appreciates that I don’t have the ability to resolve it at the moment and leaves me alone for a bit to calm down.”

“If you close a door on me, if you reject me, if you dismiss my feelings, I can’t control my reaction. **It turns from frustration into white-hot rage** so quickly that I’m liable to throw or break something. It’s incredibly embarrassing as an adult, and I’m in therapy working on the anger.”

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

“RSD feels like constant failure, and then being criticized for feeling like a failure if I express any of my emotions.”

“Criticism usually triggers feelings of self-doubt and unworthiness. I immediately feel disconnected from the person who criticizes me.”

“The initial feeling is as if you’ve been punched in the head and are struggling to regain consciousness. You then deny that it is affecting you, but your brain goes blank, your body paralyzes, and, as if by the force of a volcanic eruption, you plunge into an abyss of infernal pain and fear. That is only the beginning. Nothing derails the power of RSD.”

“Due to many real and perceived rejections in my life from friends, family, and co-workers, I have become scared to start any new friendships or group activities. I no longer volunteer to do things at church as I struggle too much to remember to get the tasks done or to attend the meetings. My family helps me out by reminding me and forgiving me when I forget.”

“Any sidelong look or shared smirk between people in a group conversation feels like I’m being made fun of, and most corrective feedback feels like, ‘You are not good enough. This is how you have failed.’ I know intellectually that these worries are irrational, but the thought only occurs to me after I’ve already felt the emotional sting of perceived rejection. I feel like I’m walking on eggshells around new acquaintances because I’m constantly trying to figure out what they want.”

“I understand rationally that my partner is not rejecting me when he doesn’t want to come to the Sunday market with me, but my emotions get easily out of hand. I feel like he doesn’t want to spend time with me, that I don’t matter, that I’m stupid for asking, that I’m uninteresting and dull, etc. It’s exhausting.”

“It is humiliation, followed by self-berating, and I feel it as a nauseous anxiety in my stomach. I anticipate it all the time when I have to present ideas at work, and in social situations I tend not to express my thoughts or feelings.”

“It feels like my heart drops into my stomach, and I’m completely taken out of the moment.”

“When I am criticized for a simple mistake at work, I become extremely emotional and cry. It has been so humiliating that I have quit jobs.”

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

“Every single time feels **like the very first time you got rejected as a child.**”

“It’s a punch in the gut and **a kick to the head while you are writhing on the ground.** The parts of me that others miss? I take care of by beating myself up for leaving myself vulnerable to them in the first place.”

“I often misunderstand what people say and become defensive or angry. I feel like they are talking about me and laughing at me. **I butt in at inappropriate times and say something irrelevant that pops into my head because it feels urgent.** My relationships have been affected by my outbursts and perceived insults.”

“The slightest change of expression or hesitation **can feel like a slap in the face,** whether it is real or perceived. For years, if my husband tidied the house, I perceived it as criticism, even though I knew he was meticulous before we married. He has had to walk on eggshells to avoid the minefield of my easily hurt feelings. I struggle with people-pleasing and am constantly analyzing the behavior of co-workers and supervisors for signs of their judgment.”

“RSD feels like searing regret, shame, embarrassment, and failure. **At the slightest hint of disapproval, I crumble.** I feel so inferior, and I want to hide from the world—it’s safer that way.”

Rejection Sensitivity Is Worse for Girls and Women with ADHD

Much attention has been focused on RSD—and many women with ADHD identify with the experience.

Studies link rejection sensitivity to depression, anxiety, borderline personality disorder, body dysmorphic disorder, bipolar disorder, and autism. However, it appears to be most strongly associated with ADHD. Impaired executive functions and emotional dysregulation increase the tendency to personalize ambiguous social interactions, interpret them negatively, and be unable to regulate an emotional reaction to the interaction that prompted it.

“Rejection sensitivity is not a formal diagnosis or disorder, but many women report that the inability to control their reactions to rejection is one of the most undermining aspects of their ADHD,” says Ellen Littman, Ph.D., co-author of *Understanding Girls with ADHD*.

Dr. Littman has been involved in the field of attention disorders for more than 30 years and has seen some highly sensitive women experience perceived rejection in superficial interactions (e.g., “I had to ask our waiter for water twice—he doesn’t like me”). But, she says, the most devastating incidents involve rejection from those closest to them. “It can take hours to recover from a wounding interaction, and many women ruminate about the incident, sometimes waking in the middle of the night to relive it. Their quality of life is affected by anxiety, distress, shame, and avoidance,” Dr. Littman says.

ADHD Rejection Sensitivity and Gender

Society supports the idea of female obligation to accommodate others’ needs. Girls with ADHD feel this responsibility early but find they are poorly wired to be attuned to the feelings of others, explains Dr. Littman. “They are often bullied and ostracized by peers for being overly sensitive, easily confused, and missing social cues,” she says. “Many girls with ADHD behave in ways that others find frustrating and become targets for criticism. Their inability to conform to societal demands resonates with their learned expectation of rejection.”

Extreme stimulation causes the brain to adapt in extreme ways, even at the cost of compromising other functions. “Many women with ADHD have experienced chronic negative feedback in their childhoods, with countless episodes of harsh punishment, bullying, exclusion, and humiliation from family, peers, and teachers,” Dr. Littman says.

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

“The resilience of girls with ADHD is chipped away by early traumatic experiences that are unpredictable, inescapable, and repeated,” she continues. “These damaging messages can affect normal development and alter brain chemistry by increasing the release of adrenaline and cortisol. For many girls with ADHD, the repeated threat of rejection triggers primitive survival mechanisms; too vulnerable for fight or flight, they often freeze up, unable to act. These episodes set the stage for the expectation of future social adversity.”

Anxiety Is Amped Up in Women with ADHD

After decades of further rejection, women with ADHD feel like impostors, fearing that their perceived failures will be discovered and provoke more rejection, explains Dr. Littman. Well-documented gender differences describe these women as having less confidence, lower self-esteem, and more distress than men with ADHD or women without ADHD.

“It makes sense, then, that women with ADHD are primed to expect criticism, internalizing their anxious and fearful reactions to rejection,” Dr. Littman says. “Men are more likely to externalize their responses with defensiveness, anger, and projecting blame on others. Studies show that anxious reactions increase the likelihood of anxiety about future interactions. Those with angry responses experience decreased anxiety about future interactions.

“Many women interpret these rejections as a judgment of their value and are devastated by the idea that they continually disappoint others. Studies show that anticipatory anxiety creates a self-fulfilling prophecy in which fearful reactions elicit more negativity, reinforcing the sense of rejection. Their emotional volatility may be seen as a melodramatic over-reaction, further invalidating their pain. Some women believe that their behavior merits rejection, that they are, indeed, unworthy. If they feel they can do nothing right, despair can lead to substance abuse, eating disorders, self-harm, and suicidal thoughts.”

Avoiding Situations That Might Lead to Rejection

Dr. Littman says that most undiagnosed women gradually internalize decades of negative messages. With shattered self-esteem, they judge themselves harshly for their outbursts of rage, panic, or tears. Ashamed of their inability to control their impulsive responses, some focus on people-pleasing, flying under the radar, and censoring their opinions.

While catering to others, they justify, defend, and apologize for their reactions. Others go further, taking on a rigid, perfectionist facade to hide their volatility. “This defense demands

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

hypervigilant self-monitoring that comes at the cost of relentless anxiety and emotional exhaustion,” Dr. Littman says.

Ultimately, many women learn to avoid situations in which they anticipate rejection. “They conclude that withdrawal will protect them from the painful rejections that seem inescapable, and they develop social anxiety,” Dr. Littman says. “They find that hiding decreases their anxiety, and they accept distance and disconnection as a tolerable trade-off. Choosing isolation is a sacrifice no one should have to make. Women may feel protected, but it prevents them from being seen, heard, and known.”

The bottom line is that these powerful emotional reactions wreak havoc on relationships. Their intensity derails communication with partners who tire of de-escalation duty. Some women resort to radio silence with friends who judge them as overreacting. Many feel shame and despair at losing control and question their efficacy as a woman in the world.

Managing Rejection Sensitivity with ADHD

Dr. Littman explains that the tendency to experience rejection sensitivity is part nature and part nurture. In addition to the role genetics play, the physiology of rejection sensitivity is related to the neurobiology of emotional dysregulation.

The nurture component involves the traumatic history of early rejections, as well as the current environments reinforcing the negative messages. A therapist can help women understand their triggers and recognize high-risk situations. “Therapy helps women re-evaluate their beliefs about their self-worth and reframe the importance of the appraisals of others,” Dr. Littman says. “The knowledge that rejection sensitive dysphoria is a common experience, not the reflection of character flaws, is often the first step toward accepting support and pursuing treatment.”

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

Self-Test: Do I Have Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria?

Could RSD be the cause of your strong emotional responses? Take this self-test, adapted from the work and presentations of William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, and share the results with a mental health professional.

This screener is for personal use only and should not be used as a diagnostic tool. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.

1. Do you experience sudden, intense bouts of rage when your feelings are hurt?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

2. Do you experience sudden, intense bouts of extreme sadness when you think you have been rejected or criticized?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

3. Are you your own harshest critic?
 - ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

4. Do you feel anxious in social situations because you assume no one likes you?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
5. Do you consider yourself a “people pleaser,” going above and beyond to get on someone’s good side?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
6. Do you pass up opportunities or avoid starting projects because you fear you’ll fail?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
7. Have you been called “overly sensitive” or a “head case” because of your strong emotional reactions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

8. Do you dedicate more time than is necessary to a project or become perfectionistic to ensure your work has no mistakes (and is above reproach)?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
9. Do you ever experience your emotions as a physical sensation, as though you've been punched in the chest or physically "wounded"?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Seldom
 - ☐ Never
10. Do you feel shame about the "lack of control" you have over your emotions?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
11. Before you were diagnosed with ADHD, were you told you might have a mood disorder?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

12. Do you shy away from close friendships or romantic relationships because you worry that if people “know the real you,” they wouldn’t like you?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
13. Do you assume the worst in commonplace interactions—worrying you will be fired every time your boss calls you into her office, for instance?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
14. Do you think that you cannot go on feeling this way?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never
15. Do you avoid meeting new people or trying new things because your fear of rejection and criticism is so strong?
- ☐ Very Often
 - ☐ Often
 - ☐ Sometimes
 - ☐ Rarely
 - ☐ Never

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

Results: Assign the following values to your answers: Very Often (4 points), Often (3 points), Sometimes (2 points), Rarely (1 point), and Never (0 points). The higher your point total (out of 60), the likelihood of showing signs of rejection sensitive dysphoria.

Note: *This screener is designed to determine whether you demonstrate symptoms like those of rejection sensitive dysphoria. A high score does not necessarily mean you have RSD. If your score is 46-60, that means you answered “Often” or “Very Often” to most of the questions and should see a trained health care professional as there is a possibility that you may be experiencing symptoms of rejection sensitive dysphoria. An accurate diagnosis can only be made through clinical evaluation.*

Afraid of Failure? Try These Coping Skills

Rejection sensitive dysphoria is a byproduct of ADHD that can cause a paralyzing fear of failure. Here, learn how to build the emotional regulation skills needed to overcome self-doubt and try new things.

Some people living with ADHD and RSD shield themselves against failure by giving up unless quick success is guaranteed. If this sounds familiar, use these tips to help you counter a fear of failure:

- **Clarify priorities.** Base them on personal values, strengths, passions, and needs.
- **Shed the “shoulds”**—the expectations we have of ourselves or the self-talk we’ve adopted from our interpretation of other people’s expectations of us, which can limit ideas or rules we impose on ourselves. These “shoulda, coulda, woulda” thoughts may come from years of feedback we have internalized and experienced as intense criticism.
- **Commit to a decision.** Living with ADHD means a lot of time and energy is spent worrying about making the wrong decision and failing. Yet in most cases, just about any decision can be adapted into a useful and productive one.
- **Let go of trying to have it all.** The drive for what you perceive as successful can lead to a debilitating depletion of time, energy, and money, as well as failure.
- **Stop comparing yourself to others,** creating separation and isolation. Think instead about where you were 10 years ago and where you are now. Acknowledge your successes and how far you’ve come.
- **Visualize obstacles.** Walk through some possible ideas about how to overcome them.

Life is a journey and we’re happiest when we’re on it, not when it’s over. Relish every moment.

This article was written by Cheryl Susman, an educational therapist and certified ADHD coach.

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

When You're So Sensitive It Hurts

After a lifetime of judgment and blame, many adults with ADHD are understandably sensitive to criticism. It cuts deep and often provokes angry retorts we later regret. Here's how to respond more calmly and ignore what doesn't matter.

ADHD makes us more sensitive to criticism. Often, our first instinct is to respond defensively or angrily to outside comments that feel like disapproval. However, adults with ADHD should know that doing so could sacrifice learning opportunities and the respect of others.

Here is some advice to help you respond effectively to critiques and criticisms.

When Criticism Is Valid

Acknowledge and paraphrase. After receiving criticism, adults with ADHD should first acknowledge any truth in the statement. When you think the criticism may be justified, get on the same page with the other person by paraphrasing their comments.

Learn from it. If a “thank you” or explanation seems appropriate, address it briefly, and then move on. Adults with ADHD tend to dwell on the criticism—don't! Instead, focus on ways you can learn from it.

When Criticism Is Inaccurate

Agree with it—in part. When responding to an inaccurate criticism, it's often best for adults with ADHD to try “fogging”—agreeing with only part of the criticism rather than getting defensive or mad.

Example: If someone says you are undependable you can respond with, “Yes, I might be undependable at times.” Or agree with the principle behind the criticism, such as “You're right, being late is undependable.” This technique allows you to gracefully deflect the criticizer while also brushing off their implied judgments.

CHAPTER 2: REJECTION SENSITIVE DYSPHORIA: A HALLMARK ADHD SYMPTOM

Improve Your Response

Ask questions. Most criticism is vague. So try to clarify details before you react. Stay away from “why” questioning and use “how,” “what,” “where,” and “when” questions.

Example: If someone says that what you are doing annoys them, ask specifically how it is annoying and when it annoys them.

Practice. Oftentimes people with ADHD receive so much criticism that they begin to react angrily and aggressively when criticized. Other times, adults with ADHD may become passive to others’ actions toward them.

Keep in mind that practice makes perfect, and the first few attempts at responding in a new way may be awkward and not received as well as you had hoped. Hang in there and keep trying until you become comfortable and relaxed with your new responses.

Stand Your Ground—Gracefully

Here are three ways to help you to stand your ground without provoking anger or setting someone up to respond defensively.

- 1. Broken record response:** Calmly and slowly keep repeating in a monotone voice without particular emphasis on any one word or phrase, what it is you have to say until it is recognized and received appropriately by the other individual.
- 2. Emphatic escalation:** Calmly and slowly restate your response or request, with more assertion each time you do so, but without becoming aggressive. Always remember to be polite when asking for clarification and say “please.”
- 3. Sensitive listening:** First acknowledge the other person’s point of view respectfully and then make your point of view clear. Avoid using the word “but.” Restating the other person’s point of view, followed by a “but” negates what you just said. Instead, follow it with the word “and” to prevent the other person from becoming defensive or tuning you out.

This article was written by Sandy Maynard, M.S., who operates Catalytic Coaching in Boston and is an ADDitude contributor.

Expert Q&A with William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA

Q: “How can diagnosing clinicians differentiate between rejection sensitive dysphoria and the similar ups and downs of bipolar disorder?”

Bipolar disorder and ADHD share 14 features in common, so even a well-trained clinician could easily misdiagnose ADHD as bipolar, and vice versa, or miss the fact that both disorders are present. Two studies, the STAR*D program, and the STEP-BD program, found a tremendous overlap between the disorders; if you have bipolar disorder, you have a 40% chance of having ADHD as well. So, the question is: Could it be ADHD, bipolar disorder, or both?

Unlike ADHD, bipolar is a classic mood disorder with a life of its own separate from the events of a person's life, outside of the person's conscious will and control. Bipolar moods aren't necessarily triggered by something; they just come and stay. Usually, the onset is very gradual over a period of weeks to months. To meet the bipolar definition, the mood must be continuously present for at least two weeks and its offset or resolution must be gradual over a period of weeks to months.

With adult ADHD, you see a very different pattern; the moods of an individual with ADHD are clearly triggered. The ADHD symptom of RSD, for example, is triggered by the perception that a person has been rejected, teased, or criticized. An observer might not be able to point out the trigger, but the individual with ADHD can say, “When my mood shifts, I can always see a trigger. My mood matches my perception of the trigger.” In technical terms, ADHD moods are “congruent.”

Mood changes are instantaneous and intense in individuals with ADHD, much more so than in a neurotypical person.

ADHD moods rarely persist for more than a few hours. It is extremely rare for them to last two weeks. Typically, the mood can be altered by the person finding a new interest or occupation that captures their interest and distracts them from the intense emotion. Distinguishing between these mood presentations is how I separate out mood disorders of all types from ADHD.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “All the Feels: An ADHD Guide to Emotional Dysregulation and Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria (RSD),” with William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA.

Expert Q&A with Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Q: “I can’t handle rejection. Will I ever change?”

Many people with ADHD look at social situations through the filter of past experiences of rejection and exclusion, which further fuels rejection sensitivity.

In part, RSD is tied to fears of embarrassment or letting others down, and to concerns that mistakes will cause others to withdraw their love, support, or connection to you.

Many folks in your position try to discount their emotions in an attempt to overcome RSD (denial only makes them stronger though), or they avoid situations where any semblance of criticism could occur.

These strategies never work because you can never please everybody all of the time. Rejection, negative feedback, or judgments are inescapable parts of life. Instead of relying on avoidance or the negative expectancy that fuels anxiety, understand that your responses to rejection follow a pattern. Your goal is to create new patterns of responding, thinking, and behaving to reduce both the perceptions of rejection and the reactions when they actually occur.

Here are some tips for how to improve coping skills and manage the effect that rejection has on your ADHD brain.

1. **Remember the times you persevered despite discomfort.** If you are reading this, there’s great news. You’ve survived everything that life has thrown at you, including all the terrifying and uncomfortable moments. RSD threatens to erase those memories of triumph and tries to convince you that the pain of rejection is unsurpassable. Make it a habit to recall moments where you persisted in the face of fear. Write some of these down in your phone or journal so you can go back and remind yourself of your courage. Over time, the unbearableness of rejection will subside.
2. **Identify your strengths.** Focus as much as possible on what you love to do and what you do well. You are NOT the sum of broken parts. You are MUCH, MUCH more than that. Make a list of qualities or talents you like about yourself. Write these down as well. Then transform them into affirmations for those challenging moments. “I am brave; I am creative; I take risks; I keep trying.”
3. **Do a “happy and a crappy.”** Each day, name a few good (happy) and not-so-good (crappy) things that transpired. This practice will teach you to de-emphasize negative thoughts and shift your attention to what’s working.
4. **Be a “STAR.”** Stop, Think, Act, and Recover to manage big feelings, especially during unpleasant interactions. Pausing will also help you accurately gauge a situation instead of speaking out of turn or rushing to a conclusion.

5. Your sensitivity is a positive. Unfortunately, (and it looks like you’ve experienced this) many people are quick to negatively label and shame sensitive individuals, which does nothing to help RSD. What *does* help RSD is embracing sensitivity and the good that comes with it. Say, “I am sensitive, which means I feel things deeply and connect to people in special ways.” Wear sensitivity like a badge of honor.

As you form new patterns, they may feel strange or awkward. Practice self-compassion. We have all experienced (and will continue to experience) rejection and hurt in life. When things don’t go the way you hope, take time to regroup, and treat yourself like you would a child with a skinned knee—with care and kindness.

Q: “When my friends or classmates say that one of my favorite books or movies is bad, I feel like it’s a personal attack. When someone says something hurtful, I feel like I’ve messed up. I feel rejected when someone doesn’t value spending time with me. What can I do?”

When teens with ADHD struggle with RSD, it affects their relationships—and their self-esteem. Often, they don’t know how to cope with their intense emotions and, feeling overwhelmed, they may lash out at friends and/or family members.

One of my teen clients told me: “When I come home from school, sometimes I just can’t hold it all together. I yell at my mom and then I feel bad afterward, but I know that I can’t get kicked out of my family.” Other kids will withdraw quietly into their rooms and swallow their pain. As parents, there’s a fine line between supporting your adolescent in managing their big feelings and intervening to diminish their distress.

While some non-stimulant medications or antidepressants, such as SSRIs, can reduce sensitivity and overwhelm, the following behavioral tools can be very effective in quieting the inner critic, shifting perspectives, and developing self-confidence.

Identify limiting core beliefs. Remind them of situations that contradict those beliefs. Help them to recall times when they felt uncomfortable and did something anyway.

Challenge negative self-talk. Name and reinforce their strengths. Pay attention to what is going well. Give examples of their successes.

Help quiet their inner critic. Help them combat the negative messages they tell themselves by prompting them to create positive self-talk phrases. Practice these so they will be familiar and handy when they are needed most.

Sharon Saline, Psy.D., is a clinical psychologist and author of What Your ADHD Child Wishes You Knew: Working Together to Empower Kids for Success in School and Life and The ADHD Solution Deck.

“RSD Has Blessed Me with an Immense Capacity for Feeling—and I’m Grateful.”

By Taylor Maurand, freelance linguist, writer, and ADDitude contributor

The year 2020 didn’t deliver much good, but it did spark something incredibly important: My ADHD diagnosis—and my ability to (at long last) find peace with rejection sensitive dysphoria.

Maybe it sounds strange to label my diagnosis a good thing. But it is—because knowing that I have an ADHD brain explains so much about my life and my experiences that previously didn’t make sense. My diagnosis was like a blurry lens suddenly coming into focus.

It was a long, four-year journey from thinking I could have ADHD to finally getting an official diagnosis. Learning about RSD was actually one of the first dominos to fall.

I had spent nearly 40 years unknowingly masking and compensating for what I now know are ADHD symptoms. I felt I could continue to learn new strategies to work with time blindness, executive dysfunction, and other issues. But something was amiss—the emotional component was getting worse, not better, with age.

As I researched ADHD and intense emotions during those pre-diagnosis years, I learned that guanfacine and clonidine sometimes treat RSD symptoms in patients with ADHD. And as I learned about people’s experiences on these medications and how their emotional symptoms dissipated, I thought, *That’s what I want.*

The Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria Experience

For anyone who doesn’t experience RSD, let me try to describe it.

Let’s say I read something directed toward me that isn’t really a rejection or criticism but feels like it could be. Before I can even think, my guts immediately feel like they are in a giant blender. My veins feel like they are on fire. Then, my brain clicks into full panic mode, spinning scenarios about how the person on the other end of the message doesn’t like me. My brain then decides that no one, in fact, likes me.

Even if I know these thoughts are objectively false, I worry that they could be true. The episode comes on quickly, and it consumes my entire day. Efforts to “calm down” barely seem to make a dent.

It’s not that people with RSD want to feel this way. It very much feels out of our control, which is why it’s frustrating to hear advice like, “Everyone is in control of their feelings.” That’s just not true for those of us with RSD.

Besides, my reactions feel valid to me. They are an appropriate response to the situation, according to my brain at that moment.

I think of RSD and emotions like tsunamis versus regular waves. If you are neurotypi-

cal, the waves in your emotional sea could be calm, or choppy, or even harrowing. But, for the most part, you can ride out the waves, maybe even swim or play or surf on them.

With RSD, you have a fairly calm sea interrupted by frequent tsunamis. They come on suddenly, without warning, triggered by things you cannot control. And once you realize what's about to happen, you have two choices—get out of Dodge, or stay and risk drowning. Either way, you are displaced and left to deal with the destruction left behind. Plus, no one ever talks about controlling a tsunami.

Coming to Terms with Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

Despite all the problems inherent to RSD, it is not the worst thing in the world, even when I believe it is in the moment. Just as a force of nature can be powerful and destructive, RSD can also bring me to my knees in awe and wonder. It feels amazing and special to contain such enormous, intense feelings—and come out on the other side.

I've also realized that it's not me who feels most uncomfortable with RSD—it's those around me. For them, it would be easier if I could just make my feelings “smaller.” But I don't always have that option. Over the years, RSD has wreaked havoc on my relationships—friendships, family, and even professional connections. The memories and the losses are painful to think about.

Thankfully, guanfacine has been an absolute game-changer for my RSD. Nothing changed overnight, but slowly I noticed that situations and remarks that normally would have sent me over the edge were not doing so. I perceived them as neutral.

Don't get me wrong—I still feel the pain sometimes. It's just not as excruciating. Is this how “normal” people feel all the time? Who knew?! No wonder they were so confused by me before.

But also, how sad. How much of my life have I spent feeling physically ill and mentally anguished over situations that perhaps were not as threatening as they seemed? How many of us have endured “helpful” critiques about controlling feelings—that suggested our reactions were a personal failing—when we weren't failing at all? We were doing the best we could.

Now that I am starting to see RSD in the rearview mirror, I feel grateful that I have a little bit of extra mental space, the “spoons” to deal with the challenges in my life. But at the same time, I can look back and feel grateful for my RSD.

I was blessed with an immense capacity for feeling, and I love that. It has made me a stronger person, a more empathic person. Though the painful moments were plentiful, I can't deny that those powerful feelings probably steered me away from situations that did not benefit me in the long run.

Ultimately, I know that what might have appeared like a “weakness” to some was actually, all along, my greatest source of strength.

“Shame: The Devil on My Shoulder”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

“Stop being so sensitive,” everyone told me when I was younger. “If you stop crying, they’ll stop teasing you.”

I was the kid who couldn’t handle red marks on my homework, who melted down at any sign of criticism. I’d dissolve into tears. I’d sometimes stomp away. I’d curl up into myself and feel worthless, miserable, and guilty. The shame was overwhelming. It led to self-harm in my teens and early 20s. I could not cope with the normal slings and arrows of daily life. Everything bad was my fault.

My psychiatrists thought I was depressed and put me on an SSRI. It didn’t help much because I wasn’t depressed. Like so many women, I went through many diagnoses before my doctors finally hit on ADHD. I wasn’t manifesting depression or isolated anxiety issues. I was dealing with rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD).

RSD is a condition that the psychiatric community at large, and the ADHD community, is just beginning to understand. ADHD expert William Dodson, M.D., calls it “an extreme emotional sensitivity and emotional pain triggered by the perception—not necessarily the reality—that a person has been rejected, teased, or criticized by important people in his or her life. RSD can also be triggered by failing to meet [your own] or others’ high expectations.”

As women, we know about high expectations, the failure to meet them, and the emotional backlash when we fall short. Add an actual, diagnosable psychiatric condition to that response, and you have a recipe for some serious psychological damage. It started with teasing from my peers in childhood over my reactions to not getting an A on every single paper; along with forgetting my homework, or losing a book, or doing any number of things girls with ADHD do regularly—missing social cues, flubbing personal interactions, blurting things out. I berated myself, and it didn’t help that others berated me too. I played those criticisms as a soundtrack of self-loathing.

Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria: Extreme Sensitivity to Criticism

It’s no surprise that a childhood like that, combined with RSD, left me with a hair-trigger response to criticism. I’m in my 30s now, and RSD is still the devil on my shoulder, the voice in my head, the soundtrack to my life. It affects every relationship in my life, from my parenting to my marriage to my friendships. I once took a much-anticipated trip to meet work friends in another state. I had fun for four hours before a comment had me convinced that these women hated me, that they thought I was an idiot.

I spent the rest of the trip in near tears. It took me months to recover. I've since realized that all of this was in my head, and my friends were, as they professed to be, my friends. They liked me.

I often feel like a terrible parent. The normal things that parents do—lose their temper, say—seem life-altering to me. I feel that I'm destroying my children's lives. I may cry in apology in front of them. RSD means having to say you're sorry more than anyone on the planet.

Rejection Sensitivity: Impact on Marriage and Parenting

RSD has had a big impact on my marriage. I would encourage anyone who thinks they may be suffering from RSD to enter marriage counseling. It will help your spouse understand that when they ask you to take out the garbage, it may lead to an hour-long argument, complete with tears. Of course, you should have taken out the garbage long ago and why haven't you done it sooner and what's wrong with you, anyway? The person only said, "Could you please take out the trash?" They are baffled and upset that you're flying into accusations.

RSD can imitate a mood disorder, including rapidly cycling bipolar disorder complete with suicidal ideation. Guanfacine or clonidine helps some patients, Dr. Dodson says. MAOIs can also be effective, but they come with a list of don'ts, including ADHD meds. Talk with your doctor.

Many people with ADHD experience some form of RSD. In women, it usually turns inward. So, you're not the only one feeling that guilt, shame, and rejection. I understand. I am right there fighting them with you.

“Oversharing Is My Default Mode. So Is the RSD-Induced Shame I Feel Afterward.”

By Les Steed, an international freelance news journalist, writer, and ADDitude contributor

I overshare. I do it when I meet new people, when someone compliments me, or I find a shred of common ground.

I don't intentionally overshare; I just want to relate. So, I instinctively provide as much information as possible in the secret hope that they will interrupt me and say those magic words: “Me, too!”

Sometimes, my oversharing triggers drama. It can also make an overwhelming first impression, which isn't how you're meant to do introductions. This is not my intention or hope, and often I find that negativity and harm trace back to someone's misperceptions of my motives—or their feelings, personal history, and biases. We can blame poor communication sometimes, but I also find it tough to overcome a person's first impression or gut reaction to my ADHD way of being.

Complicating this is the idea that conversations are transactional; one must not interrupt because “it's rude.” So, when we become hypervertal, people assume we're all give and no take—and we're not interested in listening to what they say when we really are.

The Downside of Being Hypervertal

Sometimes, I get so hypervertal that I miss social cues and cross an invisible boundary. Then I inevitably and awkwardly back-pedal or correct myself, making everyone uncomfortable. Like many people with ADHD, I am good at masking my social struggles. (We've learned from a lifetime of harsh rebukes and emotionally devastating punishment.) Those scars are not visible; they hide behind my mask. At least until it comes up; then we're suddenly getting waaaaay too deep over a first coffee.

But after a few drinks or a long exhausting day, my mask slips—and I inevitably slip up. The emotional reaction to a slip, or unveiling, is more volatile due to rejection sensitive dysphoria. This is a dangerous cocktail—the absinthe martini of social situations—especially when I feel I have said something wrong, but I am not sure what. Almost simultaneously, my mask slips at the realization that I may have experienced a false sense of security throughout the conversation, and now I feel foolish and embarrassed.

RSD can cause people with ADHD to feel stronger emotions than most neurotypical people. Our emotional range makes us loyal, enduring, genuine, loving, fidgety, passionate, chatty, warm, kind, and beautiful. Our feelings are like a strong, firm arm pulling and pushing us with varying intensity throughout the day. The torsion and tension slowly ratchet until we need to explode. Compounded with background stress, this can lead to our outbursts (which we must tame, or else!), withdrawal, or visible agitation.

However, neurotypical people may not understand that RSD causes our meltdowns. We feel shame and frustration. (We overshared again!) Then we must explain why we are so hypervocal, which is challenging to do when we are deeply embarrassed. (Often, this makes us even more chatty.) By this time, we have damaged our reputations (or at least we think we have).

Why Oversharing Is Okay

ADHD emotions are like a cooking pot placed on a faulty burner that a junior cook is learning to use for the first time. How we feel that day and week can change at any time, just like the stovetop can heat up or cool down according to the whims and experiments of the chef and the dodgy hob. Meanwhile, the cooking pot (or person with ADHD) must adapt to temperature changes and look like it's effortlessly simmering along like the other neurotypical pots.

This takes a lot of energy, self-control, concentration, and self-awareness, especially when the other pots sit and watch, bemused but untouched, boiling their bland pasta. Our pot isn't suited to just boiling pasta, though. It's more like the giant, stainless-steel saucepan, creative, adaptive, and sometimes chaotic and unpredictable (sometimes it catches fire).

The ADHD saucepan melds a variety of meat, vegetables, liquids, herbs, spices, and random ingredients discovered along the way that we hope will make the sauce pop; often leaving the original recipe in its wake as the chef gets carried away from the whirlwind of creativity, passion, and fun.

The resulting sauce may be too spicy or acidic for some people, but rich and delectable for others. It's always unique, so it's a matter of personal taste.

So, when we overshare, we are not "being too much." We're just trying to figure out what the person wants from the sauce. We may be talking to a bland pasta person who wants nothing more than to be tossed with butter and generic pre-grated parmesan from a packet.

Ultimately, the sauce is what people remember about the dish—the delicious taste that lingers, the stain that gets on their shirts, and the aroma that permeates the air. The sauce may sometimes overwhelm the pasta with its boldness, but life would be so boring without it. After all, would anyone really want to eat pasta with butter and cheese forever?

“How Rejection Sensitivity Casts a Cloud Over My Marriage”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

I am staring at my husband. I am just staring, not blinking, narrow-eyed, mouth a straight line, standing across the room and fixing him with a look.

He tells me to stop. He says I am not accomplishing anything with this. He says I just need to accept that I yelled too much at the kids because I was stressed and that's okay, everyone does it sometimes. He is not gaslighting me—I admitted I did it and felt guilty and sad and awful and terrible about it. And I apologized to the kids. So, it's over and there's nothing else left to do but move on. But my ADHD comes with rejection sensitivity. And it can be a beast.

Stop staring, he says. Stop. Just stop. When you feel upset like that, just walk away.

I cannot stop. I know I am not accomplishing anything. I am so, so angry right now. I am livid. I am raging. It's one thing for me to say I feel sad and guilty. But it's a whole other issue for him to agree with me.

Because, by doing so, he is saying I am a bad parent.

He is saying I am a terrible parent who lost control.

He is saying I should not have kids.

He is saying, when he tells me to walk away, that it would be better if I were not around my children.

Of course, he is not actually saying any of these things.

But I hear them. I hear them as if he is shouting them at me. I feel them like a punch in the gut. This is what rejection sensitivity means. In my house, we all have ADHD. But I have a bad case of RS and my husband does not. In my case, it means that I have an extremely difficult time taking any type of criticism whatsoever.

A good marriage is built on honesty. That means, at times, gentle and constructive criticism from your spouse. I can't take it.

I Curl Inward

A lot of the time, when my husband offers up suggestions for family improvement—“Hey, maybe we should enroll the kids in some sports programs,” for example—I clam up. I don't initiate a discussion about the pros and cons of the idea, and I don't offer my input. I just curl inside myself.

There's a line from the poem “Fiddleheads,” by Maureen Seaton: “When you hurt me, I evolved like a backboned sea creature, translucent/ nervous system sparking along in the meanest deep where I was small enough not to care ...” I think of this every time I stop talking and cross my arms as if to hold myself inside and feel like

the worst person in the world for not thinking of this beforehand. I might feel like I am right, and he is wrong but I cannot offer up suggestions about the mundane like a rational person at that moment. I am too busy feeling rejected and alone.

I Lash Out

Sometimes, when my husband asks something as simple as, “Did you water your plants today?” which he doesn’t particularly care about and is just part of the background patter of marital conversation, I hear something else.

I hear *you are irresponsible*. I hear *you do not take care of your things*. And I feel the anger rising. I snap. “Of course, I did! I always water my garden! I take good care of it!” And he is left baffled. “What did I say?” he asks. “What’s wrong? Did you have a bad day? Are you okay?” And it might evolve into a fight. Which I pick, almost every time.

I Pick Fights—Because It Is Easier

Psychologically, we pick fights with those we love because we are hurting and angry at ourselves, and we want to stop that anger from clawing at our insides. If we can get mad at someone else, we can deflect our hurt and anger outward, and suddenly the hurt isn’t hurting so badly. Or at least, it hurts differently, in a way that doesn’t feel so damaging and broken.

We’re mad and disappointed in our spouse instead of ourselves. This can erode a relationship, especially an ADHD relationship. Luckily, my husband knows I do it, calls me on it, and walks out of the room. I have been known to both follow him and keep arguing (if the kids aren’t around) or dissolve into a puddle of tears (if they are). Then we can move into something constructive.

I Snark Out

Sometimes, when my husband makes a suggestion I don’t so much lash out as snark out. He might say something like, “Man, I need to do the dishes,” and I hear, “You should have done the dishes,” even though according to our household division of labor this is not my job and I never touch them. “Oh, I’ll try to fit that in between my bon-bon consumption and *Days of Our Lives* tomorrow,” I bite back, even though he knows I spend my days loving, feeding, homeschooling, policing, and cleaning up after three children.

Not a constructive way to deal with life, and something that leaves him stuttering for an answer. To me, he’s telling me I should have done the dishes for him and I’m lazy for not fitting them into my busy schedule. To him, it’s an offhand comment.

I Stomp Off

Sometimes, it all gets to be too much. Maybe there are too many little things I can interpret as criticism, so much so that I feel unwelcome in my own home. *I feel so attacked that I can’t function as a parent or spouse*, whether I’ve curled up inside myself or lashed

out. So, I stomp out the door to Target or Goodwill and go shopping—sometimes compulsively. I buy stuff we don't need, and I feel momentarily better about life. Except when I come home, my husband will ask what I bought, which I hear as an indictment, and which can start the cycle all over again if the shopping hasn't thoroughly calmed me down (it helps, I've found, to take a kid along for balance).

I Think My In-Laws Hate Me

Rejection sensitivity extends beyond my husband and into the rest of the family. I am utterly convinced my in-laws (excluding my father-in-law) hate me. Every comment, every request to re-organize the dishwasher I just loaded, any question about my homeschooling (no matter how innocent), any insinuation the kids should play in one room instead of another for fear they might break something priceless, is read by me as a comment on my inability to function as an adult with competent parenting skills. It sucks.

I know intellectually that they don't mean it. And they are truly nice people who do actually like me. But I fret and freeze and clam up and fake migraine headaches and sleep too much around them because I find their presence, at times, an excruciating march of rejection. This leaves my husband to run interference, to keep me calm, to cajole me into every single visit. It sucks. They are super nice and super sweet. But my RS prevents me from feeling it.

I Make My Spouse Deal with My Parents, Too

My RS is so severe that some days, I can't even talk to my own mother. For example, she moved to our town and needed help, because moving is stressful and busy and messy. I went over one afternoon to meet the plumber and, while I was there, broke down all her boxes and organized her linens. I instantly regretted it. She would hate it. She would hate me for it. I had so much internalized my RS that I anticipate it from those I love.

So, when she called that night, I made my husband answer the phone for fear she would berate me for doing everything wrong. My mother is not the berating type. Of course, she was wildly grateful (I still think she rearranged all her linens while cursing my name). The constant need to deal with not only his parents, but also mine, can wear on him. He always has to be the adult while I'm the scared kid.

I Spiral Into Despair

RS is often mistaken for any number of psychological disorders. But sometimes, when I feel rejected or criticized, I can't help falling into a spiral of despair and misery that can culminate in tears, panic attacks, and the need to take medication to calm myself down.

My poor husband has to play both comforter and psychiatric nurse to these episodes. It's not fun, it's not pretty, and it's not conducive to an equal partnership when one person might fall off the deep end at any moment.

I Suffer Suicidal Ideation

Sometimes, my RS gets so bad that I feel like the world would be better off without me. Let me be clear: I would never harm myself, because I cannot stand the thought of hurting my children. But that doesn't mean I don't think about it. That doesn't mean that sometimes I don't want to. And when that happens and I voice the thought, he goes into panic mode.

Is this bad enough to call the doctor? Does he need to take my pills away? Can I be left alone? He often has a panic attack himself at the thought of losing me. I'm feeling guilty and rejected and unloved and so terrible I think I don't deserve to live, and the person who loves me the most is scrambling to keep me safe. It's not healthy for either of us.

Basically, RS can strain a marriage to the breaking point. I'm lucky. I married a man who will stick by me through anything, who loves me deeply, and who was aware before our marriage that I had psychiatric issues, whatever labels psychiatrists have decided to slap on them over the years. He knew what he was getting into, and he's able to see the person behind the RS: The woman who loves him deeply and who acts out not because of malice, but because of despair and fear.

I don't go on an RS tear every day. Or even every other day. For long stretches, I hold it together, and I try my best to hear the words people are saying, rather than the words I hear. But sometimes, I can't help it. Sometimes, the words twist and turn like a knife in the back. Then I start to lose control. The RS takes over. The strain on my marriage begins. And I am lucky—damn lucky—to have married a man who can cope with it.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Elizabeth Broadbent; William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA; Taylor Maurand; Sandy Maynard, M.S.; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; Les Steed; and Cheryl Susman.

CHAPTER 3

Emotional Dysregulation & the ADHD-Anger Connection

Chapter 3: Emotional Dysregulation & the ADHD-Anger Connection

New Insights Into Emotional Dysregulation and Treatment Considerations

By Joel Nigg, Ph.D.

Anger issues stemming from emotional dysregulation—while noticeably missing from diagnostic criteria for ADHD—are a fundamental part of the ADHD experience for many children and adults. Even when controlling for related comorbid conditions, individuals with ADHD experience disproportionate problems with anger, irritability, and managing other emotions. These problems walk in lockstep with the general difficulties in self-regulation that characterize ADHD. Recent findings, however, suggest that problems with emotional regulation, including anger and negative emotions, are genetically linked to ADHD, too.

Ultimately, emotional dysregulation is one major reason why ADHD is subjectively difficult to manage, and why it also poses such a high risk for other problems like depression, anxiety, or negative self-medication. Scientific and clinical attention is now increasingly turning to correct the past neglect of this integral aspect of ADHD.

Recognizing this inherent relationship between emotional dysregulation and ADHD is also important when discerning between related and similar conditions, like disruptive mood dysregulation disorder (DMDD), bipolar disorder, intermittent explosive disorder (IED), depression, anxiety disorders, and oppositional defiant disorder (ODD). In all, paying mind to anger issues and emotionality in patients with ADHD is crucial for successful treatment and symptom management in the long term.

Anger Issues and ADHD: Theories & Research

Though separated from ADHD in official nomenclature today, emotional dysregulation and anger were connected to ADHD in the mid-20th century before current diagnostic norms were created and have continued to form part of personal and clinical experiences.

Decades ago, when ADHD was known as “minimal brain dysfunction,” criteria for diagnosis actually included aspects of negative emotionality.

Anger problems and emotional dysregulation in individuals with ADHD are sometimes explained by co-occurring mood disorders, such as anxiety or depression. However, these associated disorders do not explain the near-universal anger and emotional issues that ADHD individuals experience.

A critical aspect to consider, then, is ADHD’s nature as a disorder of self-regulation across behavior, attention, and emotion. In other words, any difficulties in regulating our thoughts, emotions, and actions—as is common with ADHD—may explain the irritability, tantrums, and anger regulation issues these individuals experience. And the majority do.

About 70% of adults with ADHD report problems with emotional dysregulation, according to research published in *BMC Psychiatry*. A study in *Psychological Assessment* found that went up to 80% in children with ADHD. In clinical terms, these problem areas include:

Irritability: Issues with anger dysregulation—“tantrum” episodes as well as chronic or generally negative feelings in between episodes.

Lability: Frequent, reactive mood changes during the day.

Recognition: The ability to accurately recognize other people’s feelings.

Affective intensity: Felt intensity—how strongly an emotion is experienced. People with ADHD tend to feel emotions very intensely.

Emotional dysregulation: Global difficulty adapting emotional intensity or state to a situation.

Explaining ADHD and Anger via Emotional Profiles

Emotional dysregulation remains a constant in ADHD even when analyzing personality traits, making the case for emotional profiles or subtypes around ADHD.

Our own study of children with ADHD that used computational methods to identify consistent temperament profiles found that about 30% of kids with ADHD clearly fit a profile strongly characterized by irritability and anger. These children have very high levels of anger, and low levels of rebound back to baseline—when they get angry, they can’t get over it.

Another 40% had extreme dysregulation around so-called positive affect or hyperactive traits—like excitability and sensation-seeking. Children with this profile also had above-average levels of anger, but not as high as those with the irritable profile.

Thinking of ADHD in terms of temperament profiles also becomes meaningful when considering the role of brain imaging in diagnosing ADHD. Brain scans and other physiological measures are not diagnostic for ADHD because of the wide variation in results among individuals with ADHD. However, if we consider brain scans based on temperament profiles, the situation may become clearer. Data from brainwave recordings makes the case that there is distinct brain functioning among children who fall under our proposed irritable and exuberant ADHD profiles.

In eye-tracking tests among the participants, for example, children in this irritable subgroup struggled more than those in any other identified subgroup to take their attention off negative, unhappy faces shown to them. Their brains would activate in the same areas when they saw negative emotions; this did not happen when they saw positive emotions.

Genetic Basis for ADHD and Anger Issues

From a genetic standpoint, it appears that emotional dysregulation is strongly associated with ADHD. Our recent findings suggest that genetic liability for ADHD is related directly to most traits under emotional dysregulation, like irritability, anger, tantrums, and overly exuberant sensation-seeking. What's more, irritability appears to have the biggest overlap with ADHD versus other traits, like excessive impulsivity and excitement, in children.

These findings refute the idea that mood problems in ADHD are necessarily part of an undetected depression—even though they do indicate higher future risk for depression as well as higher possibility of depression being present.

Anger Issues: DMDD, Bipolar Disorder & ADHD

ADHD, DMDD, and bipolar disorder are all associated in different ways with anger and irritability. Understanding how they relate (and don't) is critical to ensuring proper diagnosis and targeted treatment for anger issues in patients.

Anger Issues and Disruptive Mood Dysregulation Disorder

DMDD is a new disorder in the *DSM-5* primarily characterized by:

- Severe tantrums, either verbal or behavioral, that are grossly out of proportion to the situation
- A baseline mood of persistent grumpiness, irritability, and/or anger

DMDD was established in *DSM-5* after a crisis in child mental health in the 1990s in which rates of bipolar disorder diagnoses and associated treatment with psychotropic medication in children skyrocketed—inaccurately. Clinicians at that time assumed, in

error, that irritability in children could be substituted for actual mania, a symptom of bipolar disorder. We now know from further epidemiological work that, in the absence of mania, irritability is not a symptom of hidden bipolar disorder in children. When mania is present, irritability can also emerge as a side feature of the mania. But mania is the primary feature of bipolar disorder.

Mania means a notable change from normal in which a child (or adult) has unusually high energy, less need for sleep, and grandiose or elevated mood, sustained for at least a couple of days—not just a few hours. True bipolar disorder remains very rare in pre-adolescent children. The average age of onset for bipolar disorder is 18 to 20 years.

Thus, DMDD was created to give a place for children older than six years of age with severe, chronic temper tantrums who also do not have an elevated risk for bipolar disorder in their family or in the long run. It opens the door for research on new treatments targeted at these children, most of whom meet the criteria for severe ADHD, often with associated oppositional defiant disorder.

DMDD is also somewhat similar to intermittent explosive disorder (IED). The difference is that a baseline negative mood is absent in the latter. IED is also usually reserved for adults.

As far as ADHD, it is important to recognize that most patients who meet the criteria for DMDD actually have severe ADHD, sometimes with comorbid anxiety or ODD. This diagnosis, however, is given to help avoid a bipolar disorder diagnosis and take advantage of new treatment insights.

Anger Issues and ADHD: Treatment Approaches

Most treatment studies for ADHD look at how the core symptoms of ADHD change. Treating anger problems in individuals with ADHD has only recently become a major research focus, with useful insights revealed for patient care. Alternative and experimental approaches are also increasingly showing promise for patients with emotional dysregulation and anger issues.

Interventions for Children with Anger Issues

Behavioral Therapy

- 1. Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT):** Some children with anger issues have a tendency to over-perceive threat—they overreact to an unclear or ambiguous situation (e.g., someone accidentally bumps you in line) when no threat is actually present. For these children, CBT can help the child understand that something ambiguous isn't necessarily threatening.

2. **Counseling:** Anger problems can also be caused by difficulties with tolerating frustration. Counseling can help children learn how to tolerate normal frustrations and how to develop better coping mechanisms.
3. **Parent Counseling:** Parents have a role in how a child's anger manifests. A parent's angry reaction can lead to negative and mutual escalation, such that parents and kids both start to lose their balance. This can form a negative loop. With counseling, parents can learn to react differently to their child's tantrums, which can help reduce them over time.

Medication

Regular stimulant medication for ADHD helps ADHD symptoms much of the time but is only about half as helpful with anger problems. Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors (SSRIs) may be next for treating severe anger problems. A double-blind study published in the *Journal of the American Academy of Child & Adolescent Psychiatry*, for example, found that children with severe tantrums, DMDD, and ADHD who were on stimulants saw a reduction in irritability and tantrums only after being given citalopram (Celexa, an SSRI antidepressant) as a second medication. While only one study, these findings do suggest that when mainline stimulant medications are not working, and severe anger problems are a core issue, then adding an SSRI may be a reasonable step.

Interventions for Adults with Anger Issues

Behavioral counseling (as in CBT) has clear evidence pointing to its benefits in treating emotional regulation problems for adults with ADHD. Specifically, these therapies improve skills in the following:

- **Interior regulation:** This refers to what individuals can do within themselves to manage out-of-control anger. The key element here is learning coping skills, practicing them, and checking back with a counselor for refining. Important for patients to understand is that learning about coping skills without practice, or trying some self-help without professional consultation, is generally not as effective. Some examples of coping skills include:
 - **Anticipatory coping** or devising an exit plan to the triggering situation—"I know I'm going to get angry next time this happens. What am I going to plan ahead of time to avoid that situation?"
 - **Appraisals and self-talk** to keep temper under control ("Maybe that was an accident, or they're having a bad day").
 - **Shifting attention** to focus elsewhere instead of on the upsetting situation.

- **Exterior supports:**

- **Social connections**—talking to others and having their support are tremendously beneficial for adults struggling with ADHD and anger.
- **Exercise**, stress reduction, and other self-care strategies can help.

Strategies with Limited Benefits

- Typical ADHD medication helps with core symptoms, but has only modest benefits on emotional dysregulation for adults with ADHD, according to a study published in *Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorders*.
- Another study published in *Medicine* found that meditation classes offer some benefits for managing ADHD symptoms and emotional dysregulation for teens and adults (and for children, if parents join in the practice too), but most studies on this intervention tend to be of low quality so it is difficult to draw strong conclusions.
- High-dose micronutrients may help adults with ADHD emotionality, based on a small but robust study published in the *British Journal of Psychiatry*. Omega-3 supplementation also appears to have a small effect in bettering emotional control in children with ADHD, according to research published in the *Journal of Affective Disorders*.

Problems with emotional dysregulation, particularly anger reactivity, are very common in people with ADHD. You are not alone in struggling in this area. Anger may indicate an associated mood problem but often is just part of the ADHD. Either way, changes in traditional ADHD treatment can be very helpful.

Joel Nigg, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist and a professor in the departments of psychiatry and behavioral sciences at Oregon Health & Science University.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “You’re So Emotional: Why ADHD Brains Wrestle with Emotional Regulation,” with Joel Nigg, Ph.D.

How to Control Your Anger When ADHD Emotional Reactivity Kicks In

By Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

It starts with a trigger. In an instant, a volcano of anger and negative emotion erupts. Before you can process what's happening, you say or do things you will regret later. But you can't stop yourself. If we're being honest, sometimes it feels good to let it all out.

Living with ADHD means living with a stress-producing condition that begets emotional reactivity. Though the ADHD brain is wired to feel emotions like anger, frustration, and hurt quite intensely, emotional reactivity is ultimately a response pattern—one that you can shift with the right tools and frame of mind.

Why Anger and Big Emotions Rock ADHD Brains

Emotional dysregulation is part and parcel of ADHD. Taken together, the following features explain why emotional eruptions occur so acutely and so often in ADHD.

Amygdala Hijack and Emotional Flooding

The amygdala is the emotional part of the brain that drives the fight-flight-freeze response. Amygdala hijack, a term coined by Daniel Goleman, Ph.D., occurs when the brain overreacts to a threat, real or perceived, and effectively takes over the prefrontal cortex—the thinking part of the brain.

ADHD brains appear more likely to experience amygdala hijack for a variety of reasons. For one, amygdala abnormalities are commonly seen in ADHD brains. The ADHD brain also struggles to turn off emotional processing—a problem when stress, either caused by systemic or individual forces, is persistently present. A constant flooding of stress and emotions essentially causes individuals to lose access to the rational part of themselves.

Poor Working Memory

Strong working memory is tied to effective emotional regulation, while weak working memory—which is associated with ADHD and executive dysfunction—often compromises a person's ability to manage and respond appropriately to emotions. Weak working memory could explain why you struggle to recall and decide on the coping strategies and tools available to you when faced with a trigger. Executive dysfunction also explains limited impulse control—or why you might say or do things you regret when you're overwhelmed.

Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria

RSD charges your thoughts and puts you on edge, often contributing to emotional erup-

tions. As you brace to hear or experience the worst, for example, you may lash out as a defense mechanism. That's why anger is often called a secondary emotion—fear and other feelings are often hidden beneath the surface. The possibility that the negative outcome you've imagined might not occur doesn't even come into sight.

How to Control ADHD-Laced Anger

Understand Your Anger Habits

- Habits are mostly involuntary patterns of behavior that develop to meet an emotional need. Habits are made up of triggers, routine behaviors, and reinforcing outcomes. Changing a habit only requires targeting one of these components.
- Anger and emotional outbursts are habitual responses to uncomfortable feelings. They often arise when we underestimate our ability to cope with stressors.

Investigate Your Reactivity

Become curious about how your anger works (think about it in terms of the components of a habit), when it shows up, and any patterns associated with the emotion. Metacognition is a powerful tool (and an executive function skill) that can help you monitor and evaluate your thoughts and behaviors when you experience anger. The following metacognitive questions can help you understand your reactive patterns:

- **“What is happening that is activating me or making me feel on edge?”** Receiving negative feedback, being blamed unfairly, having someone yell at you, and/or feeling ashamed over something can all test your limits, as can other stressors.
- **“What sensations do I feel when I become angry or upset?”** Anger appears in many forms: a headache; a stomachache; sweating; chest tightness; etc.
- **“What behaviors do I resort to when I'm upset or angry?”** Reactivity habits include lashing out, attacking, catastrophizing, blaming, denying, and more.
- **“What's helped me calm down when I've been in similar situations? Are those responses useful?”** Create a list of 'slow me down' options to manage the amygdala takeover more effectively.
- **“How are others reacting to my words and actions? What are their faces or bodies showing?”** Noticing other people's facial or bodily expressions will also move you from a knee-jerk response to something that is more thoughtful and measured.

It takes time and effort to strengthen metacognition. Refrain from judgment as you observe your thoughts, sensations, and behaviors. Simply apply yourself to noticing and shifting one thing. Remember that you are doing the best you can as you investigate your reactivity and apply different tools to control your anger.

Change Old Anger Habits with Effective Responses

Gather tools to slow anger at every stage: You need to access the modulated part of you that wants to stay calm. Here are ideas for responses at every stage of emotional intensity.

When you're mildly uncomfortable: This stage is just above your baseline of calm and comfortable. There is a soft trigger that is easy enough to ignore, but it's nonetheless there.

- **Notice the negative, critical voice** that is starting to change your thoughts.
- **Compare your limiting beliefs** about the situation or about yourself to the real facts on the ground.

When you're activated: You're growing upset, angry, or overwhelmed at this stage—and it's becoming difficult to ignore. Perhaps you're ruminating on something that is bothering you. There's a battle of sorts between the emotional and thinking parts of the brain.

- **Talk down the emotional brain.** Acknowledge and validate your feelings. Say, "It's okay to be angry. But what can I do to settle down?"
- **Repeat affirmations or supportive phrases.** Here is an example: "This is not the most fun moment or my best moment, but I'll get through it."
- **Visualize yourself settling down.** Imagine yourself by a lake, tossing in pebbles. As each one journeys to the sandy bottom, feel yourself settle into your feet or chair.

When you're on high alert: You're at your most dysregulated at this stage. Your body is fully engaged to fight or flee. Physical signs of anger show up here—and physical responses can help your body slow down in the middle of the tidal wave of emotion.

- **Try focused breathing techniques**—alternate nostril breathing, belly breathing, etc. I often recommend triangle breathing: Breathe in for a count of four, hold for a count of four, and exhale for a count of six. Pause before repeating the cycle. The longer exhales slow the physiological response of fight or flight.
- **Physically remove yourself** from the stressor or situation.
- **Engage in a physical activity**, like a walk or a run, to blow off steam.
- **Turn to a timed distraction.** Listen to music or play a game on your phone.

Identify your preferred soothers but know that you can mix and match responses. Breathing, for example, is useful at every stage.

Practice, Practice, Practice

Stressful situations are a part of life largely outside our control. But we can manage our

responses using insightful strategies. Keep the following pointers in mind as you move away from habits of reactivity to new habits of responsiveness.

- **Commit to change.** List your coping tools in multiple places—in your phone, on sticky notes around your home—to help you readily retrieve them.
- **Focus on one thing** that you can change at a time. Smaller goals mean greater progress.
- **Rely on a growth mindset.** Expect to be challenged and frustrated as you adjust your emotional responses. See your mistakes as learning opportunities and areas for improvement, not as personal flaws.
- **Remember why you want to change** your habits and move away from anger.
- **Don't be so hard on yourself.** Shame and regret will only hold you back. Berating yourself for things that you've done is useless if you can't take helpful lessons from those experiences. Practice self-compassion by acknowledging that you are doing the best you can. Accept that you will lose it at times, despite your best efforts. Progress may look like two steps forward and one step back, but that's still one step forward.
- **You are not your ADHD reactivity.** Intense feelings might have been a part of your life for a long time, but they do not define you. You are more than your foibles. Stumbling helps us do what we are supposed to do: learn.

More Ways to Improve Emotional Regulation

Manage RSD

- **Identify your strengths and notice the good.** Each day, write down three things that went well, no matter how small. Example: “I had a great cup of coffee. I smiled today. I like the clothes I wore.”
- **Treat yourself with kindness.** Gather a collection of affirmations and personal words of encouragement. Put these on your phone or post them around your house or office.

Maintain a Healthy Lifestyle

- **Follow a routine** that allows you to get enough sleep, eat nutritious meals, move your body, and connect with others. A routine can ground you and lower stress levels.
- **Think HALT** throughout the day—are you hungry? Angry? Lonely? Tired? What are your options to address these and regulate them?
- **Focus on building positive relationships** with others. Learn how to resolve conflicts by planning for them well in advance.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled, “When ADHD Triggers Emotional Outbursts: Scripts for Your Flashpoints,” with Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

ADHD Anger Management Tips: How to Subdue Outbursts

We all have temper triggers—things that cause our anger to flare. If you have ADHD, stress and impulsivity may exacerbate these. Learn how to identify your most troubling triggers, and brainstorm positive solutions to keep your cool.

Do daily frustrations and annoyances push your ADHD to the brink? Are you guilty of angry outbursts? Getting stressed and upset rarely helps—and often hurts your relationships in the process. So here are expert tips on ADHD anger management that can help anyone—with or without ADHD.

Know What Angers You

Identify your anger triggers. Know the situations that make you angry so you can be ready to take a deep breath, pause, and respond in a calm and relaxed manner. Remind your ADHD brain to focus on your breath, relax your muscle tension, and think pleasant and positive thoughts.

Ban negative thoughts. Change your negative thoughts into positive sayings that you enjoy hearing yourself say, like “chill out” or “stay calm.” Adults with ADHD often find these reminders much easier to hear from themselves than from others.

Consider the Consequences

Take a moment. Adults with attention deficit often lack restraint when feeling angry, so it's important to pause and think of what will result from your anger, and then think of the consequences that calm, relaxed responses will get. Resolve to talk the incident over with a friend or coach who can support and help you to continue to respond in a way that will help you grow and be satisfied.

Be prepared for the worst-case scenario. If you are in an unbearable situation, ask yourself, “What is the worst that could happen right now?” Chances are that the worst possible outcome won't happen, but you will be prepared if it does. This exercise will help you take a moment to put things in perspective.

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

Be Positive

Brainstorm positive solutions to situations that make you angry. When you're in a situation that's pushing your buttons, choose the best solution to act upon, and have a backup plan if the first solution doesn't work. People with attention deficit tend to overreact to failures, so if your Plan A doesn't work, don't dwell on it—just move on and learn from the experience.

Congratulate yourself. Give yourself kudos each and every time you manage to lessen your anger and respond in a more appropriate way. Not only will your relationships with others improve as you continue to control your anger, but recognizing your accomplishment will give a nice boost to your self-esteem.

This article was written by Sandy Maynard, M.S.

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

Men with ADHD Are Asking: “Why Am I So Angry?”

By Terry M. Dickson, M.D., ACG, CPCC

Men with ADHD are especially prone to frustration and anger for many reasons. It is possible that these males feel worthless, guilty, and ashamed. A sense of failure may make them angry with themselves. The rage and anger that results may be taken out on loved ones. It may be like a pressure cooker with tension building up; if the stored-up anger is not slowly released, explosive behavior may result. Expressions of anger may stem from not feeling loved, or feeling out of control or rejected.

Take the example of Brett, a 45-year-old male diagnosed with ADHD, who contacted me for coaching because of anger challenges. Brett was a highly successful businessman and brought in lots of business for his company. You wouldn't have imagined that he had any problems when he was on the job. He rose quickly to the top as a manager because of his leadership skills.

Yet when Brett returned home after working late hours, he seemed to lose it. His wife immediately asked him to give her a break from a day of taking care of their very active children. Brett typically came home exhausted from work, and the last thing he wanted was to deal with more chaos. This quickly led to frustration and, if left unchecked, uncontrollable anger toward his wife and children. Brett was able to eventually manage his angry outbursts toward his wife and children after months of coaching.

Anger is a natural reaction to feelings of hurt and betrayal. It needs to be expressed at times and not held inside. Men often struggle with buried feelings because they are taught that if a man shows emotion, he is weak and not a man. Feelings can be so deeply hidden that there is no sense of feeling at all. These feelings often don't come out unless there is a life-threatening trauma, job loss, or other significant change of life. However, aggressive forms of anger that are out of control hurt a person socially, mentally, and physically. The goal of anger management is to help you find ways to express your anger and resolve the problems that trigger it. Here are some tips to follow:

- **Be aware of early warning signs.** Give yourself a “time out.” Find a safe spot for yourself and try deep breathing to calm down. Close your eyes and breathe all the stress out.
- **Give yourself a break.** Go for a walk, get some exercise. Fresh air will do you good. Later you can come back to the problem from a new perspective and solve it!

- **It is OK to express your anger in a healthy, non-confrontational way.** Decide what the real ‘issue’ is, and once you are calm, state your concerns while being sensitive to the concerns of others.
- **Learn to recognize those ADHD moments that trigger your anger.** Think about what effect your anger has on others around you. How might you handle the same situation differently from now on?
- **Ask yourself this question: “Will the object of my anger even matter 10 years from now?”**
- **Take care of yourself.** Make sure that you get enough sleep, eat healthy, well-balanced meals, and exercise regularly.
- **Brainstorm positive solutions** to the problem.
- **Learn to think before you speak.** In the heat of a discussion, it is more difficult to listen. But pausing in the moment allows you to collect your thoughts and reflect upon what the other person is saying.
- **Know when to seek help** from a counselor or coach.

Terry M. Dickson, M.D., ACG, CPCC, is the founder and director of The Behavioral Medicine Clinic of NW Michigan.

“ADHD Symptoms in Men Manifest Differently”

By Alan P. Brown

As a 62-year-old man with ADHD, I can get emotional quickly, and often about relatively insignificant things. I can be immature and irresponsible. For years, I have felt embarrassment and shame about the lack of progress in my career. I also have learned that these characteristics, among others, are more pronounced in many men with ADHD than they are in their female and neurotypical counterparts.

Much has been written, deservedly, about the unique challenges facing women with ADHD. But, arguably, not as much has been written about how men experience ADHD differently. Sure, most of us know that hyperactive boys are more likely to be diagnosed than inattentive girls. However, the people in our lives really need to understand the differences men with ADHD experience.

Here are examples of how I think ADHD manifests differently in the sexes:

Delayed emotional development. Research has shown that males mature more slowly than females, and this seems especially true for men with ADHD.

Being quick to anger. While girls tend to internalize emotions, boys are more likely to externalize theirs. It stands to reason, then, that boys with ADHD have higher rates of oppositional defiant disorder. In adulthood, men with ADHD are more prone to emotional outbursts fueled by anger at real or perceived slights.

Resistance to pursuing a diagnosis. In my many years of ADHD coaching, I’ve encountered countless women who struggle with their husbands’ or young adult sons’ resistance to seeking or accepting an ADHD diagnosis because they fear the “stigma” of the disorder, and, in their male minds, it’s admitting to “weakness.” Unsurprisingly, most of my female social media followers are the ones who most actively pursue understanding ADHD on behalf of their husbands, their kids, and themselves.

Lackluster career advancement. This issue for men arises, in part, from the social construct that still expects men to be the head of the household, the main breadwinner. When a man with ADHD is unable to perform optimally or successfully retain his job (as was the case for me for many years), the shame and guilt can be devastating.

Think about how often new social interactions begin with, “So, what do you do for a living?” In other words, what is your value? And when you’re not proud of what you do, or how well you’re doing it, you feel shame and embarrassment.

How Men Can Manage ADHD Symptoms

Men with ADHD need a safe place to share their struggles, like a support group

with people who share similar challenges. Feeling heard and learning new ideas for how to cope can be very comforting.

Mindfulness training and exercise can help with mood stabilization and rein in emotions. I also recommend working with your partner, and perhaps a therapist, on communication strategies to control outbursts before they happen.

I've found that understanding common ADHD symptoms in men and working on managing them has helped me become more effective in my life as an adult with ADHD.

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

Why Is My Child So Angry?!

Beaten down by your child's defiant behavior? Wondering why she's always in a rage? It could be oppositional defiant disorder. Stop the madness—and the violent outbursts—with these strategies for anger disorders in kids.

Anne dreads waking up in the morning. Her son, Sam—who has ADHD and an anger disorder—is unpredictable. Sometimes he just goes along with the morning routine. Other times, he'll lash out at the smallest thing—a request to get dressed, an unplanned stop on the way to school, or a simple “No” to a request for pizza for dinner.

“On any given day, I never know what to expect from him,” says Anne, a public relations manager for an independent high school in New England. “He'll start yelling and kicking when anything doesn't go his way.”

Sam was diagnosed with ADHD at age five, and while that explained some of his difficulties in school, it never explained his aggressive and defiant temperament. It wasn't until the beginning of this school year that Anne sought additional help for her son's behavior, which was becoming stressful for her family. The pediatrician determined that Sam was suffering from ADHD and oppositional defiant disorder (ODD).

How Do You Recognize ODD in a Child with ADHD?

Children with ODD have a pattern of angry, violent, and disruptive behaviors toward parents, caretakers, and other authority figures. Before puberty, ODD is more common in boys, but after puberty, it is equally common in both genders. Sam is not alone in his dual diagnosis of ADHD and ODD; up to 40% of children with ADHD are estimated to have ODD.

Every child will act out and test his boundaries occasionally, and ODD seems like typical adolescent behavior: arguing, anger, and aggression. The first step to fixing a child's problematic behavior is recognizing ODD. How do you know whether your child is just being a child or if they need professional help?

There is no clear line between “normal defiance” and ODD, says Ross W. Greene, Ph.D., associate clinical professor of psychiatry at Harvard Medical School and author of *The Explosive Child*. The lack of clear criteria explains why professionals often disagree on

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

whether a child should be diagnosed with ODD.

Dr. Greene emphasizes that it is up to parents to decide when to get help for a defiant child. “If you’re struggling with your child’s behavior, and it is causing unpleasant interactions at home or at school, then you’ve easily met the criteria for having a problem,” Dr. Greene says. “And I’d suggest you seek professional help.”

Anne had never heard of ODD when she called a cognitive behavioral therapist to discuss coping strategies for her son’s erratic behavior. After spending some time in the family’s home, observing Sam and his interactions with his mother, the therapist saw signs of ODD. “I didn’t know what she was talking about,” Anne says. At Sam’s next doctor’s visit, Anne asked whether ODD could explain Sam’s behavior, and the physician said yes.

“When I thought about it, the diagnosis made sense,” Anne says. “Nothing I used with my older daughter—like counting down to some set consequence before punishing her—to control her behavior ever worked for Sam.”

Another mother, Jane Gazdag, an accountant from New York, began noticing troubling behavior in her son, Seamus Brady, now eight, when he was four. “He would scream for two or three hours over the smallest thing,” Jane says. “He fought everything.”

When Jane realized that she had stopped trying to do fun things with her son, like spending the day in Manhattan, because they were too stressful for her, she suspected that he had ODD and spoke to her pediatrician about it. Seamus was diagnosed with it.

Signs of ODD can be seen in a child’s behavior toward their primary caregiver. The defiant behavior may spread to a secondary caregiver and to teachers or other authority figures, but if it appears in a child with ADHD, ODD will appear within two years of an ADHD diagnosis.

If a child does start to become defiant, there is an easy way to tell whether that behavior is a consequence of ADHD or is a sign of ODD. “ADHD isn’t a problem with starting a task, it’s a problem with finishing a task,” says Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D. “If a child can’t start a task without a fight, that’s ODD.”

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

How ADHD and Anger Disorders Overlap

Understanding why ODD is found so frequently in children with ADHD is to understand the two dimensions of the disorder—the emotional and social components, Dr. Barkley says. Frustration, impatience, and anger are a part of the emotional component. Arguing and outright defiance are part of the social aspect.

Most children with ADHD are impulsive, and this drives the emotional component of ODD. “For people with ADHD, emotions are expressed quickly, whereas others can contain their feelings,” Dr. Barkley says. This is why the subset of children with inattentive ADHD are less likely to develop ODD. Children who have ADHD, along with intense impulsivity, are likely to be diagnosed with ODD.

Anger and frustration are hard to manage in a child with ODD and ADHD, but it is defiance that exacerbates the family stress caused by ODD. The surprising thing is that parents fuel the defiance. If a parent is quick to give in when a child has a tantrum, the child learns that they can manipulate situations by getting angry and putting up a fight. This aspect of ODD is a learned behavior, but it can be unlearned through behavioral therapy.

How Should Parents Treat ADHD and ODD?

Before tackling a child’s ODD, it is important that their ADHD is controlled. “When we reduce a child’s hyperactivity, impulsiveness, and inattention, perhaps through medication, we see simultaneous improvement in oppositional behavior,” Dr. Greene says.

The traditional stimulant medications are the initial drugs of choice because they have been shown to decrease the impairments of ADHD, as well as ODD, by up to 50% in more than 25 published studies, says William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA. Non-stimulant medications may also help. In one study, researchers found that the drug atomoxetine, the generic form of the active ingredient found in Strattera, significantly reduced ODD and ADHD symptoms. The researchers note in the study, published in the *Journal of the American Academy of Child and Adolescent Psychiatry*, that higher doses of the medication were needed to control symptoms in children who were diagnosed with both conditions.

Strattera helped Seamus control his emotions, reducing the number and intensity of his tantrums. “It made a big difference,” Jane says. For some, medication is not enough, and after a child’s ADHD symptoms are under control, it’s time to address ODD behaviors.

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

Although there is little evidence to show that any treatment is effective in treating ODD, most professionals agree that behavioral therapy has the most potential to help. There are many forms of behavioral therapy, but the general approach is to reward good behavior and provide consistent consequences for inappropriate actions and behaviors.

Behavioral therapy programs don't start with the child; they start with the adult. Because a child with ODD usually has a caretaker who gives in to tantrums and violent behavior or offers inconsistent punishment for bad behavior, the child thinks that acting out will get them what they want. Therefore, a child's primary caretaker has to be educated to effectively respond to a child with ODD. Another part of parental training is to consider whether ADHD has gone undiagnosed in the parent; adults with the condition are likely to be inconsistent in managing a child's behavior.

Implementing consistent punishment is only one part of a behavioral therapy program; a parent must learn to use positive reinforcement when a child behaves himself.

How Long Will It Take to Improve an Anger Disorder?

A behavioral therapist works with the parent and child together to reduce troubling behaviors. At the top of Anne's list was her son's "Shut up," which he shouted at anyone. Anne kept a tally sheet to list the number of times her son would shout it in a day. At the end of the day, Anne and her son looked at the total together. If the number was under the set goal for the day, she gave him a small reward, a toy, or time spent playing video games. Day by day, Sam tried to reduce the number of times he said, "shut up," and Anne tried to be consistent in her punishments.

All of the child's caregivers should participate in the program. Grandparents, teachers, nannies, and other adults who spend time alone with your child must understand that the need for consistency in behavioral therapy extends to them as well.

"ODD has a deleterious effect on relationships and communication between kids and adults," Dr. Greene says. "You want to start improving things as soon as you can."

Anne believes that her diligence will pay off. "We hope that all the work we've done will one day click for Sam," she says.

This article was written by Karen Barrow, a health and science writer based in New York City.

Anger Is Important—but Only When It's Managed

By Edward Hallowell, M.D.

Of all the emotions that can get a child into trouble, anger leads the list. While sadness or anxiety causes misery, anger leads to trouble—punishment, suspension, expulsion, and a host of other outcomes we don't wish our children to suffer.

It is important that a child expresses their anger, but the emotion should be like a sneeze: It clears the passageways and is over. A child who cannot get angry is in as much danger as a child who cannot control their anger.

Here are 10 tips for understanding and neutralizing anger. These anger management techniques can be used anywhere, and do not require a coach's or expert's help to master. If you'd like to learn more, I refer you to my book, *When You Worry About the Child You Love*, from which these tips are adapted.

1. **Exercise away hostility.** One of the best tonics for the brain is physical exercise. My friend and colleague, John Ratey, M.D., showed in his book, *Spark: The Revolutionary New Science of Exercise and the Brain*, that exercise helps promote healthy brain function, including the ability to control aggression.
2. **Learn to put feelings into words.** One of the more common reasons a child loses control is that they cannot articulate their frustration. Saying, "I'm really angry" can prevent anger from morphing into violence.
3. **Curb the electronics.** Not only does staring at a screen all day numb the mind, but it also precludes more useful exercise and face-to-face social interactions. Some electronic use is fine, even desirable. But too much, more than two hours a day, should be avoided.
4. **Teach your child that anger is a signal, not an outcome.** When they get angry, they should learn to stop and ask, "Why am I angry?" If they can put that into words, it will be easier to control. Furthermore, if they are angry because they are being mistreated or are in danger, they can ask for help.
5. **As a family, practice compromise and negotiation.** In his excellent book, *The Explosive Child*, Ross W. Greene, Ph.D., introduced a method he calls collaborative problem-solving. Read the book and learn the technique. It works wonders. It is based on negotiation, not giving orders or commands.
6. **Check out any underlying problems you suspect your child may have.** Various conditions, including ADHD, conduct disorder, seizure disorders, thyroid dysfunction, or brain tumors, can manifest themselves as uncontrollable anger.

7. **Keep notes.** If your child has a problem with anger, take a few minutes daily to document what they have done. After a month, read through the entries. You may see a pattern that will suggest effective interventions.
8. **Skip physical punishment.** Families run best with a shared agreement: “We never put hands on each other in anger.” The days of spanking should be long gone. It will worsen a child’s anger.
9. **Be the boss.** That does not mean you should run your family as if it were the Marine Corps. But children do better knowing that their parents are in charge.
10. **Talk it out.** If none of these suggestions help, talk to people you trust or find an ADHD support group for parents.

Almost every child who has anger challenges can learn to control them. It may take some time and some backing and filling, but solutions can be found. Never worry alone.

Edward Hallowell, M.D., is a child and adult psychiatrist and founder of The Hallowell Centers for Cognitive and Emotional Health. He is the author of 20 books, including Driven to Distraction, Delivered from Distraction, and ADHD 2.0: New Science and Essential Strategies for Thriving with Distraction—from Childhood through Adulthood, with John J. Ratey, M.D.

Expert Q&A with Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Q: “My teenage son’s anger frightens me. He has kicked a hole in his bedroom door, and he is verbally abusive when we argue. What can I do?”

Dealing with anger can be challenging for teens with ADHD. Something goes wrong or someone says something that sets them off, and anger flares. Later, kids often regret their words and actions but don’t know how to prevent their overreaction the next time.

Many parents have told me that they don’t know how to help their children deal with anger. Like you, they’re tired of living with the fear of the next outburst. How can you tone down the anger?

Dealing with Anger and the ADHD Brain

Teens with ADHD feel emotions intensely. Changing hormone levels add to the intensity of their feelings. When the amygdala—the emotional control center of the brain—senses real or imagined danger, it triggers a fight-or-flight response. Within seconds, your teen’s thinking brain (prefrontal cortex) is temporarily offline, and feelings rule the day.

Working memory plays an important role in managing feelings. Research has linked weaker working memory to increased reactivity and reduced capacity to accurately assess emotional situations.

Teens tell me that this flood of emotion feels like a tidal wave, and they can’t keep their heads above water. Many teens with ADHD who hold themselves together in school release their frustration by attacking family members. Frequently, low self-esteem and disappointment in their school performance are the causes of angry outbursts.

Expert Help for Dealing with Anger

Physical violence and name-calling are not acceptable. An experienced family psychotherapist well-versed in ADHD can help. A clinician will address everybody’s concerns, conduct family therapy to change negative patterns, and teach anger management skills. They can assess your son for mood disorders too, since many teens mask low self-worth and hopelessness with anger.

Family therapy will also be a good place for you to share your own feelings in a safe, supportive environment. I also suggest speaking to your son’s prescriber. Some prescribers help teens with ADHD manage their emotions by combining stimulant and non-stimulant medications.

The Six-Step Plan for Dealing with Anger

Both you and your son will benefit from new tools. He needs to learn how to identify his triggers and use strategies for dealing with anger. You should determine the boundaries of appropriate involvement in his social life.

Work collaboratively, start with compassion, and you can achieve your goals. Here's how to join forces to find mutually satisfying solutions:

1. **Examine the cycle of anger during calmer times.** Is there a pattern to his angry outbursts? Look for particular times of day and triggers that seem to set him off. Additionally, note how your son reacts after an incident: Does he own his actions or blame you for his behaviors? What happens when he manages his reactions appropriately? Write down your responses.
2. **Are you contributing to his outbursts?** Which of your words or actions seem to annoy him most? What are your motivations to get involved in his social behaviors? Write down these answers, too.
3. **People can change only one thing at a time.** Reflect on the most important thing your son could improve and what you would like to change about yourself. Remember to practice patience with yourself and your son.
4. **Chat with your teen about working together,** doing things differently, and ask him some questions from list items Nos. 1 and 2. Write his responses down. Be sure to talk for less than 20 minutes—longer family meetings can turn into arguments. Choose a calm moment in the day for this conversation; talking after dinner, before bed, or during the weekend works best with teens.
5. **Create a plan of action that includes changes in behavior for both of you.** Discuss the consequences of not following your agreed-upon plan. Name some ways you can each show your remorse appropriately. For example, if you agree not to lose your temper and you do, maybe your consequence is to fold and put away his laundry. If he curses at you, he helps you with the dishes or takes out the trash. Make a list of consequences for each of you and post it in the kitchen.
6. **Check in about this agreement weekly.** Make any adjustments if necessary. Practice reflective listening by acknowledging what he says and ask him to do the same. Remember your shared goal: less conflict.

Learning is a process of trying, having a setback, and trying again. Your son's working memory challenges mean that encoding and recalling new behaviors will take longer than they would for a neurotypical child, but with time and patience, you and your son can become pros at dealing with anger, together.

Expert Q&A with Leslie Josel

Q: “My son suffers from terrible anger. He yells and throws things in rage, then apologizes and blames himself. How can I teach him to better manage his anger?”

I have to say that I grappled with answering this question since I’m not a medical professional and do not want to give you advice about your child’s explosive behavior that is incorrect, or, worse, harmful. However, I have worked with many families struggling to manage this type of behavior. And most feel alone, confused, and without guidance. This issue is more prevalent than you might think, and I hope by shining a light on it, other parents will seek the help they need. So, if you are concerned about taking the right path to help your son, please consider seeking professional help. This way your questions and concerns can be fully addressed.

That said, here are a few strategies to try.

- 1. Go over routines so your son knows exactly what to expect.** The practice of previewing and reviewing helps kids feel safe, so they can control their emotions a bit more easily.
- 2. Try to spend some time every day (15 to 30 minutes) with your son doing anything** (within reason) that he suggests. I have found in my work over the years that limits and boundaries are a common source of explosive behavior. Giving your son 30 minutes a day where he can “set the rules” can easily make him feel more in control of his environment.
- 3. Give choices.** Wherever possible, try asking questions like, “Do you want to start your homework at 4:14 p.m. or 4:28 p.m.?” or “Do you want spaghetti or chicken for dinner?” You get the idea. Bonus tip: Try to limit the open-ended questions. I find that simple choices are easier for the brain to manage and less likely to cause decision fatigue (which could lead to outbursts).
- 4. Be crystal clear on the rules in your home.** I can’t stress this enough. Hitting, punching, throwing things, etc., should be non-negotiables. So be empathetic to your child’s emotions but set limits accordingly.

Good luck!

Leslie Josel is an ADHD-academic and parenting coach, founder of Order Out of Chaos, and ADDitude contributor.

Expert Q&A with Terry M. Dickson, M.D., ACG, CPCC

Q: “Why do I get so angry with the ones I love most?”

We all know the destructive power of anger, particularly when it's uncontrolled. Here are some tough truths:

- Anger impedes our ability to be happy.
- It can send marriages and other family relationships off-course.
- It compromises our social skills, interfering with healthy relationships.
- It can hurt productivity at home and in the workplace.
- It can lead to health problems because of increased stress.

Many ADHD traits make it tough to control anger. The strongest, perhaps, is impaired executive function and diminished inhibition, leading to hasty responses due to frustration and impatience. People with ADHD also feel emotions more intensely than neurotypical people, causing them to overreact to situations or experiences that most people would respond to reasonably.

Perhaps you find yourself blurting out hurtful things in the heat of the moment, forgetting the last time you did this and the regret you felt afterward. When you combine poor working memory skills, typical of those with ADHD, with emotional impulsivity, a person may not say the right things or take the right actions when they are frustrated or angry.

How to Control Your Emotions with ADHD

Here are some things you can do to control emotions and improve the relationship with your family:

1. **Remember that anger is not necessarily bad.** It is a natural reaction to feelings of hurt and betrayal. Anger can be a motivating force promoting positive energy. Sometimes, it is important to demonstrate a sense of injustice at wrongdoing. At times, it is OK to express your anger in a healthy, non-confrontational way.
2. **Recognize the early warning signs that you are losing control of your emotions.** Are you easily irritated? Impatient with others? Do you go from calm to furious in a flash? Does your chest tighten? Do you start clenching your jaw or grinding your teeth? Learn to recognize those moments that signal anger is on its way. For example, if you always seem to argue with your spouse at night, avoid bringing up contentious topics when you are tired. It is difficult to make smart choices when you are in the grip of negative feelings.

3. **Give yourself a “time-out.”** Put some distance between whatever is stressing you and your reaction to it. Allow yourself time to process harsh feelings and negative thoughts, so that you can channel them into positive action.
4. **Get lots of exercise.** Physical activity will help you focus and feel better. Exercise helps burn off extra tension and reduces the stress that fuels angry outbursts. Go for a walk. Fresh air will do you good. Later, you can come back to the problem with a new perspective. It is also important to get enough sleep and eat healthy food, both of which will help you regulate emotions.
5. **Think before you speak and become a better listener.** In the heat of a discussion, it is hard to listen. Pause a bit to collect your thoughts and reflect on what the other person is saying.
6. **Practice simple relaxation strategies—e.g., deep focused breathing or focusing on relaxing imagery.** Choose a calming memory from the past. Try progressive muscle relaxation techniques, slowly tensing up your muscles and then relaxing them. Start with your toes and work your way to your neck and head.
7. **Don’t fixate on thoughts and feelings.** Maybe you can’t stop thinking about how someone reacted to you or about an overwhelming situation. In those moments, ask how your thoughts are serving you, and what it would feel like if you let them go.
8. **Know that anger may come from poor self-esteem.** Do you judge yourself harshly? Poor self-esteem has detrimental effects on relationships, especially when it brings constant emotional turmoil.
9. **Try cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT).** It is a short-term, goal-oriented treatment that can change your thinking patterns and actions by focusing on how you process thoughts, images, beliefs, and attitudes that hold you hostage to negative behaviors.
10. **Consider medication.** ADHD medications are very helpful for impulsive behaviors, as well as for improving focus and working memory. You may also need medication if a mood disorder and/or anxiety trigger your anger. It is best to see a mental health practitioner who is well-versed in ADHD to ensure you have the right diagnosis.

You can’t completely eliminate angry feelings, but you can change how you handle your emotions and keep your anger in check, making a positive difference in your relationship with your family.

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

How to Manage Your Anger Before It Bubbles to a Boil

ADDitude readers share how they manage their anger and control negative emotions.

Adults with ADHD experience disproportionate problems with anger, irritability, and rejection sensitivity. This emotional dysregulation is exacerbated when baseline stress and anxiety are already abnormally high. To identify helpful strategies, *ADDitude* asked its readers, “How do you manage negative emotions, such as anger, in your relationships?” Read their advice.

“Empathy and knowledge of ADHD’s hallmark symptoms has helped me. Dislike the disorder but not the person. This approach doesn’t always work, but it is the best place to start.”—*Julie, New York*

“The best way to assess and restrain yourself is to understand and accept your disability. My husband struggles with my ADHD. He doesn’t understand why I need sticky notes for everything, placed in areas where I can’t miss them. I have used articles from *ADDitude* to help him understand that my missteps are not intentional. Just as I have learned to live with his CPAP machine running all night, he is learning to live with my ADHD.”
—*Shawn, Utah*

“I pause before speaking, and I think hard about whether I am taking things or words the wrong way.”—*Annabelle, New Zealand*

“Mostly by biting my tongue, withholding certain remarks, and trying to take time to think about the situation and my responses. When I’m tired or under pressure, I do not listen well, and my reaction time is short. I say things I later regret. When I am angry, I will ask for a timeout or some space to cool down. Medication has played a big role in helping me to avoid ruminating about things.”—*T. B., South Africa*

“I am a duck in the rain. Everything is water running off my back. I’ve been married for 48 years, and I have to ignore things to keep from strangling my spouse.”
—*Charles, Arizona*

CHAPTER 3: EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION & THE ADHD-ANGER CONNECTION

“I take a break and come back to the conversation once I’ve calmed down and had time to think. I write down important thoughts before talking to ensure I remember them.”—*Stacy, North Carolina*

“I exercise. Simply making time to **go on a walk or hike helps calm me** and improves my mood.”—*Satina, New York*

“Through CBT, **I have begun to recognize how anxiety and other emotions can cloud judgment and responses.** It is hard not to get caught up in the moment when you have ADHD, but I am getting better at recognizing what I am feeling, then taking time to reflect and gather my thoughts before responding.”—*Anonymous*

“I ask for time to ‘gather my thoughts.’ It gives me time to cool down and think about their perspective and if I am having a rational response to whatever triggered me.”—*Michelle, Arizona*

“I call a trusted friend and vent when I am frustrated, but always make sure it is a friend who will not judge my husband or children by what I tell them. I also write my thoughts on paper or **write a letter about the issue** that I may or may not give to my partner or child.”—*Stephanie, Texas*

“Learning about the emotional components of ADHD has been instrumental in helping me step outside of my anger for a moment and also allows me to understand how my emotions affect my husband, friends, and family.”—*Christiane, Indiana*

“I try to **communicate what I need and how I’m feeling right away,** rather than hold it in. I tend to explode if I don’t.”—*Angie, New York*

“My spiritual life is a huge asset that allows me to assess my thoughts and emotions. **Prayer, study, and mindfulness** are fundamental.”—*Kevin, Ohio*

“Self-care! I get up early to start the day and focus myself before my son gets up.”—*Emily, Australia*

“Talk things out, take deep breaths, and schedule breaks during the day.”—*Amy L., Minnesota*

“I take full responsibility for how I respond to my emotions. **I identify and express the primary emotion which is not anger.** Usually, it is fear or pain.”—*Paul, Colorado*

“How to Keep Your Cool”

By Sandy Maynard, M.S.

Everyone gets mad sometimes. But given our penchant for impatience and impulsivity, we adults with ADHD lose our cool more often than most.

Fortunately, I’ve found simple, yet effective, ways to stay calm in the face of everyday hassles, like traffic jams, boring meetings, rude salespeople, parking tickets, long waits for customer service, and so on.

My Lost Luggage

Not long ago, I flew home to Washington, D.C., after a long, exhausting trip. What a relief to be home again, I thought, as I eyed the baggage circulating on the conveyor belt. But relief turned to frustration, and then anger, as I realized that, no matter how much I wanted my suitcase to materialize, it wasn’t going to. The airline had lost my luggage. Again. I was furious.

As I trudged to customer service, I did just what I tell my clients to do in such situations—I took several slow, deep breaths. I kept on deep breathing (in through the nostrils and out through the mouth), and managed to be civil as the man behind the counter explained that my suitcase wouldn’t be delivered to my home until after midnight.

I was still fuming when I boarded the Metro train, although I was pleased with myself for not causing a scene at the airport. As I took my seat for the ride home, I thought about how my former client, Richard, would have handled the situation.

Richard is doing well now, but he was a real hothead when he first came to see me. He lost his temper in all sorts of everyday situations, especially those over which he had little control.

Long meetings at work drove him crazy (long-winded boss). Ditto for rush-hour commutes (traffic), long family trips in the car (bickering kids), and discussions with his wife about money (different priorities). Once, while trying to assemble a storage cabinet, he got so frustrated (crummy instructions) that he threw it across the room.

Preempting Problems

Richard and I started our work together by identifying ways in which he could exercise at least some control in such situations. He realized that he was more likely to keep his cool on family trips if he got plenty of rest beforehand. Similarly, he found that having a snack before a meeting helped him stay calm, no matter how long his boss droned on. Robert also realized just how vital maintaining his sense of humor was to his well-being. He started collecting *Dilbert* cartoons, and even added “Sense of humor” to his packing lists.

Richard found breathing exercises especially effective. He got into the habit of taking 10 slow, deep breaths before getting into his car, sitting down for meetings, and so on. The more he practiced this simple technique, the better it worked.

When I finally arrived home, I realized that the key to my apartment was in my still-missing suitcase. Now on the brink of tears, I took yet another deep breath and phoned maintenance, which isn't known for its speedy service when tenants are locked out. With all the good cheer I could muster, I explained my plight, concluding with, "I'll be the frazzled-looking lady half passed out on the lobby sofa."

The maintenance man laughed. "Hang in there, Sandy," he said. "I'll be right over." And he was.

“Have I Overreacted? Big Time? Five Ways I Rectify Emotional Outbursts.”

By Les Steed

It's crisis time. I know because my heart rate is up. A lump in my throat forms. My muscles feel tense and alive. I hear words, but it's a part of the blur around me as I am hit with a thousand stimuli at once. My mind races as I consider potential escapes and threats. Everything is slow and fast at the same time.

Something's happened, and it's on me to figure out what it is and safely deal with it. It could be anything—a car crash, a death, a breakup, an arrest—it doesn't matter. The point is I'm losing control and I must regain that control to make us safe.

My ADHD spikes as my adrenaline increases. In many ways, ADHD symptoms have evolved so that individuals with ADHD are hard-wired to recognize a true threat and assess and react instantaneously, without fear or consideration of long-term consequences.

We skip all the bits we don't need, including logic, and jump straight into action. Our thoughts are on autopilot: Just stop the threat. Make everyone safe. Do not rest until your mission is complete. Deal with the aftermath later.

The only problem is that this time the big threat consists of... 10 party poppers and a loud “Surprise!”

But it's too late. I hear loud bangs and see lots of movement in what should be my empty apartment. I hyperfocus on the bright streamers and the fiery candles thrust into my face along with the loud noises around me. My mind and body are consumed: “We're under attack: Protect your girlfriend!” I swiftly forgo the non-threatening cues and details. I don't just ruin the surprise; I decimate it.

My flight-or-fight impulses cause me to shove the homemade cake my adorable grandma was wielding from behind the front door away from me with one hand and launch my partner back down the hall to protect her with the other.

Now Grandma's lying over a bean bag four feet away from her walker, her legs and petticoats waving in the air above her, covered in icing that reads ‘Happy Birthday’ and four letters of my name. Meanwhile, I'm standing in the middle of this mess shouting, “Sorry! Sorry! Sorry!” while flapping my arms like a penguin that just drank four espressos.

Everyone's yelling and looking at me in horror (except for Grandma, who assures me that “It's quite alright, Dear!” while I slip over my freshly iced floor in a rush to pick her up, and my brother, who is crying with laughter).

I feel overwhelmed and try to explain myself. I forget to apologize and just start blubbering everything in my head while the place erupts around me. It is chaos!

So, how should I handle this situation and others like it? Here's my hard-learned process:

1. **Close your eyes.** Shut out everything and take a deep breath. Make sure you enunciate clearly and say, "I'm sorry." Only say it once. The more you talk, the more it sounds like you are making excuses.
2. **Remove yourself from the situation and handle your emotions.** Tell people where you're going (behind a bush, a different room, etc.) and let them handle things while you pull yourself together. Otherwise, your stressed-out follow-up will make everyone else's reaction worse. Give them space to feel their feelings—at least 15 minutes. Take that time to think about what happened.
3. **Return once you're calm and apologize again.** Explain that you tried to do the right thing at the moment, and you made a mistake. You meant well, and you are sorry. (Your motive matters as much as your actions.)
4. **Do something small to show you care,** like tidying up. Take responsibility for your actions; talk to someone you hurt when they are ready. Don't hate yourself for what you did; remember that very little is completely unforgivable.
5. Once everyone's calm, **listen and do what they say** is needed to make it right for them. Don't deviate from their instructions (unless they tell you to take a long walk off a short cliff or are just being mean), and let them approach you if they don't want to talk when you first approach them. Take constructive instruction, but not personal criticism (someone just calling you an idiot isn't helpful).

Finally, keep your rejection sensitive dysphoria in check. Remember not to take what people say at the moment personally, especially if they're the hot-headed type. They have the right to react too, but that doesn't mean that you're automatically the worst person ever for reacting the way you did. Even if people tell you to "get out," it doesn't mean that they don't love you—it might even become an endearing story that you laugh about together one day.

Good luck.

“Help! My Kid’s Having an ADHD Meltdown in Target!”

By Elizabeth Broadbent

You’re at Target. You’re at Little League. You’re at a freaking grocery store, and he does it again: Your nine-year-old experiences an epic ADHD meltdown. His face reddens. He stomps. He screams, sometimes incoherently, sometimes coherently in very loud monosyllables: “I hate you! I want that!”

You’ve seen this before.

You know that this could have been avoided. He needs food. He needs a drink. He needs rest. He needs a simple brain break. But you misread him or tried to get it all done, and now you’re stuck with a screaming kid somewhere in an unforgiving public place where screaming kids mean bad parenting.

You feel the shade being thrown in your direction. Moms cut their eyes at you. *Other kids* cut their eyes at you. And they murmur words meant for you to overhear. *God, that kid is how old? He acts like he’s two.* When you lean down and speak to him gently, they snort. *He acts like that because he needs to get spanked. If he were my kid...* When you hug him, they all but laugh. *You know he throws those tantrums because he gets what he wants.*

You feel yourself wilting under their scrutiny, wishing you could have your own ADHD meltdown.

Pause. In the immortal words of Will Smith, the Fresh Prince of Bel Air, “Parents just don’t understand.” Except for us—the parents of children with ADHD. *We* understand that our kids sometimes act much (much, much) younger than their biological age. Some days this translates to a nine-year-old throwing an epic ADHD meltdown in the snack aisle. To a casual observer, this may look like just another brat kid going all Veruca Salt for Tostitos.

But take those deep breaths you always tell your kid to take.

Who matters in this situation: Your kid, or those people who freely give out judgment but no grace? Look, you would not want to be friends with Judgey McJudger-son. When *you* see a parent with a kid melting down, you make eye contact. You give them a teensy smile. It’s like a little fist bump of neurodiverse solidarity: *You got this. I’m on your side.*

Of course, people like you never appear when your kid is having an ADHD meltdown, but whatever.

We have a word for those people muttering at you when your kid loses it. They’re called bullies. We’ve all been there. We have seen a child have an ADHD meltdown in the most embarrassing places: at church, at our in-laws’ Thanksgiving dinner

table, at a crowded playdate. We've learned how to deal. It's not easy and it's not fun. But you can do it.

1. **Don't take it personally.** As your child screams, remember that they are not really screaming at you. It looks like it. It feels like it. But this ADHD meltdown has its cause in brain chemistry, not your parenting failure. Give yourself permission to remember that. Silently and frantically repeating "This is not my fault" might help at first.
2. **Name the most important person in this situation.** Hint: It's your kid. And as much as you might wish, in that moment, that you were not their parent, you are, and it's your job to help them calm down. You know how to do that. You do it all the time.
3. **Disregard the bullies.** Your kid is now yelling in your face. They are getting louder. The background muttering begins. Name the people who are not important in this situation—the bullies who are not helping.
4. **Focus on your child.** Think of Taylor Swift's "Shake It Off": *Haters gonna hate, hate, hate, hate, hate/ Baby I'm just gonna shake, shake, shake, shake, shake/ Shake it off.* If necessary, begin singing under your breath. This step will actually regulate your breathing and have some kind of regulatory psychological effect. Or something.
5. **Ignore Judgey McJudgerson's eyes on you.** It's tempting to proclaim, "YOU ARE HAVING AN ADHD MELTDOWN. LET'S PRACTICE OUR BREATHING." But that won't make the bullies feel bad or stop judging. They might not believe ADHD exists, and if they do, they obviously don't care enough to understand it. So don't mortify your kid that way. They're having a hard enough time already.
6. **Do what you know works.** Calm your kid, all the while telling yourself these people don't matter. Remain in triage mode, sing your Taylor Swift, and sweep victoriously past the haters. You have successfully negotiated an ADHD meltdown while ignoring parental judgement from all sides! High-five! Good job! Gold star for the day!
7. **Carry on.** Once you have your kid calmed, finish whatever task you were trying to accomplish. Remember: triage mode.
8. **Go home.** Pawn your kid off on your partner. If that's not possible, wait until bedtime. Find a quiet place. Give yourself permission to feel all those bad feelings about failure and sadness and why can't my kid be like other kids and why does he have to melt down next to the salsa and why do I always look like The Worst Parent Ever™? Quietly lose it. It's okay.

9. Take one of those deep breaths your kid refuses to take. Sing a bar of Taylor Swift. You love your kid. *None of this means you don't love your kid.* It's okay to wish for normal sometimes, because when you step back, you wouldn't trade your child for any other on planet Earth. Imagine a mom or dad giving you a teensy smile. Imagine that standing behind you are all of the other parents reading this article right now. We're saying: *We've been there. It's okay. You got this.*

People who have neurotypical children and plenty of judgment to spread around will always mutter at you. But you're doing a great job. It doesn't feel like it when your kid is shrieking, and people are staring and you want to sink into a shelf full of Cheetos. Having a neurodiverse kid is hard, and these people only make your life harder.

Here's a great secret, though: *They can only make your life harder if you let them.* Their bullying sucks and it hurts. But remember, mid-meltdown, who's the real priority? Sing your Taylor Swift. Then sweep past them like a runway model. They could not calm a child in the midst of an ADHD meltdown. They would wither under their own judgment. You are strong.

Haters gonna hate.

You got this.

“Why You Lash Out—Sometimes for No Good Reason”

By Sandy Maynard, M.S.

Do you lash out when your spouse reminds you—nicely—to take out the dog or pick up a gallon of milk? Do you fly off the handle when the boss asks you to turn in the next assignment on time? Have you wondered, “Why am I always angry?”

I know many people who do, including myself. In fact, many of us adults with ADHD lack restraint when we think that someone is dissing us. The question is: Are they? Because many of us have low self-esteem—after years of negative interactions—we are hypersensitive to criticism, real or imagined.

Bursts of anger have repercussions that last much longer than the few seconds it takes to vent. Having an argument in the workplace can get you fired. Blowing up at a loved one can strain the relationship. And it all takes a toll on your self-esteem—bringing remorse or shame for days afterward.

Is Anger a Symptom of ADHD in Adults?

My client, Mike, came to me to learn some anger-management strategies after he realized his ADHD tantrums had damaged his relationship with his teenage son, who, like Mike, has ADHD. Mike had long believed that “getting the anger out of [his] system” was healthy.

Until now. “My outbursts are creating a rift between me and my son that doubling his allowance won’t repair,” he told me. “I need to figure out how to keep anger in check—or I may make front-page news for strangling my son!”

I explained that most teens know which buttons to press because they installed them. After a good laugh, we identified the times when Mike was most likely to lose his temper—after a tough day at work when he had screwed up an assignment. When he came home to find that his son hadn’t taken out the garbage—again—Mike got upset. If his son had a fender bender, received a parking ticket, or cut out of school early, Mike blew his lid.

Help, Don’t Yell

I reminded Mike that he must maintain realistic expectations about his son, who was easily distracted. Mike came to see that neither he nor his son was perfect and that he should adjust his own imperfect behavior. Instead of yelling at his teen for forgetting to do a chore, Mike worked on helping him remember to do it by posting a list on a bulletin board in the kitchen and reinforcing it with text messages during the day.

If Mike’s son still forgot—or got into trouble at school—Mike learned to observe his rising anger and figured out ways to short-circuit it. He took a relaxing walk with his

dog and deferred discussions with his son until Saturday or Sunday morning when he felt refreshed and less pressured by his job. He and his son could talk calmly—and productively—during those chats.

Finally, Mike found comfort in a local ADHD support group for parents contending with similar problems. It is a great comfort to him to know that he isn't alone with his anger problems.

Another client, Karin, who was sweet and personable during her visits, surprised me when she told me she had problems managing her anger at work. Karin was furious with a co-worker who frequently blamed her for something that wasn't her fault.

Instead of talking with the co-worker or her immediate supervisor, she acted impulsively and went to the boss to defend herself. "Knowing that everyone thought it was my fault that the company lost the contract made me so angry," Karin says. "I felt I had to let Mr. James know that it wasn't."

We talked about a strategy that would let her indulge her anger without acting rashly. I suggested that Karin set a timer and let herself be angry for five minutes. After the time was up, she had to move on. I also had her place a visual cue next to her phone to remind her to pause before taking rash action—like calling the boss. She rummaged through her photos and found a snapshot of herself and her kids making sandcastles on the beach.

"Looking at the photo does two things for me when I get angry," Karin says. "It reminds me that my job is not as important as it seems. What counts most is my relationship with my family. It also reminds me that my happiness doesn't come from my job but from within—and that no co-worker or boss can take it away from me."

Karin still gets angry at work, so she has expanded her cuing strategy: She keeps a draft folder for emails labeled "Wait On." If she thinks she is sending email out of anger, she lets her message sit for 24 hours and re-reads it before hitting the send button. "Many of these emails never leave that folder. If I decide to send one, I edit out rude or inappropriate remarks before doing so."

And when she does slip up and says something that she regrets later? "I own up to my mistake and apologize." Not all of her apologies are accepted graciously, but saying she's sorry makes her feel better about herself. As a result, her relationship with her co-workers has improved dramatically.

“It Turns Out My Angry Child Needed a Worthy Challenge.”

By Theresa Cerulli, M.D., a psychiatrist at Beth Israel Deaconess Medical Center and the Neuroscience Education Institute

I remember the phone call from the psychologist who had completed my daughter's neuropsychological testing, “She's very bright, to the point that it's hard to accurately measure her IQ.” This sounded like good news. Then there was the “But...”

My seven-year-old daughter, who initially enjoyed the challenge of the testing, had become bored and frustrated and decided to end the session by throwing the large yoga ball she had been sitting on at the psychologist.

The exercise ball, intended to allow kids to move and focus during testing, was a projectile in my daughter's hands. The nice neuropsychologist chuckled, “I'm sure there have been other children in my office who thought about doing it, but your daughter is the first who did.”

There I was—a psychiatrist raising a child who hadn't yet started second grade but was now diagnosed with ADHD, anxiety, and anger management issues.

My Daughter Needs to Be Challenged

That was 10 years ago. We've come a long way since then. We were fortunate to have met many qualified doctors, therapists, teachers, and coaches on the journey. That psychologist was the first to tell me, “She needs to be challenged.”

It became our goal, and it led me to a wonderful parent-run organization called Destination Imagination (DI). DI is the world's largest creative problem-solving organization with about 200,000 children participating worldwide each year supported by more than 35,000 adult volunteers. The Destination Imagination program encourages teams of young learners to have fun, take risks, focus, and frame challenges while incorporating STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics), fine arts, writing, research, and service learning.

DI found ways to keep my daughter intellectually and physically challenged. We signed her up for taekwondo and girls' ice hockey. My task was to support her while redirecting her iron will. Destination Imagination helped me do that. Martial arts shaped her character. Somewhere between kicking a bag and breaking boards, she learned about honor and respect. She wasn't like her peers on the ice—she was short with a slight build. But her hockey coach said that she's “all heart, and she plays as if she is a foot taller. She doesn't know she's small.”

As for Destination Imagination, her team, full of “passionate” bright kids, fought with each other almost constantly for eight long years. Despite all the arguing, or perhaps somehow because of it, they earned a spot at the nationally hosted Global

Finals three times, competing with students worldwide. Then, in her final DI year, her team faltered during their performance and “lost.” But they walked across the convention center stage before 10,000 people, having stood out for their teamwork.

Be the Guardrails, Not the Driver

We too became a team at home, partners in managing her ADHD. Besides keeping her challenged, my new mantra became “Be the guardrails, not the driver.” Knowing about the frightening statistics about ADHD and car accidents, I was nervous when she obtained her driver’s license and first summer job. But I didn’t grab the wheel; she’s coping.

With the encouragement of her ADHD coach, she asks me, “Mom, can you get me a clock for the bathroom?” Done. I synced our phones with the family schedule, then she stunned me by asking for paper calendars for her room and the kitchen. Really? I asked. She explained, “When I scroll a schedule on my phone, I end up down a rabbit hole.”

My daughter is now 16 and still has ADHD and anxiety. It may never change, but it is well-managed. Perhaps I learned as much as she did from Destination Imagination. Sometimes what we fear as a loss is really a win; it’s what you make of the journey. Just ask my daughter.

Here is the quote she chose from a movie about Alan Turing to post at her middle school graduation, “Sometimes it is the people no one imagines anything of who do the things that nobody can imagine.”

“When Your Anger Rears Its Ugly Head”

By Stacey Turis

It was one of those mornings. A thread of annoyance was pulsing through my body. I know that feeling, and when it's there, nothing good comes from it.

I kept myself in check while getting the kids ready for school. We had done the entire song and dance, and all that was left was breakfast. Even on a good day, breakfast raises my anxiety levels. I live with a couple of miniature lollygaggers that either won't stop talking, insist on taking little, tiny bites, refuse to sit in a chair, or all of the above at the same time.

After repeating myself over and over, I finally lost it. I had a big bottle of vitamins in my hand, which I started slamming against the counter with each syllable I spoke. “Shove. The. Food. In. Your. Mouth. Be. Fore. I. Flip. The. Freak. Out!” Apparently, the tantrum looked hilarious, because the kids looked at each other for half a second before they burst out laughing. Wrong answer, kids.

I felt anger instantly scream through my body, and, without warning, my arm shot back and then forward as I launched the vitamin bottle as hard as I could toward the counter. It torpedoed the newly brewed pot of coffee. Shards of glass from the pot, along with hot coffee, rained down on most of the kitchen, including my white cabinets.

I was so shocked by what had occurred, that it was my turn to get the giggles. I doubled over in laughter. The poor kids didn't find it as amusing. The tears rushed to their eyes, and their eyes were huge after seeing Mommy do what she had always threatened: Flipping the freak out. I ran to the eating area, apologized, hugged them, and apologized some more—everything a good parent does after traumatizing their children. But I still felt like a big jerk for the rest of the day, especially after finding out the kids had reenacted the scene to teachers, kids, the principal, and the guidance counselor.

Bouts of anger or rage are fairly common among individuals with ADHD. For one thing, we feel things more intensely, so we react more intensely. Throw in some anxiety, a little depression, maybe some overwhelm, and you aren't looking at someone that runs at the baseline of “just chillin'.”

When we don't have time to lock down our emotions, and the inevitable happens, the most important thing is to not waste time beating ourselves up—we have more urgent things to attend to.

Apologize

First, apologize to any innocent bystanders who happened to witness the fit. Sweet “sorry” goes down a lot smoother than bitter blame. Though people with ADHD

operate at a more intense level, we still need to be accountable for our actions. That's how we prepare better for the next round.

Clean Up

If you made a mess during your hissy fit, immediately clean it up, or patch the wall, or replace the door hinge—whatever needs to be done to get the environment back to normal. You don't need a hole in the door to remind you of the time you acted like a wild person at the breakfast table.

Understand

After you've cleaned up the physical environment, it's time to work on your mental environment. Think about the factors that contributed to the angry outburst. Is it hormones? Stress from work? Being overwhelmed? Get to the root of the anger and figure out what steps can be taken to relieve some of the pressure.

It's also a good idea to replay the whole ugly scenario. Don't wallow in it; just try to understand what you might have been able to do to prevent it. As for me, I should have left the room when I heard my voice getting louder and deeper. That's my "crap-about-to-hit-the-fan" voice. Now I recognize it and remove myself from the conflict as soon as I start to sound like Barry White's third cousin.

Forgive

We need to forgive ourselves and move forward. Period. I love this quote from Maya Angelou: "I don't know if I continue, even today, always liking myself. But what I learned to do many years ago was to forgive myself. It is very important for every human being to forgive herself or himself, because if you live, you will make mistakes—it is inevitable. But once you do and you see the mistake, then you forgive yourself and say, 'Well, if I'd known better, I'd have done better,' that's all."

See? If you and I had known better, you and I would have done better—and the next time we will.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Karen Barrow; Alan P. Brown; Theresa Cerulli, M.D.; Terry M. Dickson, M.D., ACG, CPCC; Edward Hallowell, M.D.; Leslie Josel; Sandy Maynard, M.S.; Joel Nigg, Ph.D.; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; Les Steed; and Stacey Turis.

CHAPTER 4

Stop Overwhelm and Stress from Controlling Your Life

Chapter 4: Stop Overwhelm and Stress from Controlling Your Life

Recognizing the Stressors That Paralyze ADHD Brains

By Jerome Schultz, Ph.D.

Two facts: All people do not worry about the same things in the same way. What one person thinks of as a small problem may be perceived by another person as an intense stressor. We face life's stressors in different ways, depending on our health, our age, our temperament, and our previous experiences. In terms of our ability to face danger and manage stress, we range in character from "Navy SEALs" to "Nervous Nellies."

The second fact is that people who have ADHD are not all alike. Many exhibit the typical symptoms associated with the condition, but not everyone has all these symptoms. The severity of the symptoms ranges from mild (with little negative impact) to severe (with significant impact). Let's examine the interplay between behavioral characteristics and the neurobiological differences associated with ADHD, and the stress caused by the intense events that affect our lives today.

Stressors and Emotional Regulation

People with ADHD often find it hard to regulate emotions because their brains are different from other people's. New stressors trigger negative emotions associated with past events. A person with ADHD who has been laid low by the "typical" flu may mix those memories with the threat of COVID-19, increasing their worry. Those individuals without ADHD might think, "Well, this is the flu, and that was something different," and not let emotional memories fuel the fear.

Many people with ADHD have a lifetime of making impulsive errors, forgetting things, losing jobs, failing tests, or feeling like they were underperforming. Such negative emotional experiences build up over time and can “hardwire” the brain to be always on the lookout for danger. New threats appear much more serious than they really are.

How Stressors Impact ADHD Brains

If people with ADHD are generally under more stress, it follows that they will face the world with an increased level of stress. Here’s why: Stress activates the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal (HPA) axis. This creates a cascade of hormones, including catecholamines, corticotropin-releasing hormones, and cortisol (a biochemical indicator of stress). This elegant biological response is designed to keep the body safe in dangerous situations. During such reactions, the body diverts blood away from the stomach (Who needs to digest food when you’re running from a rhino?), and to the leg muscles (All the better to outrun it with!).

Blood is also re-routed from the pre-frontal cortex, the part of the brain behind our forehead that helps us weigh the facts and problem-solve using executive functions. (Don’t think about this! Just run!) Researchers have found that, in stressful situations, adults with ADHD have higher levels of cortisol than people without the diagnosis. Merely thinking about stressful situations raises the level of cortisol in their body. Too much cortisol is not a good thing. It’s supposed to be manufactured and used at the moment to get us out of harm’s way. But the stressors in our contemporary lives do not attack in a quick strike like a wild animal. The negative event doesn’t hit and run; it keeps threatening us. It comes at us over and over again in the news, on TV, or in our social media feeds. It is a chronic condition.

Stress-impaired executive function diminishes working memory and impulse control, as well as mental flexibility and coping skills. Stress also makes it hard for people with ADHD to focus and sustain their attention. When we consider the overwhelming amount of information that is streamed into our homes (and heads), we realize the importance of focus. Chronic stress prolongs the protective flow of hormones and causes the brain to recalibrate its biochemistry. It can’t handle all this bad news! (This is the “hardwiring” that I mentioned earlier.) Looked at in this way, unless individuals with ADHD understand what’s going on in their brains, and learn to monitor and control their stress reaction, having ADHD can impair the way they cope with crises.

How to Cope with Stressors with ADHD

The best predictor of how you deal with challenging times is how you have handled stressful situations in the past. When you search the Internet, you’ll have no trouble finding advice about reducing stress. There are literally thousands of articles suggesting warm baths, yoga, meditation, prayer, exercise, eating healthy and staying hydrated,

staying connected to friends through technology, and so on. If any of these have worked for you in the past, use them.

ADHD Tips for Coping with Stressors

Think (yes, right now!) about what you, a person with ADHD, do naturally, without anyone bugging you or guilt-tripping you, to have fun and find pleasure and relief from stress. Maybe you thought of things that were exciting enough to capture and hold your attention, that were thrilling, risky, or—if you're honest—even a little dangerous. To gain a sense of control over things, get your hormones flowing, stimulate your brain in healthy ways, and stay healthy, the following tips might help:

1. **Keep moving.** Run or walk (in your living room, on a treadmill, up and down stairs, on the street).
2. **Play video games.** Especially exciting ones that challenge you. I recommend race car driving or space exploration over “shooter” games, but that's your choice.
3. **Follow medical advice.** If you're taking medication for ADHD, follow your doctor's orders, and make sure you have enough on hand. These meds maintain a healthy balance of chemicals in your brain.
4. **Get unreal.** Get yourself a virtual reality headset (you can get the functional fold-out one for under \$5), pop your phone into it, and “go” where you want. Your brain will love it. Set a 30-minute timer and give your eyes and brain a rest. The chemicals you're generating can be addictive for a brain that doesn't produce enough on its own.
5. **Listen to music that “rocks” you,** whatever your musical tastes. Dance if the spirit moves you. The parts of your ADHD brain that register stress and put you in fight-or-flight mode don't operate when you're listening to music. Singing with the music or humming along will add to your pleasure.
6. **Mega-clean** your room, apartment, or entire house. If you're the kind of person who gets in a “zone” while cleaning, this will be a win-win. It will activate the health-oriented parts of your brain, disinfect your surroundings, and give you a sense of accomplishment. You'll be in control, a state that wards off anxiety.
7. **Make stuff, write stuff, cook stuff.** Find some short-term projects for which you have the materials and skills to successfully complete—painting, song or poetry writing, crafting, baking—things that produce a tangible product you will be proud to show to or share with others. The human brain craves success. It is wired to remember failure because it doesn't want us to repeat it. Science tells us that it takes three successful experiences to make up for one failure.

8. **Binge-watch TV.** The more exciting the show, the more your brain is activated. But watch only what you like; otherwise, the boredom buzzer will go off. Choose shows with short episodes. Surf to keep it interesting.
9. **Read some good news.** Or at least alternate some good news with the bad. You should skip the obituary page.
10. **Tickle your funny bone.** Watch comedy shows or listen to comedy podcasts. A joke is a good neuro-fix. It's biochemically impossible for a laughing brain to worry.
11. **Ommm.** Your brain shouldn't be kept on high alert all the time, no matter how much it craves novel experiences. If you give it a break with yoga (or a nap), it can reset before turning on the steam again.

Jerome Schultz, Ph.D., is a clinical neuropsychologist on the faculty at Harvard Medical School in the Department of Psychiatry.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

A Get-Things-Done Guide for the Overwhelmed and Overloaded

You can't hide from your to-do list forever. Use these 11 strategies for decluttering, managing paper, overcoming distractions, and getting things done.

Every day we're confronted with information, distractions, work, and more. Is it a surprise anyone gets anything done, never mind those with ADHD? People with ADHD are easily overwhelmed by the fast pace and interruptions, so they need some stay-focused strategies to keep them on track. Consider this your guide.

Capture All That Information

Instead of going crazy trying to write down all those bits of information that come your way, try these solutions:

- Call important information into your voicemail and leave yourself messages. Your smartphone's voice recorder app can also come in handy for this.
- Convert verbal information into text, using apps like Google Keep and Evernote (evernote.com).

Finish Something, Anything, Early in the Day

Completing a chore—a small task or something larger that you worked on yesterday—gives you a sense of closure, making the rest of the day meaningful. No matter how the day goes, you can say you got something done, which gives you a sense of satisfaction that will encourage you to keep going tomorrow.

Get a Grip

If a phone call or a request from your spouse or partner distracts you from a task you're working on, hold on to a physical artifact to remind you of what you were doing. An unopened envelope, for instance, will remind you that you were opening mail before the interruption and will refocus your attention more quickly.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Put It on the Calendar

It's not enough to write down a task on your to-do list. You have to enter it into your calendar (paper or digital). Assigning a task to a specific day increases your chances of completing it. With a to-do list only, you have a 40% to 50% chance of doing the task. Scheduling the task increases your chances of completing it to 70% or more.

Just Do It

Don't get overwhelmed about where or when to start a decluttering task. It doesn't matter where you start; begin at any spot in a room. After you start, continue in some kind of logical order. If you start on the left side of the room, keep going left. If you start on the top shelf of a cabinet, work your way down. There is no ideal time to tackle clutter.

Change the Scene

People with ADHD can optimize their focus and attention by doing different tasks in different kinds of places. If you have to do your taxes, rent a room in a local hotel for a day or two. You can spread out all the papers and receipts, with fewer distractions than at home. Or find a setting like a coffee shop with some background noise.

Enlist a Support Team

Stop trying to be an ordinary person who keeps it together in the same way as people without ADHD. Support might mean another set of hands, someone to keep your morale up, or someone to function as a body double. (Someone who is physically present as you do a task but doesn't do the task with you.)

Switch Up Your Routine Every Quarter

People with ADHD get bored with their routines quicker than those without the condition. The higher boredom factor keeps them from tackling things they once completed with ease. Routines—whether opening mail, doing dishes, or tackling a work project—can be kept fresh by changing them up every three months. This doesn't mean a complete overhaul, just a tweak.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Play It Loose with Deadlines

Schedule extra time to finish a task. Rather than trying to precisely estimate how long a task will take, just say, “Screw it. I need 30% more time for everything I plan, no matter what.” Just pick a number: 20% more, 50% more, and plan for that. The worst that could happen is that you finish it early.

Keep Calm and Carry On

As you start your day, do the first three things that worry you the most to get them off your plate. The internal distraction of worry plays more on people with ADHD than on neurotypical people and prevents them from getting things done. If you do any small part of what is worrying you, you may break the anxiety and move forward.

Manage the Mail

- To cut off junk mail at its source, log on to catalogchoice.org and have them alert marketers to stop sending you stuff.
- Pick one place for the mail to land, maybe the dining room table. Yes, it piles up quickly, but at least you know where it will be when you decide to tackle it.
- Don't open junk mail. It can contain four to seven pieces of paper. Junk mail goes, unopened, right into the recycling bin.

This article was written by Judith Kolberg, who is credited with launching the field of professional organizing dedicated to addressing the needs of individuals who are chronically disorganized (CD).

10 Ways to Bring Calm and Organization Back Into Your Daily Life

By Paul Hammerness, M.D., and Margaret Moore

As most adults with ADHD have learned, moments of forgetfulness and disorganization can have major consequences. Just one morning of misplaced keys can set your whole day off kilter, leaving you feeling overwhelmed and struggling to catch up. But, just as one episode of forgetfulness can trigger a series of negative events, one small step forward can lead to giant leaps of improvement in the organization of your life. Here are some solutions that could start you down a new path.

Get Ready for Lift-Off

Create a launch pad for your daily essentials—a place where you always put your keys, wallet, glasses, cell phone, etc. You'll know that's the place those items will always be, and every morning that's where you'll launch your day. The launch pad is a simple solution, but its effects go far beyond knowing the location of your keys. You will be less stressed before you leave the house in the morning, and you'll enter a new environment more relaxed and thinking more clearly.

Be Mindful of Absentmindedness

When we lose our mindfulness—meaning our complete presence and attention to the task at hand—it feels like we're losing our minds. For example, when we set down our keys, we're already on to the next task and don't notice where we left them. The first step on the path to regaining mindfulness is to build awareness. Notice when you are mindful or when you've lost mindfulness and write it down to analyze later.

Practice Being Mindful

Analyze your notes and think about what percent of the time you are mindful and present in the moment. Perhaps you're at 50%. Where do you want to get to and by when? Set a goal and practice being mindful. For example, "This week I will be mindful about where I put my phone. I will take a few seconds to consider where to store it in my work bag or pocket and to notice when I'm placing it. Next week, I'll work on my keys."

Overcome Distractibility

To overcome distractibility, you need to develop a two-step brain pattern:

1. Evaluate the incoming information.

2. Shift back to the present if the information isn't urgent or jump off and focus on new information if it is a high priority.

A helpful way to do this is to rate the urgency and importance of each new message or input. Give it a rating of 1-10. Anything seven and over demands immediate attention. Anything four or below can probably be ignored for the time being.

Beat the Clock

Always running late may be a sign that your commitments are beyond your personal bandwidth. If so, consider the following suggestions to conquer habitual lateness: Write down a list of your commitments—daily, weekly, monthly. Determine if some can be jettisoned, delegated, or reduced. Prevent over-scheduling by learning to say no. Reduce your list of regular commitments by at least 10%.

Give Yourself Daily Downtime

Lateness and forgetfulness may be signs that you need some downtime to restore calm and balance and to increase brain function. Try 10 to 15 minutes a day of a repetitive, mindful activity (deep breathing, meditation, yoga). You can do it in the morning to start the day with calm footing or in the late afternoon. Use this time to adjust your emotional balance and check negative thoughts at the door.

Forget About Multitasking

Don't fret about your inability to multitask; research shows it isn't effective. Each task, brief or otherwise, is best done with your full attention. Bring your entire consciousness to each task and make a clear break—a mental transition—between tasks. Don't let the previous task or a future task infect the current one. When you bring your full presence to a task, time slows down and expands, and much can get done in small moments.

Schedule Interruption-Free Zones

If you feel like you can't get ahead because of the constant demands on your time, schedule interruption-free zones during the most productive times each day. Start with 15 minutes, then build up over time. Practice not looking at texts, emails, or calls when you're in an interruption-free zone. Then, when you need a break, schedule a 20-minute zone to deal with these interruptions. Enjoy the sense of control that comes from not responding in a knee-jerk fashion.

Practice Positive Thinking

Stress caused by distraction and disorganization can lead to an overall deterioration of physical and mental health. Turn priorities upside down and take care of your health first. It will give you more energy, balance, and calm to accomplish things. To reduce stress, take a few moments each week to review the good things in your life. This may sound trite, but it will help you shift to a more positive footing.

Shift Your Mental Picture

Ever have a nagging sense that you are teetering on the edge, and all it will take is one more task to send you plummeting into chaos? Change that thinking pattern by saying, “I’m doing a good job; I’m keeping my cool and balance despite the risk of going over the edge.” Shift your mental picture from one of you trembling on the precipice to you confidently walking along the edge, filled with the promise of discovery. Yes, that’s you, on your way to great new things. Enjoy the view!

Paul Hammerness, M.D., is a Harvard Medical School psychiatrist. Margaret Moore is the founder of Wellcoaches Corporation. They are the co-authors of Organize Your Mind, Organize Your Life.

How to Stop Catastrophizing: A Guide for ADHD Worriers

By Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Worrying isn't necessarily bad, but it can be bothersome and even debilitating. Sometimes, it can be motivating. Worrying about submitting your homework, getting to work on time, or charging your phone are examples of productive worrying. Productive worriers are forward thinkers who devise creative solutions and plans to address likely outcomes.

The flip side is poisonous or toxic worry—worrying about things you can't control, like thunderstorms, plane crashes, whether people like you, etc. This catastrophic thinking replays in your brain over and over again. It leads to discomfort. Toxic worriers have trouble sleeping; they feel exhausted or agitated; they get headaches or nausea; they avoid living fully.

The Worrying-Anxiety Connection

Anxiety arises when you over-respond to fear or worry. It is physiological. Anxiety may cause uncomfortable bodily states, such as stomach pains or chest tightness, headaches, dry mouth, or hot palms. Anxiety also comes with a psychological component (distorted beliefs and/or negative expectations) and an emotional facet (fear, dread).

Anxiety has helped us survive as a species. It's been adaptive over the centuries and helps our bodies prepare for real danger. When facing a tiger about to pounce around the bend in a forest, our muscles tightened, and our breath became shallow. We were ready to flee or fight, and sometimes we also froze, perhaps becoming someone's dinner. But today, anxiety is rarely caused by an approaching tiger. While there may be genuine concerns in unsafe situations, often our anxiety is a false alarm: an overreaction to the danger itself. That late-night email from your boss may not be a hungry tiger, but it will still set off a series of distress signals in your brain and body that make you think like there is one.

There's a real difference between a perceived danger and a real threat. A true danger is a speeding car heading your way as you cross the street. You notice it and jump back on the curb just in time to avoid a collision. Perceived danger is based on a negative expectancy without grounding in reality: You see a tiny spider crawling on the ceiling. It could crawl down ten feet and another six feet across the floor, up your leg, and bite you. You could die from this imagined spider bite because you think, without any facts, that the spider is deadly. Negative expectancy and all-or-nothing thinking are common in people with ADHD due to a common symptom: emotional dysregulation. However, you can learn to unravel these perceptions and stop catastrophizing. To start, identify if a worry is productive or toxic.

Toxic Worry vs. Productive Worry

Productive worry can help you solve problems and focus your energy on useful ideas. For example, my husband is a productive worrier who uses backward design to get us to the airport in plenty of time for our flights.

But productive worry can go awry, which happened once when my husband and I were at the end of a beautiful vacation spent at Glacier National Park in Montana. We were heading to the airport, and I asked if we could pick up lunch.

“It’s 11:45 a.m., and our plane leaves at 1:45 p.m. We have time because this airport is quite small,” I said.

“We don’t have time,” my husband said. He was so worried about missing the flight that he began speeding, and we got pulled over by a police officer. Luckily, the police officer did not give us a speeding ticket. But the interaction wasted precious minutes and distressed us both. Nonetheless, much to his chagrin, I insisted on picking up lunch, and we still had plenty of time at the airport.

It doesn’t take much for productive worry to transform into toxic worry. While productive worry focuses more on controlling a situation, toxic worry makes you feel vulnerable. I am a combination worrier: sometimes productive (Will I turn this article in on time? I better!) and sometimes toxic (Will my Facebook Live event have helpful conversations? Will my daughter who lives 3,000 miles away get their flu vaccine?) While I can control and influence my actions to address my productive worry, there’s nothing I can do about my toxic worry. I have to acknowledge my concerns and then let them go. This, of course, is much easier said than done.

Three Ways to Stop Catastrophizing

To shift toxic worry into something productive, you need to first recognize that you are catastrophizing. This happens when your brain’s amygdala (the fight, flight, or freeze organ in the limbic system—the emotional region) figuratively takes over your thinking brain (your prefrontal cortex) by activating adrenaline and cortisol. Your entire being is focused on obtaining safety and feeling secure. Basically, the part of you that runs from tigers and steps aside from racing cars begins controlling all your responses.

1. Dismantle the “What-Ifs”

To regain control, turn down the volume on your catastrophic thinking by remembering past successes, tools, interventions, and statements you’ve used to overcome perceived dangers. When I’m in a “what-if” spiral, I shift my thinking to “What could go right?”

Follow your “what-ifs” to the end of the line. Ask yourself, “What if this happened? And then what? And what if that happened? And then what?” Keep going until there’s some resolution. Can you live with that resolution?

Try to consider best-case outcomes in addition to worst-case scenarios. What might happen that could be positive? Can I predict any happiness instead of pain?

2. Set Up a Buddy System

Toxic worry intensifies in isolation. So, set up a buddy system with someone you trust who can offer a different perspective. Who could you call or text if you’re in a poisonous worry spiral? Do you have a therapist, coach, or counselor? Whether you are concerned about perfectionism, personal relationships, or sociopolitical injustices, who could be your ally in these dark moments?

3. Create a Plan

Come up with a plan for escaping your next spiral. Make a list of self-soothing actions to take when worry rears its ugly head. Post it somewhere accessible, like on your phone or sticky notes at home. Your plan can include settle-me-down phrases, such as “I’m afraid, and I know how to be brave,” or “Things work out, keep breathing.” It can also contain a list of activities to slow your reactivity, such as drinking a glass of water, walking outside, cuddling a pet, getting a hug, etc. Here are some more ideas:

- **Exercise.** Daily exercise pumps up your endorphins, which bathe your brain with good feelings. When I wake up feeling “ugh,” a run or bike ride gets me out of my negative headspace.
- **Create a playlist.** Categorize songs into different playlists on your phone, label them “angry songs,” “sad songs,” “happy songs,” “how-to-stop-worrying songs,” etc.
- **Practice mindfulness** to interrupt the pattern of negative thinking. Meditate. Do yoga. Listen to the birds. Drink a cup of tea. Do a crossword puzzle. Play Wordle.
- **Try triangle breathing.** Breathe in for four counts, hold for four counts, and exhale slowly for six counts. Do several rounds of this.

Ultimately, the best intervention for catastrophizing is one that releases your toxic worries back into the wild so that you no longer carry them. Poisonous worry says, “Something bad could happen, and you can’t handle it.” Instead of listening to or agreeing to this noise, say, “I’ve got this. I can hold onto my courage and move forward.”

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Simplify Your Life: 7 Habits That Bring Calm and Stability

The ADHD brain craves stimulation, and often performs well amid bursts of chaos and pressure. But when stress and external pressure continuously build, our brains freeze up. To reset your brain, you must simplify your life. Here's how.

ADHD brains often gravitate to the complicated and frenzied. Emergencies spike up dopamine flow, keeping the mind engaged and at the ready. In other words, many of us absolutely thrive in moments of pressure.

But what happens when life gives us too many fires to extinguish, one after the other? We shut down. The ADHD brain is pushed to its limits when life's demands pile on with no end in sight. Ongoing overwhelm keeps the brain in high-alert mode, quickly depleting its resources and causing mental fog. To free up mental bandwidth, we have to streamline our lives wherever possible.

In this era of “more”—more worries, more grief, more things, and more people to manage at home—take these steps to simplify your life for a mental and emotional reset.

How to Simplify Your Life

Step #1: Take a Six-Second Pause

Stress and overwhelm cause us to respond irrationally, and sometimes unnecessarily, to situations. These knee-jerk outbursts begin in the brain. It takes about six seconds for the prefrontal cortex, the “rational brain,” to receive information and “kick in” after the amygdala, the brain's emotional processor, senses a stressful situation.

But stress inhibits prefrontal cortex functioning—as does ADHD. Add in a sensitive amygdala (also due to stress), and situations that are normally tolerable are perceived as too much, causing the amygdala to take over and “hijack” the brain before the rational part can step in.

To counter this, you have to force yourself to take a six-second pause when confronted with a stressful scenario. More than that, you must “distract” the amygdala to give your rational brain enough time to think and respond appropriately. How? By thinking complex thoughts. Some ideas include:

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

- Try to list six cities that begin with the letter “P” (or a similar activity)
- Alphabetize or otherwise rearrange a fixed or known series of items (like naming the Seven Dwarfs in alphabetical order)
- Practice scattered counting (i.e., counting that doesn’t follow any order)

Step #2: Learn to Say No

Many of us with ADHD have a self-defeating habit of over-committing. We’re first to volunteer, to run errands, and to put ourselves behind.

Saying “no” is hard for us because we’re people-pleasers—and that comes from a lifetime of feeling like we disappoint others and ourselves. But agreeing to everything only leads to more overwhelm, and more disappointment. To counter this, practice saying no with integrity. Here are some ways:

- “I so appreciate you thinking of me, but I won’t be able to help this time.”
- “That sounds like a wonderful opportunity, but I cannot make it work.”
- “I know I couldn’t do it justice, and I don’t want to let you down, so I have to decline.”
- “I’m really trying to balance my commitments, so I can’t add anything else right now.”

Sometimes, we are the hardest people to say “no” to. We add more and more to our full schedules (without anyone prompting us), and we burn out. Before taking on more, ask yourself:

- I am already using every minute of my life (it’s true!). What will I need to give up to make time for this?
- How important is this? Have I wanted this for a long time, or is it a new impulse?
- In my aim for simplicity, does this activity help me reach this goal, or is it another distraction?

Step #3: Rein in Nonstop Thoughts

The ADHD mind rarely stops. Stress and problems are the perfect gateway for rumination, where we obsess over the issue and try to find answers. We can tell when we’re in a never-ending thought spiral if we’re tense, worried, irritable, and overly emotional.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

The antidote to autopilot thoughts is to disengage and pay attention to the mind, a practice otherwise known as mindfulness. Many mindfulness exercises work to calm the ADHD brain or zap you back into the present. Here are some to try:

- **Thought stopping:** When in a rut, pay attention to exactly what you're thinking about, and stop it in its tracks. You can do this by saying (preferably aloud) "STOP!" or "CANCEL!" Some people also wear a rubber band on their wrist and snap it when a ruminating thought appears.
- **Repetition:** Our minds especially wander when we're engaged in mindless activities, like washing the dishes, cooking, or cleaning. In these moments, repeat to yourself the activity that you're doing so that you stay in the present—"I'm washing the mug. I'm washing the mug."

Remember that the goal of mindfulness is not to completely stop a wandering mind (that may be impossible with ADHD). There is always a benefit to noticing our thoughts.

Besides mindfulness, seek other activities that boost feel-good energy and help keep you calm, like dance (or another exercise), yoga, quality time with a loved one, drawing, listening to music, or simply lighting a scented candle.

Step #4: Clear Physical Clutter

Physical clutter creates mental clutter. Ensuring that our spaces are kept clear of clutter calms the brain, allowing us to live a much more present and simple life. To tackle clutter:

- **Acknowledge it.** We often hide from the mess by ignoring or downplaying the mountain in front of us. We can't confront the problem if we don't accept that one is there—so start acknowledging it! Take note of the piles around you and get things off the floor to prevent accidents.
- **Narrow your focus.** Even if there are multiple spaces to tackle, start with one. Schedule a specific time to start cleaning, and do not exceed two hours. Take three slow, deep breaths before starting. It's easiest to start by throwing out trash, and then focus on the items that have a home and need to be put away. Bills that need to be paid can follow, but don't stop the decluttering process to pay them or do anything else—simply stack or file the documents in order of importance.
- **Leave "breadcrumbs."** If you're interrupted or don't finish an entire section at once, leave notes and other reminders to yourself on your progress and next steps.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

- **Don't know what to do with some stuff?** Take note of the items and put them in a labeled box. If you can go an entire year without opening the box, that means you don't need what's inside, and can toss or donate the items.

Step #5: Get Better Sleep

A lack of replenishing sleep can impact our cognitive functioning, mood, ability to handle stress, and overall health. There can be no simple life without prioritizing a good night's sleep. Use these tips to troubleshoot sleep problems that commonly accompany ADHD:

- Have a bedtime and stick to it.
- Turn off electronic devices well before going to sleep.
- Use earplugs or a white noise machine to quiet the mind and drown out other distractions.
- Change out your pillow every one to two years. Adjust pillows as necessary for proper spine alignment.
- Consider replacing your mattress if you haven't done so in the past seven to 10 years.
- Use light-blocking curtains and eye masks.
- Keep the bedroom at comfortable temperatures for sleep. A cooler room is often better for slumber.

Step #6: Know Thyself

Cluttered, distracted lives have the added consequence of making us lose ourselves. Knowing who we are, where our strengths lie, and what fulfills us is crucial to simplifying our lives. These crucial bits of information bring meaning into our lives and grant us needed clarity to carve our hours, days, and paths forward.

If you've lost touch with yourself, find your way back by thinking about "core you" (save these in a journal!). If you are unsure what "core you" is, ask yourself:

- What do I represent?
- How can I be of service?
- What are my top five strengths?
- What do I love to do?

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Part of knowing yourself is also learning to trust yourself. Simplify the number of “experts” in your life—be it authors, podcast hosts, and other personalities—all of whom come with different agendas and instructions. No one knows you like you know you.

Step #7: Commit to Simplicity

Simplicity is a life-long commitment. As such, you must treat this like any goal, and plan for it.

- Set aside time, be it weekly or daily, for actions that support your vision. Invite yourself to take something out of your schedule, and replace it with mindfulness, an activity you love, or anything that keeps the bigger picture of simplicity in mind.
- Adults with ADHD tend to fall off the wagon after an initial commitment. That’s OK—find ways to remember your ultimate goal by using reminders (place sticky notes on the mirror, put notes in your phone, or have weekly check-ins).
- Support is essential. Find someone who believes in you—a coach, a friend, a mentor, a therapist, and/or a loved one. Ask them to reflect on your progress.

This article was written by Linda Roggli, PCC, a Professional Certified Coach, author and founder of the A-D-Diva Network for ADHD women 40-and-better.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar “Time to Reset: Simplify Your ADHD Life in the New Year,” with Linda Roggli, PCC.

Overstimulated by Life? Here's How to Give Your ADHD Senses a Break.

Is overstimulation a facet of daily life? Do you experience emotions and physical sensations intensely? Are you easily overwhelmed? Emotional dysregulation and sensitivity issues are common in adults with ADHD. Here, learn to manage and reduce sensory overload.

Feeling overstimulated? All the time?

Overstimulation is a daily reality for many people with ADHD. We feel too much—physically and emotionally. We struggle with emotional regulation, impulsivity, and big feelings. Many of us also experience sensory sensitivities, reacting strongly to sights, tastes, smells, and more. And when we're stressed, we feel everything more intensely.

Navigating sensory overload is exhausting. It impacts our sense of well-being—we don't seem to glide through life as easily as others do. And we never know what will trigger us on any given day.

The good news is there are plenty of ways to manage our sensitivities and lessen—or even prevent—sensory overload. Here are a few suggestions.

Overstimulation Strategies: How to Manage Physical and Emotional Sensitivities

The Basics

- **Gain awareness.** Educate yourself on hypersensitivity, ADHD, and sensory issues. It will be an ongoing process, but the more you understand these factors, the better you'll understand your own challenges.
- **Practice self-advocacy.** Learn to speak out, without shame, about your needs.
- **Share your sensitivities.** Explain your pain points so others in your life can adjust their expectations.
- **Lead a healthy lifestyle.** Nutritious foods, restful sleep, movement, mindfulness, and any activity that reduces stress and adds joy to your life will make it easier to

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

regulate your emotions. Keep these in check, and it might reduce your physical sensitivities and irritabilities, too.

- **Find support**, including professional help, to manage your hypersensitivities, ADHD, and lifestyle factors that may contribute to your challenges. A good therapist can help you build awareness around your triggers and provide coping tools.

For Touch

- **Wear non-itch fabrics** and tagless, seamless clothes (or remove tags).
- **Try on clothing**, while shopping or from your own closet, and pay attention to how you feel. Is the item too constricting? Does it itch in some places? What kind of fabrics feel the most comfortable to you? Put back or donate items that will cause trouble.

For Sound

- **Use a white noise machine** or whirring fan to block out distracting, annoying sounds at home or in the workplace.
- **Find a location you can escape to** if you need a break (e.g., the bathroom, a closet, or another part of the home/building), especially in triggering situations (like family reunions).
- **Avoid cafes and other noisy public places** or go during off-peak hours. If you're a regular in some locales, try asking the people who work there to turn down the music.

For Smell

- No-scent policies at work and elsewhere are *de rigueur*, so don't be afraid to **speak up** (discreetly if need be) about strong scents.
- **Consider using essential oils**. Essential oils and incense can help mask offensive smells and even soothe anxieties. Test your tolerance for these first.

For Taste

- **Be open and honest about your sensitivities** before accepting dinner invitations or entertainment outings. Your friends might be more understanding than you think. Remember, they invited you for your company, not to challenge your taste buds.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

For Emotions

- **Be aware of the situations that trigger your strong emotions.** Do your best to remove yourself from them or anticipate and avoid surprises.
- **Learn to identify the physical responses** that accompany emotions. Does your heart race? Does your chest tighten? Do you clench your fists or jaw? Are you suddenly jittery? Do you “shut down” for hours or days?
- **Use a journal or calendar** to keep track of the situations, contexts, and physical cues around your emotions, both good and bad. Do your emotions seem more heightened during a specific time of day? Before or after taking ADHD medication? On an empty stomach? When you’ve had a sleepless night? This will help you gain control over them.
- **Talk to friends and loved ones about ADHD** and how it impacts your ability to control emotions. Acknowledgment and awareness can go a long way.
- **Practice self-compassion.** It’s no good to beat yourself up if you lose control. Everyone does it from time to time. Apologize when needed and move on. This way, you’ll also model self-acceptance and self-forgiveness to those around you.

This article was written by Zoë Kessler, an author, journalist, and motivational speaker.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “Why ADHDers Are So Sensitive: The Reasons for It, The Strategies to Manage It,” with Zoë Kessler.

Overwhelmed Mom Syndrome— It's a Real Thing

Running a household is grueling enough without ADHD. Here are eight life-saving tips for parents with executive function deficits, lagging patience, and hardly enough time to read this.

Managing the home is one of the most unfriendly lines of work that anyone with ADHD could undertake.

But the multiple-task coordination required to keep a household functioning smoothly bumps directly against the executive-function difficulties inherent in ADHD. Adding to that is the pervasive gendered division of housework, where women are still expected to manage a household. This makes for a crisis of overwhelmed mothers with ADHD.

It is key to recognize the challenges on the domestic front, be realistic and forgiving of yourself and put organization systems in place to help you work around the difficulties.

Tough Work, Indeed

Consider the job description of homemaker and child caregiver: “You’re required to provide all the organization and structure for three or more people. Tasks are poorly defined, filled with distractions, and require constant multitasking. Because much of the work—including cooking, cleaning, and laundry—is boring, you must be able to function without needing a high level of interest or stimulation,” says Sari Solden, M.S., LMFT, a psychotherapist and author of *Women with Attention Deficit Disorder* and *Journeys Through ADDulthood* and co-author of *A Radical Guide for Women with ADHD*.

“Appearance is important as well,” Solden continues. “You must create an attractive household, attending to the details of décor and the children’s clothing. It is also important to maintain a calm demeanor while caring for children, who, by definition, have problems with attention and behavior.

“You’ll need to carefully structure their lives to give them the calm, supportive, organized home environment they need to succeed at school and with friends. Excellent calendar and scheduling skills are critical. You are required to prioritize without guidance, and

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

work without incentives, such as raises, bonuses, promotions, or even the support and company of co-workers.”

Would anyone with ADHD (or without, for that matter) apply for an impossible job like this?

Of course not.

Yet many women with ADHD remain determined to achieve these ideals, even though, as Lynn Weiss, Ph.D., notes in her book *Attention Deficit Disorder in Adults*, “an ordinary day for a woman is a nightmare for a woman with ADHD.”

Kathleen Nadeau, Ph.D., co-author of *ADD-Friendly Ways to Organize Your Life*, points out that mothers with ADHD “may be struggling valiantly with demands which are often difficult, if not impossible, to meet.” Women with ADHD, no matter how successful in other areas of life, struggle on the household front. They may ponder the “how to be a good mom” question and experience stress and a feeling of failure to measure up.

Take Control—Now

What to do? First, stop beating yourself up about ADHD patterns. Instead, create a household that can accommodate them. An ADHD-friendly house is easy to clean and keep in order—one that works for you and everyone else in the household. That means finding creative solutions to the daily challenges you face. Dr. Nadeau points out eight common problem areas below and offers innovative approaches for each. Good luck!

- 1. Need housework help?** Do whatever it takes to hire a cleaning person. Don’t immediately assume that you can’t afford such a service. If necessary, take on part-time employment just to pay for a cleaning person. Look at it this way: Housecleaning is a part-time job for which you are poorly suited. Why not take on a job in which you can excel?
- 2. Hate laundry?** Most individuals with ADHD do. Instead of letting laundry pile up, do one load every morning. Better yet, train the children to do their own. Can’t remember to sort, fold, and return clean laundry to the appropriate spots? Put out two baskets: one for clean clothes, the other for dirty clothes. Let household members find the clothes they need and deposit soiled ones in the designated basket.
- 3. Need a quick declutter?** Use the old garbage-bag trick. Get a big bag and drop unneeded items from every room into it.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

- 4. Mail building up?** Most ADHD households struggle with the daily influx of mail (mostly junk, interspersed with the occasional, carefully hidden important item). Stick to this simple mail-handling routine: Open the mail while standing next to the kitchen trashcan. Throw away junk mail immediately—or, better yet, drop it into a handy recycling basket. Then, place any bills (unopened) in one pile and important correspondence (which requires a response) in a second. Immediately take both piles to the desk where they “live”—the bills to the “bill-to-be paid” slot; and the correspondence to the pile for “action” items.
- 5. Need a home for newspapers and magazines?** Place a pretty recycling basket in the room where they are typically read. Toss in reading matter when you’ve finished with it. Another family member can easily find the magazine or newspaper they are looking for on the top of the pile.
- 6. Hunting for important items every morning?** Create a “ready-set-go” site in your home—this can be a small bookshelf, with hooks on the wall next to it. Place all items needed the next day—books, papers, clothes to take to the dry cleaners—on the shelves or hooks. Mount a bulletin board above the bookshelf, so you can tack up reminder slips: “Robby, dentist, 4:30 p.m., Tuesday.”
- 7. Redecorating or remodeling?** Take ADHD into account as you make decisions. A dark rug in front of the sink catches drips, and a hardwood floor hides crumbs and spots that would be glaringly evident on linoleum. Sponge-painted walls make a great fingerprint-hider.
- 8. Need peace and quiet?** Most ADHD households are lively, cluttered places. Not a problem, except for the fact that women with ADHD sometimes need to downshift for a few moments in a quiet space. Turn one room into a calm, visually appealing space where you can go to gather yourself. Make it a house rule that this room is for solitude or quiet conversation only—not a place to bicker, tease the dog, or argue with your mom.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Never Good Enough: The Emotional Toll of Motherhood

Here's why mothers with ADHD struggle more than their counterparts, and how you can begin to live life on your terms.

Motherhood is challenging for everyone. For overwhelmed ADHD moms, it is the job from hell. It requires top-notch organization, prioritization, and time-management skills—a perfect choreography of the brain's executive functions, according to clinical psychologist Ellen Littman, Ph.D. Plus, it requires infinite patience, a high tolerance for boring housework, and an almost inhuman emotional calm.

“Typical parenting advice is not written for moms with ADHD,” Dr. Littman says. “You try to do the things they suggest, and you end up feeling even worse and more alone.”

What follows is not typical parenting advice.

The Feminine Ideal

Why do mothers with ADHD report feeling inadequate? Unworthy? Sad? Perpetually exhausted? Overwhelmed? We blame SuperMom.

“The feminine ideal is crazy,” Dr. Littman says. “It expects you to cooperatively organize everyone without complaining and look great while you do it. It's unrealistic for anyone. There's the part of you that knows it's unrealistic, and then there's the part of you that pursues it anyway.”

And that is when unhealthy comparing, competing, and internal conversations occur. In other words, you stay up until 2 a.m., completing cute crafty teacher gifts and banging your head against a wall.

Girls' Guide to ADHD

The negative self-talk and poor self-esteem that many moms battle rarely show up for the first time in their adult lives. They are born in adolescence, especially those with undiagnosed (or diagnosed) ADHD. If you grow up being called “ditzy,” “dreamy,” or “dumb,” you begin to believe it. You begin to think you are lazy or “less than” others because no

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

one's told you that neurology and physiology are to blame. You internalize the shame, and it begins to eat away at you.

“We’re only really embracing now that girls can have ADHD. High-functioning women with ADHD look so different from hyperactive boys with ADHD that very few people will understand or will label the disorder correctly for them,” Dr. Littman says. “The most important thing for women to understand is that motherhood is not hard because you have character flaws or because you aren’t trying hard enough. It’s hard because there are neurological things getting in the way.”

The Estrogen Link

Research suggests that fluctuations in estrogen impact a woman’s ability to regulate symptoms of ADHD. When your estrogen levels are higher, you can better regulate the dopamine in your brain. When they are lower—like before menstruating—symptoms are amplified.

This means that some girls don’t show any signs of ADHD until puberty hits—a much later onset of symptoms than is typical with boys. It also means that your emotions and symptoms are on a monthly roller coaster ride that is hard to plan around and recover from.

The Dark Side of Social Media

Connecting with not-really-friends on Snapchat or Instagram means you see photos of their perfectly coiffed kids and kale-infused meal creations every darn day. You can’t escape those images of perfection (even if they’re staged and exaggerated wildly), and you can’t help comparing yourself, your microwave dinners, and your never-ever-clean house.

“You try to hide the chaos behind the façade,” Dr. Littman says. “You worry that people will find out you’re an impostor, so you hide your feelings—keep them pent up. You put up a wall so that no one understands your experience. It becomes very lonely.”

It’s Not an Excuse

Even when we do open up about our ADHD and try to explain the symptoms that have defined us for too long, many people are incredulous. They don’t believe that ADHD exists in adults. Or they think we’re making excuses. Or they say we’re too successful to have ADHD. None of these reactions is helpful.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

“ADHD is not an excuse; it is an explanation—a totally physiological explanation,” Dr. Littman says. “The smarter you are and the better you compensate the more people will doubt you. The harder you struggle to cope, staying up late to pull things together, the more people will doubt your ADHD. They don’t see that the cost of your success is terrible sadness, anxiety, and burnout.”

Where Is Your Oxygen Mask?

When moms feel chronically strung out and stressed, they don’t feel they deserve any time for themselves or feel entitled to relaxation or adequate sleep. They put their own self-care on the back burner. This saps your resources, makes you likelier to get sick or have an accident, and exacerbates ADHD symptoms. Feeling awful becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy.

“You invalidate yourself, and you accept invalidation from others who say you’re not doing a good job—including abusive comments from a child with ADHD,” Dr. Littman says. “You can fall into a cycle that is really negative.”

Why SuperMom Must Be Stopped

Everyone is entitled to say, “This is what I need help with.” Right now, women with ADHD are not comfortable doing that. So, they lead secret lives.

“You maintain the façade of looking like other women,” Dr. Littman says. “But the everyday chaos, pain, torment, and struggle—that is the secret you live with. That stuff will undo your life, not whether your kids are 10 minutes late or forgot the field trip permission form. Those unhealthy feelings about yourself? That is what’s going to ruin your life.”

Following are seven strategies that will help you redefine “how to be a good mom” with ADHD.

Step #1: Acknowledge Your ADHD...

...and how it impacts you and your family. Your ADHD is just as serious as your child’s ADHD.

Its symptoms are just as wide-ranging and impact your family just as much—if not more. Don’t hide it, and don’t blame yourself for neurological manifestations beyond your control.

Also, acknowledge that you and your child may have very different types of ADHD. You may be gregarious, outgoing, and creative while your child is hypersensitive and withdrawn.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

“One person is always overwhelmed by too much stimulation, and the other person is always frustrated by not getting a response,” Dr. Littman says. “It’s frustrating, but there is no one to blame.”

Step #2: Pursue Treatment

ADHD medication works wonders for some adults. Nutrition and exercise help others keep symptoms in balance. But almost everyone benefits from talking with a therapist, counselor, or support group. Find a therapist who gets what it’s like for mothers with ADHD to cope, and you will be one big step closer to validation and support.

“Many women with ADHD feel, ‘This is my sole burden to carry as an albatross.’ And it’s a very heavy burden,” Dr. Littman says. “It’s really hard to go this alone, and there is no reason to.”

Step #3: Enlist Help

Tell your significant other, friends, or family that you need help. Show your vulnerability and accept assistance and ideas from others. Be willing to give and take. Do your absolute best. But don’t ever apologize for your ADHD.

“Organizing the entire world of your family is not your job alone,” Dr. Littman says. “It is something everyone can learn.”

Step #4: Work with Your Child

Children with ADHD are more likely to follow rules that they have a part in creating. Invite your child to solve problems with you. Ask them, “What should we do?” “How can this work better?” “What do you think we should try?” Delegate to survive and learn to try different ideas even if you think they’ll fail. You may just be surprised.

Step #5: Give Yourself 10 Minutes

If you don’t schedule it, it probably won’t happen. So, mark your calendar for 10 minutes of daily ‘regrouping’ time. This can entail meditation, yoga, walking the dog, reading, painting, etc. Whatever it is, make sure it’s just for you—and don’t let anyone drag you away early.

“You may not feel you deserve it, or you may feel too overwhelmed,” Dr. Littman says. “But you will be happier and healthier for it.”

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Step #6: Ignore Everyone Else

“Don’t seek out normal. It’s boring,” Dr. Littman says. “Instead, focus on feeling good and happy. No one can decide for you the best way to live. And no one is judging you as harshly as you are yourself.”

Expert Q&As with Leslie Josel

Q: “How can I overcome ‘mommy overwhelm’ to help myself improve? I am a full-time working mother with a newborn.”

I truly applaud you for being so open with what you want to accomplish and wanting to work on yourself! I’m guessing that, like many moms of young children, your needs play “second fiddle” to everyone else’s. Here are some ideas for making change.

1. Put on Your Own Oxygen Mask First

If you truly want to help yourself forge a stronger, more confident life, you must first identify your own challenges and find solutions that work for you. What might that look like? Let’s say that you need an hour of exercise every morning to feel centered and to focus your brain, but you don’t have the childcare to do so. Put other workarounds in place like swapping childcare duties with a friend or neighbor. Or perhaps household-cleaning help is what you need? Barter services so you get an hour of housekeeping in exchange for you cooking a few delicious meals.

2. Recognize the Right to Say No

A wise woman once told me that I could do everything—just not simultaneously. You have a lot on your plate as a full-time working mom, and a new mom at that. Determine what is absolutely necessary to get done and do just that. The less you say yes to, the more time you will have to focus on what is absolutely necessary.

It’s difficult to say “No” or “This just doesn’t work for me.” And sometimes we say yes to things just because we are caught off guard. So, remember, it is well within your right to say “No”—without any further explanation. A simple, “I’m sorry, but I can’t,” will work just fine.

3. Make Getting Started Simple

I know you are overwhelmed. And I know it’s tough to start anything when you’re overwhelmed, making you feel more overwhelmed. So, make your goals super small. One email to write, one call to make, one drawer to organize, one pile of clothing to put away. You get the idea. Chances are good that, once you start, you’ll feel less overwhelmed and more in control.

Q: “I’m overwhelmed by starting the project to reduce my overwhelm. Help!”

Project planning is daunting—especially for those with ADHD. There are endless steps to organize and plan, details that need remembering, decisions to make, and loads of required activation. So, take a deep breath, and I’m going to share a few strategies that I use with my coaching clients.

1. Start with a brain dump. Identify all the things that are needed to complete this project, and get them out of your head and onto either paper or your computer. Sounds

obvious, I know. But obvious doesn't necessarily mean easy. Getting all those to-dos and details out of your brain will allow you to create a plan of action more effectively and efficiently. What truly overwhelms my clients is not necessarily doing what needs to be done but creating the plan. And the first step is to free up space in your brain, alleviating the stress of trying to remember. By putting to-dos down, you can visualize them, which makes ordering, prioritizing, and planning that much easier.

2. Make your to-dos actionable. The key here is to create some movement. It's a simple trick I use to get the mundane to jump off the page. So instead of writing "painter," try "call painter." Instead of "backsplash," write "visit tile store."

3. Schedule "office time." Think of this project as a job. That said, you need to schedule a few uninterrupted hours a week to work on it. This step is critical. If you don't plan the time, the likelihood of making progress is slim. Perhaps Monday mornings or Thursday afternoons work for you. Add this time slot to your planner or calendar like you would a doctor's appointment. If you give this project the same importance as other appointments (or as I like to call it, "bubble wrapping your time"), you're more likely to honor it the same way.

4. Group like with like. To avoid having an overloaded to-do-list meltdown, your tasks need to match. When deciding what to do during your "office time," plan all your errands for one morning, and phone calls for another. You get the idea.

5. Limit choices. Too many choices can make us go down the analysis paralysis route. So, limit them. Decide you will visit only two kitchen stores, get two contractor quotes, and look at four paint colors. By limiting your choices, the decision-making process becomes less exhausting.

6. Phone a friend. If visiting a kitchen store to pick out new appliances fills you with dread, invite a friend with an eye for design. Or send paint swatches to your sister if choosing colors is not your forte. Having someone to share the decision-making load might be the perfect antidote to moving your project along.

Q: "Will a daily routine keep me from feeling overwhelmed? I'm a work-from-home mom with no daily structure. I feel so out of control, jumping from one thing to another."

Here's how I explain establishing routines to my coaching clients: Planning, organization, and time management all require ongoing, conscious, active brainpower. Routines, almost by definition, do not.

Think of a routine as "I plan it once, and I'm done." In other words, a daily routine allows you to move through your tasks without thinking about what's next. Routines are great tools to help battle procrastination because giving your brain a break from consciously planning and preparing specific to-dos means fewer things will get in your way of accomplishing the work that requires effort.

A funny thing about routines and rituals is that sometimes they form naturally without much deliberate thought. Brushing your teeth before (or after) you wash your face is a routine you probably fell into one day. The same goes for putting on your socks and shoes. Other routines take considerable thought and effort. When students receive their new class schedule at the beginning of a school year or semester, they need to devise all-new routines to support the structure of their days. The same applies to adults.

Ritual vs. Routine

What's the difference between a routine and a ritual? I describe a routine as something you perform at a planned time and put on your planner or calendar, such as doing laundry every Tuesday at 7 p.m.

However, a ritual is an order or procedure you follow when working (or preparing to work) on a task or activity. For example, your prework ritual may look like this:

- pour coffee
- scan planner and task list for the day
- switch on desk lamp
- turn on music
- light candle
- gather any materials that are needed to begin a specific work task

While these examples may make them sound very different, routines and rituals are both effective tools to help you form habits. And the best way to prove their effectiveness is to show you what could happen without them.

Why Are Routines and Rituals Important?

Let's say you don't have a set schedule for laundry. It's 9 a.m. on Monday morning, and you're about to dive into your work report that's due at 11 a.m. You feel two hours gives you ample time to complete it. As you head to your home office, you glimpse your laundry basket overflowing with a week's dirty clothes. Naturally, you decide to put a load in before considering whether you can manage both simultaneously. "What's the big deal?" you think.

Here's why it may be a big deal: It takes 15 minutes to start the laundry after sorting, emptying pockets, presoaking items, etc., giving you a late work start. Forty-five minutes into work, you interrupt yourself to move the wash to the dryer, hang clothes to dry, search for more hangers, and begin another load. Soon, the washer and dryer beep again, indicating more laundry. Once completed, you sit back at your desk and realize it's now 11 a.m. You're feeling overwhelmed because you are only halfway

finished with your report. Doing laundry seemed innocent enough, right? But you've now lost time to the rinse cycle, causing unexpected consequences. One small decision threw your morning off track, and the ripple effect continued into the afternoon.

However, if you had an established laundry routine on Monday nights, you could have focused solely on your report and worked straight through without interruption.

Now I'm not saying that you need to have every moment of your life planned to the minute. None of us can live that way. But establishing and sticking to certain routines can make your life easier, save precious time, take the guesswork out of how to get things done, and provide a sense of calm and control.

Bonus tip: HabitHub (available on Google Play or Apple stores) is one of my favorite apps to help incentivize forming routines. It encourages you to create a daily habit by reminding you to perform a task and track it when it's complete. The app makes a visual "chain" showing each day the task was completed. As the chain gets longer, it incentivizes you to keep at the task, so you don't break it. You can organize your to-dos into categories and customize each according to how often you're supposed to do it. It's incredibly flexible and makes setting up and staying in a routine a breeze.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

Stress: Keeping Your Cool at School

Between work schedules, finances, and family obligations, stress can be found everywhere—including your children.

“One of the first mistakes parents make is assuming that kids aren’t susceptible to stress,” says Rebecca Newgent, Ph.D., assistant professor in the Department of Educational Leadership, Counseling, and Foundations at the University of Arkansas. “They figure kids don’t have to work; they don’t have to pay bills; they have it easy. But actually, there are potential stressors at every age.”

For example, grades, popularity, and physical appearance can stress a young person’s life, as can family troubles like divorce or financial instability. But whether trivial or serious by adult standards, these issues all loom large in children’s eyes. Dr. Newgent advises parents not to dismiss an issue that genuinely troubles their child.

The first step in helping a child deal with stress, she says, is recognizing the symptoms. “Knowing how stress manifests is especially important for parents of younger children because younger children may not know the cause of their symptoms, or they may lack the vocabulary to express their feelings.”

Dr. Newgent explains that children exhibit stress physically, behaviorally, and psychologically. Physical symptoms may include frequent stomach aches, headaches, acne breakouts, and even high blood pressure. Behaviorally, kids under stress often become more irritable or withdrawn. They may begin acting out at school or neglect their studies. If stress goes unchecked, children may show psychological symptoms such as forgetfulness or lack of concentration. Stress can even progress to more serious conditions such as anxiety or depression.

If parents see signs of stress in their child, Dr. Newgent recommends talking to the child—first trying to identify their feelings then, if possible, digging deeper to discern the cause of those feelings. “Like adults, children can experience different types of stress,” she says.

For example, preparing for college or going to camp for the first time might be a source of “positive” stress—where some of the feelings are unpleasant, but the eventual outcome is rewarding. In such a case, parents should acknowledge the source of stress while encouraging their kids to persevere through difficulties to reach their goals.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

“On the other hand, incidents such as bullying or perpetually poor grades represent forms of ‘negative’ stress,” Dr. Newgent says. “Under these circumstances, parents should focus not just on alleviating stress but on working with their child to eliminate the cause.”

School counselors, psychologists, and even medication are available if children become overwhelmed by stress, but before parents resort to drastic measures Dr. Newgent suggests they try two simple approaches. First, encourage the child to do something healthy.

“Exercise, go out into the fresh air, watch a silly movie—encourage them to find a mental or physical release that gives them a break from their stress,” Dr. Newgent says.

It’s long been known that physical exertion produces endorphins that can relieve symptoms of stress and depression, but any sort of leisure activity can be beneficial. Such an approach may seem like an attempt to distract children from their worries, but Dr. Newgent explains that it helps children establish a pattern of positive activity and teaches them to cope with stress through healthy habits.

Dr. Newgent’s second recommendation is as much a prevention as a treatment. She urges parents to act as good role models for their kids—to deal with their own stress in reasonable and healthy ways. “Just as parental worries can be felt and adopted by children, so can parental coping mechanisms. Parents who lash out or withdraw under pressure will have children who mimic that reaction,” she says.

In addition, parents who react poorly to stress create an environment where children may try to hide their emotions to avoid upsetting their parents. Such circumstances—where parents are wrapped up in their own problems and children bury their feelings—invariably perpetuate stress, anxiety, and depression in kids, Dr. Newgent explains.

A more appropriate approach is for parents to deal with their stress individually but not to hide it from the family or pretend it doesn’t exist. “Children are perceptive. If there’s stress in the house, they’ll sense it and begin to feel it themselves,” she says.

In cases of long-term stress, Dr. Newgent recommends parents acknowledge their feelings to their kids, but she cautions against revealing too much. Parents who discuss financial problems or family issues in great detail risk raising feelings of anxiety or personal responsibility in their children.

CHAPTER 4: STOP OVERWHELM AND STRESS FROM CONTROLLING YOUR LIFE

“Set appropriate boundaries about how you discuss family situations with your kids,” she says. “When you do talk to them, assure them that you’re working to fix the problem or make things better and that there’s nothing they need to worry about. Be very reassuring.”

“Fact: Clutter Causes Stress. Solution: These 11 Daily Rituals.”

By Gretchen Rubin, best-selling author

When you're feeling blue or overwhelmed, it's tempting to try to pick yourself up by indulging in a “treat.” One of my “treats” is the decision not to pick up after myself. Instead of trying to tidy up as I go, as I usually do, I let small tasks mount up.

“I can't possibly be expected to do something silly like clean up clutter,” I tell myself. “I'm too busy/upset/rushed/overwhelmed. I deserve a break.”

The problem is that, in the end, the mess makes me feel worse. Maybe I get a tiny buzz from flinging my coat onto the hall floor, but the disorder makes my bad mood worse. Plus, it's not nice for anyone who lives with me. On the other hand, serene, orderly surroundings make me feel better. Outer order brings inner calm.

Now, instead of “treating” myself to a mess, I try to keep things tidy when I'm feeling low.

Here are some tips to keep your surroundings uncluttered, no matter how you feel.

1. Make your bed.
2. Put your dirty clothes in the hamper.
3. Hang up your bath towel.
4. Keep magazines out of sight. People disagree with me on this one, but I find it impossible to keep stacks of magazines from looking messy.
5. Shut all drawers, cabinet doors, and closet doors as you go.
6. Pick up the mail, sort it, recycle junk mail, and put important mail in the proper place (I have a drawer for bills and a file for invitations).
7. Put dirty dishes in the dishwasher or, failing that, the sink.
8. Deal with the recycling. It differs greatly from town to town, but you know what you're supposed to do.
9. Put books away in the proper place: back on the shelf, in the library-return pile, or in the donation pile. Speaking of that...
10. Keep a bag handy for things you want to give away. As soon as you decide you don't want something anymore, put it in the bag. Every so often, drop off the bag at a thrift store.
11. Hang up your coat. My epiphany: I never hung up my coat because I didn't like dealing with hangers. Eureka! I started using a hook. Problem solved.

“Slow Down and Live Stress-Free”

By Jennifer Koretsky, senior-certified ADHD coach and author

In my early 20s, I lived and worked in New York City. One morning, I was riding a crowded subway. I was late to work, as usual. I had an early meeting that I hadn't prepared for. I also felt guilty, because I had to leave my brand-new, whimpering puppy home alone for several hours.

If all this weren't bad enough, a nearby passenger kept stepping on my toes. The first time he did it, I huffed. After the third time, I yelled at him, unleashing a string of epithets. I nearly had a breakdown.

My Life, Pre-ADHD Diagnosis

From the outside looking in, I seemed to have a great life: I was a superstar in my company. I had a nice apartment, good friends, and a supportive family. Yet I was overwhelmed by everyday life. I felt as if I always ran behind. My apartment was never neat enough or clean enough. I didn't go to the grocery store often enough. I looked around and saw a city full of people who seemed to juggle everything. I judged myself harshly.

So, I pushed harder to keep up with everyone. It didn't work. Pushing harder only led to more stress and, eventually, to burnout. Thinking about everything I should be doing was so taxing that I fell apart regularly. It was a cycle I went through many times.

Stress and Adult ADHD

The day of my subway rant, I knew that something had to change. I saw a therapist and was eventually diagnosed with ADHD. As I educated myself about the condition, I discovered that the feeling of being overwhelmed was common among adults with ADHD. When I was stressed out, I had less control over my ADHD symptoms. I was more likely to get distracted, and I lost track of time more easily. On the other hand, when I was calm and centered, I could pay attention in boring meetings and keep the fridge stocked with something more nutritious than Crystal Light.

I decided I would break the cycle of self-imposed stress, once and for all so that I could enjoy the happiness and success that I deserved.

Slowing Down

I gave myself permission to slow down. Sometimes it was easy: I'd listen to music, take a long walk with my dog, or meet a friend for lunch. Other times, I had to force myself to turn off my chaotic brain by attending a yoga class or going to a concert. I soon learned that a little bit of relaxation went a long way in helping me meet the challenges that my ADHD symptoms threw at me.

It was only when I slowed down that I realized that my unhealthy lifestyle was increasing my stress levels. I ate takeout food at mealtimes, barely got by on five hours of sleep each night, and used my free time to camp out in front of the TV.

I started small, by making dinner for myself a few nights a week. When I became comfortable with that adjustment, I worked on getting more sleep, forcing myself to turn off the TV at 11 p.m. and reading a book until bedtime instead. I hit the gym after work, as well as before a meeting—exercise always cleared my head.

Accepting ADHD as a Part of Myself

Most importantly, I stopped comparing myself to others. My ADHD made me different from other people. When I accepted that truth, I didn't care whether my desk was as neat as my co-workers' desks. If I could find what I needed, I was in good shape. When I stopped worrying about what others thought of me, the pressure and the stress lifted. I could handle pretty much anything—even having my toes stepped on by a wobbly passenger in a crowded subway.

“Forget Meditation: Simplifying My Life Is the Best Way of Reducing ADHD Stress”

By Katy Rollins, blogger and ADDitude contributor

I am undergoing a bit of a personal revolution. I guess that’s a slightly dramatic statement, but periods of personal growth are significant and necessary. Part of this process of personal growth has been making my life smaller. Much smaller.

I decided that taking care of my home, my household, and my family is my number one priority. In support of that goal, I have eradicated every obligation that isn’t necessary from my life. Currently, the only obligation that I have retained outside of my home is my “day job.” I need my job to pay my bills, so it’s not negotiable.

I even sold my event production business and curtailed work on my clothing design business. I thought that I would hate this, but I’ve noticed that having fewer obligations means that I also have less stress. I realize that this relationship should be logical, but for me, it wasn’t obvious. My ADHD mind doesn’t always make the obvious connections immediately.

I’ve always needed the charge of being busy. In some ways, I think it was a form of self-medication. However, now that I have had a treatment plan in place for several years, including medication and regular visits with my therapist, I seem to need less excitement to keep me feeling alive and focused.

With a clear schedule, I began envisioning my life and my home in a new way. To start, I calculated the hours needed to maintain my home in good working order and to keep clutter at bay. For my home, that’s about 25 hours/week. I can’t afford a housekeeper, so that’s a part-time job’s worth of time that either I or someone else living in my household needs to spend on things like laundry, dishes, vacuuming, mopping, cleaning bathrooms, decluttering common areas, taking care of pets, and other household tasks, like my husband’s outdoor work. I also threw in a little time each week for “surprises” that every homeowner knows arise.

Calculating this was an eye-opening moment for me. It wasn’t as horrifying for me as it might be for people who hate cleaning more than I do, but it was still a stunning number. It gave me important information. One valuable nugget: I realized I wouldn’t be able to do this alone. I needed to engage my family in this process of caring for the house each week. My husband and kids were already participating in these activities, but no one was doing it on a schedule.

Hence: I made a schedule.

I’d like to dwell on how weird this process has been for me. I’ve always known how to do household tasks, individually. But I have never organized a system for home

maintenance. I never had to look at it this way before. It's pretty cool, actually, to realize that there are ways to declutter and simplify every corner of my home, if I'm willing to make it a priority and put in the time.

I had gotten so tired of my life feeling out of control. I want my home to feel organized, clean, and welcoming. I want to be able to invite friends over without having to spend five hours cleaning first.

But cleaning is just the tip of the iceberg. Once I started organizing my home, I realized that many other aspects of my life needed to be organized. But before I do that, I need to go home and cook dinner.

“What I Wish Someone Had Told Me Before My Flaming ADHD Burnout”

By Les Steed

I imagined riding my motorcycle through the green hills—slipping away without telling anyone I was leaving—even just for a day. Instead, I kept going. I kept going in a job that was wearing me down to the bone. I kept going in a broken relationship that made me feel like a failure. I kept going all alone because I had to prove to the world that I could do good work; that I was worthy.

This was my life three years ago, and a few years before that too, when I was being grossly underpaid while feeling responsible for the demise of a business that began sinking long before I arrived. Still, I worked all day and night just to meet unreasonable demands—some from my bosses, but most from myself. I felt intense pressure, but I kept going because I was terrified. Terrified of failing my then-girlfriend, failing my bosses, and failing myself and sinking my fledgling career.

I took on far more than anyone could have fairly expected of me because I am a high achiever and my attitude was, “I have to do this all myself because no one else can.” I not only accepted responsibility for everything; I also accepted and focused on taking the blame for everything and felt totally alone in my culpability, even when I often wasn’t. I was not the lone savior or villain, but I do think I cared more than many of my colleagues, and so I destroyed myself and burned out.

In my effort to make everything work for everyone else, I ended up with extreme anxiety, feelings of failure, sadness, and self-loathing. I felt unlovable for my relationship problems, like I was a monster, that I was the crappiest person at work, and that everyone was talking about me behind my back. In that underlying despair, every negative word was devastating, even when it was unintentional or benign. I couldn’t register any positivity because I dismissed it as a fake gesture from someone just trying to make me feel better because they felt sorry for me.

I wish I had prioritized myself and taken a proper break for the sake of my mental health. Instead, I kept going. My performance deteriorated, as did my mental health. My anxiety got worse; I was miserable all the time; I was increasingly socially dysfunctional (I’d whine a lot about the same thing, going round in circles all the time for months, sometimes years), and I completely lost my self-respect and pride.

Eight months in, I was a crying semi-alcoholic wreck who was too afraid to really fix my own problems because I hated myself so much. Ultimately, I could cope no longer and left my job and the relationship just to make the pounding pressure stop.

I made it out, but the damage was done. Looking back, here is the advice I wish someone had given me when it became clear I was destroying myself for a job that

was not worth it: You are brilliant, hard-working, respectable, fun, and extremely brave—but you are not invincible or capable of the impossible. You are not omniscient. No one will hate you for not taking on every project. You're not letting anyone down by simply saying, "No, I've got too much on my plate already" instead of pushing your own happiness further and further down the calendar to take on more deadlines. Here are more things I wish I had considered:

Assess your priorities. What are you reasonably and comfortably able to do to move your career and your life forward at an equal pace? Why are you trying to live up to semi-fictitious expectations? When will you recognize that your health and mental well-being impact everything else in your life and work?

Figure out what is really being asked of you against the excess pressures and responsibilities you put on yourself.

It is totally unreasonable to take full responsibility. You don't have all the experience. You don't have all the manpower. You aren't perfect. You are learning as you are going. That doesn't make you weak or unreliable; it makes you human. It's important to manage your work so you can spend some time and energy on your happiness.

Take time to feel infinitesimal. You do so much good already. The projects will be there when you get back from taking your deep breath. When you need a break, ask for one without shame. Take a day off.

Finally, **plan some alone time.** Set aside a thousand dollars for it and plan it so you can just click a few links, pay for it all at once, and grab your bags when the time is right, like activating the escape hatch.

The world does keep ticking without you trying to hold it together as you burn yourself out until you literally can't keep going. It takes time to heal from the damage of being overstretched, which in itself is a deeply painful process. Acknowledge that, realize it doesn't make you weak, and put your own well-being first for a change.

“I Feel Like I Have No Time for Myself”

By Sari Solden, M.S., LMFT

Years ago, I gathered with 80 middle-aged women in New York City for a fun and rewarding day. The event brought laughter, tears, and relief to many who finally opened up about a long-held secret. They had spent their lives struggling with organization and low self-esteem at the expense of developing their talents and strengths. While worrying so much about time management and planning, they had no time for themselves—they had, in effect, scheduled themselves out of their own lives.

Here's what they said:

“Every minute of the day, I am scheduled to do things I am not good at, but I'm trying to be disciplined.”

“I feel too guilty to see friends or to take a break from organizing.”

“I will start thinking about my own life when everything is under control, everyone's needs are taken care of, and people stop asking me for things.”

“If I criticize myself, I will motivate myself. I just need to grow up.”

If you've said any of these things, find a different way to measure success. Gauge it not by the things you've checked off your list, but by vitality, authenticity, and connection to what you do.

If you're putting your life on hold—until your piles of clutter are gone or the laundry is folded, don't. Figure out what you want to achieve and move toward it. Ahead, find four ways to do just that.

Stop Focusing on ADHD Challenges

Joan, a client of mine, managed to do that. After being diagnosed with ADHD, in her mid-40s, she met with me in my office. I remember her clutching her planner, her eyes glued to the schedule and calendar.

She had divided each day into 15-minute segments that would allow her to tackle her disorganization.

Two weeks later, her plan crumbled. She couldn't keep up with it.

Why? Her structured days held nothing that nourished her spirit or enhanced her strengths. Her dreams and yearnings, the things that made her unique, were put on hold until “someday,” and she doubled her efforts to change who she was.

Through therapy, she was able to reverse the negativity that was preventing her from reaching her goals. She gave herself permission to live her life while meeting her challenges with ADHD head-on.

Eventually, she took a yoga class and joined a choir.

Instead of wasting energy trying to wish your ADHD challenges away, accept them, and try the following:

- **Make friends, in person or online**, who have similar challenges. You will be able to see their talents more clearly than they do, and in doing so, you will see your strengths and find support to use them.
- **Find someone who sees you clearly, values you, and will help you achieve small goals** based on your beliefs and your vision for the future. This may be a therapist, an ADHD coach, a support group member, or a friend.

Spend Time Making Your Dream a Reality

Spending one hour a week on something you value or something pleasurable will help you move toward achieving larger life goals.

Find your passion, and make your passion happen. At the close of the event in New York, a woman handed me a CD she had just released. On it, she sang a medley of songs, all of which she had written. I remembered her. We had worked together for a while on her struggle to reclaim her life and art. Then she moved away.

Back in Michigan, the next day, I listened to her songs. I heard a woman's evocative voice, singing. My eyes filled with tears. I remembered her disorganization and her ache to return to what she loved doing, to being herself.

Whether your passion is humor, warmth, or the ability to work with numbers, people, or ideas, when you find yourself putting your life on hold, picture this woman. Ten years ago, she was sitting in a roomful of unfolded laundry, besieged by kids, seeing only her deficiencies. Then she gave herself permission to live, even as she struggled with her biggest ADHD challenges. You can, too.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Paul Hammer-ness, M.D.; Leslie Josel; Zoë Kessler; Judith Kolberg; Jennifer Koretsky; Margaret Moore; Linda Roggli, PCC; Katy Rollins; Gretchen Rubin; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; Jerome Schultz, Ph.D.; Sari Solden, M.S., LMFT; and Les Steed.

CHAPTER 5

Emotional Regulation Strategies That Work

Chapter 5: Emotional Regulation Strategies That Work

How's Your Emotional Resilience? Learning to Cope with Intense ADHD Feelings

By Joel Nigg, Ph.D.

Emotional dysregulation is a pervasive and, at times paralyzing, experience for many people with ADHD. Despite exclusion from diagnostic criterion, experiences of emotional dysregulation—outsized anger, irritability, shifts in mood, intense feelings, sensitivity, and more—are common and frequently very troubling components of the ADHD experience.

ADHD treatment can dampen the severity of these emotional symptoms to some extent, but standard treatments for ADHD do not restore emotional balance or help with inattention. Therefore, to get the most improvement, it is usually necessary to also learn how to build emotional resilience. From practicing coping skills to meeting basic health needs and seeking professional interventions, adults and children with ADHD can deploy various strategies to rein in extreme emotions and achieve greater emotional stability. Here are the most common and effective strategies.

Understanding ADHD and Emotional Dysregulation

Why is emotional dysregulation so ubiquitous with ADHD? The frequent presence of ADHD's comorbid conditions—namely anxiety, trauma, and substance abuse—is certainly one reason. But not the only one. The connection is more fundamental to ADHD as well. Here are the prevailing theories:

- **Executive dysfunction:** Implicated in ADHD, deficits in executive function skills like inhibition and working memory make regulating emotions more difficult. The same skills that help us concentrate also work to adjust emotions to the situation.
- **Confused internal signals:** Research shows that poor emotional coherence—or mixed physiological signals (heart rate, facial muscles, brain activity)—is a complication for

many with ADHD. Emotional coherence is the melody played by an orchestra with many harmonized instruments; it sums up how we feel. With mixed signals, the melody becomes a cacophony and difficult to interpret—people may feel strongly but with confused emotions. For example, frustration and disappointment may feel the same, but they aren't. Frustration is a signal to move forward with more effort or a new strategy, while disappointment is a signal to move away. Thus, responses may be mismatched to the situation.

- **Hidden expectancies or biases.** Emotion has conscious and automatic influences. It involves interpreting physiological signals—at first, we do so automatically, then deliberately. Heart rates, for example, may jump at a sudden sound. But once we realize the small sound is nothing to fear, we feel fine. But if one has a hidden bias, they may interpret ambiguous signals as a threat or in some other way that makes it harder to map emotion to the situation.

Developing Emotional Resilience: Starting Principles

1. Monitor Overall Health

Neglecting to eat and sleep well, coupled with a lack of exercise, will impair an individual's ability to feel good and deal with life's stressors and challenges. Dedicating yourself to a new schedule for a month is usually enough time to see if there's any positive change. Some habits may help regulate emotions in the moment, but they are seldom useful in the long run.

2. Ensure Social Support

Social circles are critical to cultivating emotional resilience. Social support is crucial for children. For teens, seeing their friends is necessary and should be supported (in a safe manner). For very young children, parents are their critical source of support.

3. Manage Stress

Children with ADHD are more prone to feeling stress, even when faced with the same events as their neurotypical peers. While a strength in some situations, this sensitivity can create overwhelm and make coping more difficult.

A child's tantrum, for example, can simply be a sign that they cannot cope with the situation. They are overwhelmed, and thus their coping skills are breaking down. One solution is to help reinforce their coping skills (like developing an alternative behavior or learning self-calming skills).

In this case, it's critical to become aware of a child's chronic stressors and triggers, and to figure out which stressors can be eliminated, and which can be managed.

4. Address Trauma and Ongoing Adversity

Many people with ADHD have a history of adversity or emotional trauma, sometimes directly stemming from the experience of ADHD and emotional dysregulation itself.

Traumatic history can cause the body to expect and see trauma, even when it isn't there. The result is an overreaction to a given situation.

Caregivers need to know if a child is dealing with an adverse situation, like bullying or feeling discouraged at school. On the other hand, many times, when parents are very stressed (by worrying over finances or other concerns), children and teens pick up on this and become dysregulated in response.

5. Develop Coping Strategies

Emotional regulation begins with self-awareness. Coping strategies, which may take shape or be honed with the help of a professional counselor, include planning ahead for stressors and having a plan for dealing with them. Some steps include:

- **Anticipatory coping.** This entails building a mental framework before facing a recurring, stressful situation (like dealing with a child's tantrums). The anticipatory coping strategy may be escaping, planning a different response, or going through with it but practicing self-care afterward. With a plan, it is much easier to maintain an emotional match to a situation and reduce overwhelm.
- **Self-talking appraisals.** These entail mentally reframing an event to defuse its intensity. Assuming that the stressor means deliberate harm (like a clumsy person bumping into someone) is the start of the problem. Rethinking the situation to assume the best or extend the benefit of the doubt eases tensions.
- **Shifting attention** is especially helpful for children, who may lack more advanced coping skills. Sometimes, the best way to avoid a stressor (like social media, a television show, the news, or a specific person) is to direct attention away from it.
- **Humor.** Laughing about a situation (joking about it with a friend or exaggerating its importance) sometimes helps change perspectives and attitudes around the once troubling situation.
- **Rationalize.** Although often referred to in a negative light, rationalizing can also be an effective way to cope—also by changing perspectives.

Counseling and Psychotherapy

For adults and children, counseling is the most well-proven intervention for addressing the emotional dysregulation tied to ADHD, as well as anger problems and extreme irritability (compared to medication). Professional counselors help patients identify coping

skills and put them into practice, so they actually work. The logic of counseling, however, is slightly different for children than it is for adults.

Behavior Counseling for Children

This type of intervention teaches parents how to respond effectively when a child experiences emotional and behavioral difficulties. Often, a child's angry or excessive response can cause parents to react similarly, creating a cycle of tantrums and frustrations. Parents, for example, may unwittingly reward tantrums by giving in or otherwise teaching the child that tantrums are effective.

Behavior counseling teaches parents to reduce critical comments and increase warmth and support to change their children's behaviors and their own. Counselors, in turn, also work directly with children to teach them alternate behaviors, help them change their own attributions and beliefs, and increase their frustration tolerance.

Emotional dysregulation is often a difficult and debilitating part of the ADHD experience. Through self-coping skills and therapy, it is possible to build emotional resilience and significantly improve quality of life.

The content for this article was derived from the ADDitude webinar "ADHD Anger, Tantrums, and Mood Shifts: Effective Treatments for Emotional Dysregulation," with Joel Nigg, Ph.D.

The Emotional Resilience Playbook for People with Big Emotions

By Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

ADHD brains are routinely hijacked by big emotions—and big problems often follow.

Sometimes, adults with ADHD react with big emotions when things don't go according to expectations.

Even minor frustrations and interruptions can cause us to overreact with an outburst or meltdown, making it hard to complete tasks and maintain relationships.

This emotional dysregulation creates a vicious cycle, dooming us to repeat the same reaction again and again.

We can't always stop big emotions from spilling over, but we can learn to minimize the damage they cause to others and ourselves and develop emotionally healthy responses in the future. This process of developing emotional resilience is critical. But first, we need to understand how we process our emotions: by hurling or by hiding.

Hurlers and Hiders (aka Fire Breathers and Shame Eaters)

Most people with ADHD who experience strong ADHD emotions fall into one of two camps: the “hurlers” or the “hiders.” The hurlers, aka fire breathers, sling their big emotions at anyone or anything around them. In doing so, they damage their relationships in ways they may not realize or understand.

The hiders, aka shame eaters, shove their emotions inside. Why? It might be due to conflict avoidance, fear of rejection, low self-esteem, or the feeling that they won't be heard. They may experience stomach or digestive issues because they're stuffing their emotions into their body.

Strategies for Hiders

Name that emotion. Don't judge the emotion you are feeling; just identify it. This is critical to releasing it. Otherwise, your stuffed-deep-into-your-body emotions will re-surface as unresolved pain that needs to be felt and heard.

For example, perhaps you got yet another parking ticket, and you reason that you deserve this punishment is because you are bad at life. That is the feeling of shame.

Breathe and release. Now that you have named the emotion, let it go. Find an effective catharsis—a healthy release valve—like exercise, music, or even a primal scream.

Strategies for Hurlers

Understand your patterns so you can anticipate big emotions before they erupt. What do you start to feel? How do you know when big emotions are building? When I'm angry, I hear, "Oh, heck no," in my head. When I hear this big emotional tell, I tell myself to calm down, listen to that emotion, and not give in to the hurler mode.

Learn to release emotions pre-emptively. Ask: "How do I let go of this energy? What are my options?" Find a healthy release.

Strategies for Relatives and Friends of Hurlers

Have you ever found yourself on the receiving end of a hurler in full fire-breathing mode? Here are a few tips to manage this:

- **Don't argue with the hurler in the moment.** The individual isn't capable of rational thinking until the hurling is done. If you say, "Don't talk to me like that," the hurler's ADHD brain will say, "Oh, yeah. That's more energy. That's more fire for me to breathe."
- **Create a boundary.** After the hurling is over and some time passes, say to the person, "Your hurling hurts me." Sometimes, the hurler will feel ashamed.
- **Don't bury the hurt.** If the hurler refuses to take responsibility, consider seeking help from an ADHD coach or ADHD-informed therapist.

Calming Big Emotions

Here are some more catharsis tips:

- **Sit up, push back your shoulders, and take a deep breath.** Inhale, hold, and exhale—each for five seconds. This signals to your brain that you can't possibly be in danger; if you were in peril, your breathing would be fast and shallow.
- **Vomit words (i.e., rant) safely.** For some of us, spouting out grievances provides an emotional release. One client of mine would call a friend and ask, "Permission to vomit?" The friend would say, "Permission granted," and then my client would rant. Once she got it all out, the emotion was gone. Crying or yelling into a pillow also works.
- **Move your body.** Go for a run or take a hike to trigger a release.

- **Try tapping (also known as Emotional Freedom Technique).** This practice involves tapping your fingertips on meridian points on the face and body. Tapping helps relax the nervous system, calming our fight-or-flight mode and creating space to breathe.
- **Consider self-havening, or therapeutic touch,** to calm emotions. Begin by focusing on something calming, then cross your arms and give yourself a hug.
- **Cool down.** When you feel your emotions intensifying, or your pulse or breath quicken, go to a bathroom right away and put your hands and wrists under cold water. It is amazing how quickly this can reset your brain. Ice cubes on the wrists also work.
- **Establish daily practices** to frequently assess your emotional state. When you start your day, rate your emotional intensity using a number from one to 10, with 10 being the most intense. Repeat this assessment at lunchtime and at the end of the day. If you feel like a 10, you can say, “I need to do a catharsis ASAP.” On days when I don’t get enough sleep, I’m at risk for high-intensity emotions, so I check in with myself frequently to make sure I’m emotionally managed.
- **Choose how you want to feel.** If something frustrating happens, check in with yourself and say, “I don’t want to react in an unhealthy way.” Choose an appropriate and healthy level of intensity; that’s key as we practice emotional resilience.

Tamara Rosier, Ph.D., is the founder of the ADHD Center of West Michigan, a board-certified coach (BCC), and the president of the ADHD Coaches Organization (ACO). She has also worked as a college administrator, a professor, a high school teacher, and a faculty developer.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “Build Your ADHD Emotional Resilience: Strategies for Adults Who Feel Things Deeply,” with Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

Calm Starts at Home: How to Teach Emotional Regulation Skills

By Mark Bertin, M.D.

Emotional regulation skills (also known as self-regulation) empower us to process difficult experiences and feelings without getting overly triggered or spiraling out of control. With ADHD, which impairs executive functioning and thus affects the effective management of attention, time, and emotions, intense emotional reactivity can be as disruptive as almost any other symptom.

Parents of children with ADHD are intimately familiar with these extreme emotional bouts—outbursts, meltdowns, and tantrums that leave both parent and child feeling exhausted, and possibly powerless. What they might not realize is that, through medication, mindfulness techniques, awareness, and behavioral interventions, emotional regulation skills can be taught to children with ADHD.

Strategy #1: Accurately Label Feelings

Effective emotional regulation hinges on emotional intelligence—the ability to be aware of, express, and manage our emotions on our own and in relationships. This all starts with noticing our feelings as they come and go, which is not as easy as it seems.

Research suggests that a more complex emotional vocabulary adds nuance to our emotional experiences. If you only know “anger,” then any similar emotion becomes “anger.” If you recognize, in a more subtle way, when you feel “annoyed,” “anxious,” “sad,” “frustrated,” or “disappointed,” you more accurately pinpoint your experience. A larger emotional vocabulary could affect how you interpret a difficult moment.

A healthy familiarity with emotion starts with a family open to all emotions. All emotions exist for a reason, so there isn’t a lot of benefit in ignoring them. For example, anger keeps us safe in certain situations, and sadness signals to those around us that we need support. Emotional maturity develops over time; it’s normal for younger children to struggle with it. Read books, talk about emotions, and describe your own emotions to your child.

Normalize emotions by keeping them in the open and show children how to manage them. You might say, “I’m angry; we will talk once I’ve calmed down.” Sometimes it is better to keep emotions to yourself. You may worry or feel angry more than your child needs to know. But when you’re able, showing emotional self-control is its own teaching tool for children.

Still, an emotionally open household does not eradicate all challenges, of course. It isn't a parent's fault when a child has trouble with emotions; it's often an aspect of ADHD itself.

Strategy #2: Behavior Interventions

Behavioral interventions are a labor-intensive but proven path to better emotional skills for struggling children. Behavioral programs are key tools for educating even the best-behaved child. Some programs work directly with children, while others focus on parent training.

Child-directed therapy, where kids learn to identify emotions first and build coping skills to meet what they experience, can be vital for anyone with ADHD. Parental involvement helps, as adults reinforce what their children may otherwise forget to work on. Child-focused therapy should offer direct guidance in forming practical new habits as children learn to handle their own disruptive emotions.

On the other hand, one useful short-term strategy for managing emotion is often entirely parent-based. Behavioral parent training (BPT) reflects our knowledge of brain development—kids learn primarily from immediate feedback in early childhood. One foundational teaching point of BPT is recognizing the difference between our emotions and our behaviors. Parents should aim to validate emotion, but not unwanted behavior: “I can see you are angry, but it is never OK to hit.” A coordinated behavioral plan that balances praise and reward with firm limits and consequences is vital for managing emotion in children.

Tantrums, for example, are often nothing more than a behavior triggered by a cause: “I don't want to stop playing my video game.” This makes sense; we all get angry. With a behavioral plan, we validate that anger (“I see that you're frustrated”) but tie it to a more appropriate behavior (“If you shut down your game appropriately, you can have 15 extra minutes tomorrow”). The lesson is that any emotion is OK, but certain actions are not.

Behavioral plans are evidence-based ADHD care. However, they are often abandoned early because they may require exhausting effort and lots of modification to work. Keep adjusting until you have a strategy that works and consult with a professional or coach if your system seems ineffective.

Strategy #3: ADHD Medication

Many people manage medical disorders without medication, and that's great when it works. But sometimes, our health requires more. That's why medication may play a significant role in fostering emotional regulation in individuals with ADHD.

ADHD is a medical disorder. This doesn't mean that medication is the only tool to cope with it, but it does validate considering medication. ADHD medications are safe and effective when used appropriately. Despite common misperceptions, the correct medication should have benefits with no significant side effects.

ADHD medications do not primarily address emotional reactivity, but they often help. Since irritability can get better or worse with ADHD medication (better when you're on the right one), monitor your child's symptoms closely while adjusting. Work with your doctor to find the right dose and medication until you feel comfortable with what your child takes.

When selecting ADHD medication, the clinician must also consider the possibility of a co-occurring condition. Up to two-thirds of children with ADHD have one, such as anxiety or a sleep disorder. These disorders may affect emotional symptoms independently of ADHD.

Strategy #4: Mindfulness Meditation

Mindfulness means paying more unbiased, moment-to-moment attention to how things are right now, for better or worse. The premise, to be clear, isn't that we will always be calm or happy. Life is inherently changing and uncertain, and we benefit from skills to navigate that reality.

Emotional regulation is one of the most proven benefits of mindfulness. Over time, it trains our brain like a muscle. We hardwire new traits, such as observing discomfort without reacting immediately. We can practice noting emotions without falling into our habitual patterns.

Most of us spend a lot of time distracted, reactive, and on autopilot. For example, we might feel overwhelmed when our child has another tantrum and fall into unthinking habits ourselves, like caving in or using over-the-top consequences. But with mindfulness, our ability to stay settled expands, allowing us to see our options with clarity and act with clearer purpose.

Mindfulness is usually done through meditation—we focus on something neutral, like our breath or the feeling of our feet on the floor, as a place to return to when our busy mind wanders. When the next distraction happens, we start again. Through that, we create a new habit of awareness and skill in managing emotions.

For families, mindfulness begins with adults. It's not much use telling someone else, like our children, to practice mindfulness while we overreact emotionally. It is also an unavoidable part of life that anger and reactivity lead to more anger and reactivity. Live mindfully, and your children learn mindfulness from observing you.

When you see an opportunity, introduce mindfulness for your kids—maybe through a brief bedtime meditation for a younger child or finding a teen group for an older one. Even if your child doesn't buy in initially, the broader goal is to plant seeds that, one day, will lead to a consistent mindfulness practice for your children.

With time, mindfulness becomes instinctual. We notice what's going on internally ("I'm so furious") and create space for healthier choices ("I'm going to settle down before I figure out what to do"). Not surprisingly, studies show specific benefits for managing emotions in children with ADHD, some even as young as seven years old.

Tantrums, anger, and emotionality related to ADHD increase stress, decrease positive connections, and generally make life difficult. The pattern, in turn, erodes the resilience required to manage ADHD in the first place, further escalating everyone's emotions. There are even health implications: Chronic intense tantrums make it harder to get kids to eat, sleep, or even exercise, again undermining emotional management. Getting anger and emotion under control has layers of benefits.

Mark Bertin, M.D., is a developmental pediatrician in Pleasantville, New York, and author of How Children Thrive and Mindful Parenting for ADHD.

The Key to ADHD Emotional Regulation? Cultivating Gratitude, Pride, and Compassion

By Caroline Buzanko, Ph.D.

The emotional component of ADHD is nearly as profound as it is underestimated.

Children with ADHD experience the same emotions as other children, but their feelings are more frequent, intense, and longer-lasting. Because the underlying brain mechanisms that help manage emotions are affected by ADHD, emotional regulation development is delayed. Emotion hits them more quickly, and it more easily overwhelms them. The result? Big, exaggerated overreactions. What's more, children with ADHD have a tough time self-soothing; they need more time to calm down and get over grudges.

Parents tell me that managing their kids' outbursts—and notoriously intense mood swings—is their most challenging struggle. Emotional dysregulation affects well-being, family life, academic achievement, and vocational success. It contributes to low self-esteem and social difficulties more than any other symptom of ADHD. Emotional dysregulation can also persist into adulthood and usually worsens with age, so early intervention is essential.

Emotional Brain vs. Cognitive Brain

Most interventions designed to teach emotional regulation are ineffective—even counterproductive—for children with ADHD because they rely on using the cognitive brain (e.g., executive functions) to control the emotional brain. But executive dysfunction is common in the ADHD brain, which often makes association errors when it's upset. As a result, a child's cognitive brain may actually promote problem behaviors and then justify the behavior afterward.

For example, a child may hit a classmate who cheated at soccer and feel justified because the punch was meant to teach a lesson—even if his teacher had warned them before recess not to hit. The child's cognitive brain reacted to the cheating in an impulsive and ineffective way; it could not see clearly how to make a better decision at the moment.

Another problem is that using the cognitive brain is effortful, and it tires very quickly. Working on an essay, for example, will deplete kids' brain power, leaving few resources to make good decisions on the playground at recess. Children with ADHD might keep their cool at school but then melt down when they get home. And, as any parent can attest, getting kids to think rationally, to identify if they are in the “red zone,” or to use any calming strategy when they are in meltdown mode does not work.

For kids with ADHD, a more effective way to teach self-regulation skills is by harnessing the power of the emotional brain.

The emotional brain is immensely powerful. Unlike the cognitive brain, the emotional brain is infinite. Emotions get stronger the more they are used. Emotions are stronger motivators than reason. The emotional brain acts quicker than the cognitive brain. And emotions are contagious (watch any child in the heat of a temper tantrum, and you will see a quick increase in parent frustration).

When upset, the emotional brain will overpower the cognitive brain every time. For children with ADHD, whose emotions are more automatic and intense than others, emotion takes over all thinking and influences what happens next in any situation. Often, they will either lash out or disengage completely. The bottom line: Kids with ADHD cannot use their cognitive brain when they are upset. Therefore, why not use their strong emotional brain to our advantage?

How to Harness the Emotional Brain for Regulation

When it comes to emotion regulation, the best strategies are proactive and positive. This is especially important for kids with ADHD because they invest so much effort into doing well and controlling themselves. Unfortunately, they overreact and get so much more corrective feedback than other kids, which is very disheartening.

Since down-regulating negative emotions is so cognitively effortful, up-regulating positive emotions is a better approach because it is easier to do and increases the likelihood of success. Many of the positive parenting strategies you're already using—novelty, rewards, and making tasks engaging—are effective in promoting positive emotions, too. Why? Because we seek tasks that promote helpful, feel-good emotions and contribute to motivation and persistence.

In any situation, proactively regulating positive emotions helps reduce problem behaviors (with the bonus of building self-esteem and cooperation).

For example, my daughter used to fight with me every morning about going to school because lunch was stressful. To help her overcome this hurdle, we tapped into her emotional brain by giving her things to look forward to—rather than worry about—at school. At the time, she had the important job of feeding the class fish, and she loved it. We discussed the pride she felt in contributing in such a valuable way to the classroom. That responsibility alone helped shift her from anticipating the things that could go wrong to what she was excited about.

At night we focused on strengthening the cognitive brain. Before she went to sleep, we worked on coping with anxiety. We talked about what to do when worry shows up (that

helps make it predictable) and reviewed how to problem-solve different scenarios, like what she could do if she had no one to eat with at lunch or if her friends didn't want to play a game she wanted to play at recess.

Three Prosocial Emotions That Bolster Emotional Regulation

Targeting future-oriented prosocial emotions is particularly important for children with ADHD because they live moment-to-moment, unable to think ahead about the consequences of their emotions or behaviors. Gratitude, pride, and compassion are three key future-oriented prosocial emotions that help build persistence, cooperation, and empathy in children with ADHD.

Six Ways to Cultivate Gratitude

Gratitude can rescue us from emotional (over)reactions and build delayed gratification. When we are thankful for what we have, we stop seeking out the next best thing. Here are some ideas that build gratitude.

1. **Give thanks every day.** Establish a family ritual, like discussing the five things you are grateful for every day or talking about what inspired you today.
2. **Make a gratitude jar.** Because children with ADHD are visual, writing down notes of gratitude each day may help them “see” this emotion.
3. **Encourage them to write thank you notes.** Part of being grateful is remembering all the important people in our life. Encourage your child to send notes of appreciation to people who've helped them during the week.
4. **Create a Tree of Support.** Have kids decorate a tree on a piece of paper or poster board and then write the names of everyone in their life who supports them—family members, friends, teachers, coaches, youth ministers, etc. Hang the tree somewhere prominent to remind them of all the supportive people in their lives.
5. **Make a Reciprocity Ring.** When someone needs help with something—homework or another type of task—they post the “job” on a sticky note or whiteboard. Think of it as a family “help wanted” ad. The helper then writes their name on the paper. This is a visual way for family members to see how they are supported by each other. Helping others makes us feel good. Having these acts of generosity on display promotes family harmony by fostering cooperation and collaboration.
6. **Write *I Noticed* notes.** Catching and recognizing acts of goodness is especially important for kids with ADHD, who receive so much criticism throughout their day. *I Noticed* notes are a great way to highlight prosocial behavior and provide a constant stream of positive feedback, which helps kids with ADHD stay on track.

They also build gratitude because someone is taking time out of their day to compose a handwritten note.

Three Ways to Build Pride

Pride is another goal-directed emotion that directly promotes self-control, effort, and perseverance—even more than motivation, self-efficacy, self-esteem, or even just being happy. When we are proud, we are motivated to work harder. The keys to building pride are connection and contribution. Children need to feel like they are doing something valuable for people who are important to them.

- **Allow your child to be an expert in something that interests them.** Dog walker. Video game master. Bathroom sink cleaner. It really doesn't matter. What's important is to find something the child is good at and create opportunities for them to share their knowledge or skill. Let them help make important decisions within their field of expertise, too.
- **Give your child an important job to do.** Yes, even if you can do it yourself in half the time with a fraction of the mess. Be on the lookout for basic life skills such as cooking scrambled eggs or ironing a cotton shirt. Kids benefit when they contribute meaningfully to the family—and you do, too. Even if they work independently, children will work longer on hard tasks when they think they are contributing to the group. Maybe there's a chore (pumping up the bike tires, perhaps?) they can complete that will contribute to the whole family going for a bike ride together. Motivate them to work through a hard task by playing upbeat music or offering encouragement as they do it.
- **Make a skills board.** List things they're good at or things that others value, such as comforting small children or being very thoughtful when others are hurt.

Ways to Help Your Child Act with Compassion

Compassion is a critical prosocial emotion that helps overcome anxiety, avoidance, and procrastination while promoting empathy and cooperation.

1. **Treat your family like a team.** The best way to promote compassion is through similarity. Any cue can work, even wearing the same color. That's why athletes wear the same team jersey. It unites them as a team. Maybe you can clean up an outdoor community space together as a family. On the designated Saturday, don T-shirts specifically designed for the occasion. Working together towards a goal, sharing areas of interest, acknowledging each other's achievements, and supporting others are all ways to promote compassion.
2. **Play a conversation-starting game** like Never Have I Ever. Each player takes a turn asking other players about things they haven't done. For example, "I've never broken my arm." If a player in the game has had a broken arm, they keep score on a piece of

paper. Play continues until everyone has had a chance to contribute. These sorts of experiences help kids see the many ways they connect to others.

3. **Practice mindfulness meditation.** Buddhist monks originated meditation ages ago as a way to develop compassion, and this centuries-old tradition works just as well today. There are plenty of guided meditation apps, but it's easy to carve out opportunities to practice being in the present moment—noticing smells, sounds, and textures during a neighborhood walk.
4. **Teach children to practice self-compassion.** Self-compassion is important for children with ADHD because of the amount of corrective feedback they get and the amount of guilt and shame they often experience. Self-compassion allows them to accept mistakes, as well as the fact that having ADHD might mean they have to work harder than others on certain things. Talking about neurodiversity and everyone's strengths and challenges is a great way to build self-compassion in the early stages. Just like I need glasses to see as far as others, they may need an extra cool-down period after recess before they can settle into learning. Be sure to point to the upside of having ADHD—being energetic or extremely creative, for example—when having strengths and weaknesses conversations.
5. **Teach them about their brain.** Teaching children about their brain—how it is still developing and how they can help build it through diet, sleep, and coping skills—is also helpful. Then, for example, when kids get distracted, they understand that their brain got too excited by the sound in the hallway and can figure out what they need to do to get their brain back on track (vs. internalizing “I am stupid”).

Experiment with different ways to incorporate gratitude, pride, and compassion into your child's life. Remember, kids constantly change. So, too, will your family's strategies for building emotional control through positivity. Be patient and know that nothing is a substitute for focused practice and constructive feedback.

Caroline Buzanko, Ph.D., is a licensed psychologist and clinical director of Koru Family Psychology.

From Lizard Brain to Wizard Brain: Teaching (and Learning) Emotional Regulation

By Rebecca Branstetter, Ph.D.

I saw a parenting meme in my feed the other day that hit pretty dang close to home.

It was a split screen of how parents start their day (as the happy, soft-spoken dinosaur from *Toy Story* and how they end their day (as the terrifying T-Rex from *Jurassic Park* roaring one inch from your face).

I feel that.

We all start out the day fresh and ready to be positive, proactive, and empathic with whatever challenges our children are facing. When we're rested, we typically have the patience to respond calmly when they are reactive or having a hard time (like when a toddler screams and throws a tantrum because there are RAISINS in her RAISIN Bran...hypothetically speaking, of course). As the day wears on, parental patience wears thin, and we tend to be more reactive, triggered, and annoyed when our children act out or shut down.

Complicating matters is the inescapable fact that our baseline for maintaining inner calm has moved. Most parents are operating with a higher level of stress.

Our kids are under unprecedented stress, too. Their tolerance for this stress may also be smaller than usual. And if your child has ADHD or emotional reactivity challenges, they may go from happy Rex to full Jurassic Park in seconds flat.

Given this stressful dynamic, it's no wonder we're all buckling under the heavy load of big reactions—whether it's blowing up or shutting down—from things as small as raisins or as big as an outbreak at school.

Lizard Brain vs. Wizard Brain

Neither parent nor child wakes up in the morning planning to be a terrible lizard.

When stress is triggered in either parent or child, two spooky sci-fi things happen. (Nope, I'm not talking about extracting-DNA-and-recreating-dinos kind of sci-fi. This is even spookier.)

Spooky Sci-Fi Fact #1: We are evolutionarily pre-programmed to match others' emotions before we can even mentally register that we are doing it.

This means that stress and uncomfortable emotions like anxiety, anger, and sadness are highly contagious. We “catch” the stress from our kids, and our kids “catch” it from us.

Y’all, the whole process takes milliseconds.

When your kid flips out and gets angry because you calmly ask them to put away their dirty socks, your calm turns to anger before you can consciously register it. When you are stressed out about an email that pops up on your phone from work, and you feel tense, your child feels that same tension as if it were their own.

Spooky Sci-Fi Fact #2: All stress, big or small, real or imagined, registers the same way—DANGER!—and we go into the “brain stem,” the part of the brain responsible for survival.

This primitive part of the brain literally does not know the difference between the stress of struggling with a math assignment or the stress of a saber-toothed tiger. Either way, the amygdala, the fear center of the brain, lights up like a Roman candle, and we go into fight or flight mode (or the modern-day version: acting out or shutting down).

With kiddos, I sometimes call it “lizard brain” because primitive responses to stress do not involve logic or thinking. All our “brain juice” (a term I just made up) goes to survival, and we don’t have any cognitive resources left for thinking straight.

As I teach in my online positive parenting courses, problem-solving cannot occur in “lizard brain” mode.

Yet, when our kids get stuck in the brain stem, it’s soooooo tempting to address them with logic, problem-solving, or a valuable adult life lesson such as: “When a company advertises a product with raisins, it likely has raisins in it! So just eat it!” or, “It’s just a math worksheet. It will only take 10 minutes, so just calm down and finish it!”

It doesn’t take much imagination to picture how these life lessons go over in those lizard brain moments. Yep, your child may go full Jurassic on you. Then, you instinctively go Jurassic on them, and there’s two angry dinos in the room (see Spooky Sci-Fi Fact #1).

Tapping Into the Wizard Brain

You might be thinking, “OK, great, so basically, we are destined to trigger and re-trigger each other all day long?”

Nope! I have good news for you.

You have a fully developed wizard brain (frontal lobe—the “stop and think” part of your brain that is built to pause and respond skillfully, with calmness).

And the even better news is that calm emotions are also contagious! When you come into a situation with calm, it triggers calm in your child. When you take a pause before responding to your child’s anger, their anger subsides. This process of up-regulating or down-regulating your child’s emotions is called “co-regulation.” You can bring calm or chaos to a situation by how you respond.

And once both parties are calm, problem-solving can begin. Our “wizard brains” (frontal lobes) are back online.

But how do parents cultivate inner calm amid craziness? What sounds good in theory is much harder to do when you’ve been triggered.

The following strategy for keeping calm in a stressful situation with your child is simple, but it is not necessarily easy until you remember and practice this: Take care of yourself first. Escalated parents can’t de-escalate their children. Your calm teaches your child calm.

Wait! Don’t go!

This is not the part where I tell you to practice self-care: take up yoga, practice meditation, and carve out heaps of “me time.”

Don’t get me wrong; self-care is great, but those are things you do “off the job” as a parent. They can lengthen your fuse, but the fuse is always still there.

The problem with self-care activities is that it’s hard to do them in the Jurassic parenting moment. You can’t just bail on your wailing, dysregulated kid and drive off to a yoga class right then and there.

So, this is the part where I share what can you do “on the job” when the stressful moment is actively going down.

What to Do When the Lizard Attacks

First, become aware of when you’re being triggered. Is it a bodily sensation, like a tight chest or clenched jaw? Or is it a thought, like, “Why are they giving me such a hard time?” or “How many times do I have to tell them?” or “Why are they making such a big deal over nothing?” If you can catch the thought or feeling before you respond, that’s huge.

Second, practicing empathy is the fastest route to calming yourself and your child during a heated moment. Remind yourself that your child is in “brain stem” and in a moment of suffering, too. They aren’t giving you a hard time; they are having a hard time.

Third, this one tip from Kristen Neff, Ph.D., self-compassion researcher, has been a game changer in my parenting: In a Jurassic Moment, I do a “one for me/one for you” breath before responding. One breath for me (I am having a hard time) and one breath for my child (this is hard for you, too). It helps me stay calm and helps model for my child how to pause before responding and how to empathize in challenging times.

And speaking of self-compassion, remember to give yourself self-compassion if you T-Rex out from time to time! If you lose your cool with your child, it’s okay. It’s human. It happens, especially when we are under stress and have a shorter fuse than normal. Take the time to apologize to your child—it’s a teachable moment. When you say, “I am sorry I yelled. I was feeling frustrated, and next time I will take a few deep breaths,” you are teaching them what to do next time they are frustrated or make a mistake.

Rebecca Branstetter, Ph.D., is a school psychologist, author, and expert in child development and education.

ADHD and Emotional Regulation: A Parent's Guide

By Liz Matheis, Ph.D.

What is self-regulation, exactly?

Most people would agree that ADHD's primary challenges include focus, sustained attention, organization, and memory. However, many children with ADHD also struggle to regulate their emotions. This struggle manifests as big bursts of anger or frustration, or extreme giddiness that seems incongruent with the immediate situation. Many parents describe this as “going from 0 to 60 in 3.2 seconds and with little warning.”

Studies show that affect or emotional regulation problems impact children and adolescents with ADHD because the part of the brain that controls behavior connects to the part that regulates emotions. You may call this phenomenon “big feelings” and “big reactions” in your home. But, let me get technical: Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D., defines self-regulation as “the means by which an individual manages herself to attain a goal.” Let me take it one step further and technically define emotions.

Say Hello to My Emotions

According to a study published in the *International Journal of Clinical Medicine*, emotions are signals that alert your body to happenings around you. Those signals are powered by our senses—touch, hearing, smell, sight, and taste. We can either translate what is going on and respond negatively, neutrally, or positively (e.g., I see a familiar face in the supermarket, and I say “hello”), or we can perceive something as a dangerous situation and become panicked (e.g., I'm going to look at the ground and run down another aisle).

Log In to Self-Awareness

What does this mean for you and your child with ADHD? To help a child who becomes emotionally inundated, we must work to increase their awareness of feelings in the moment and of situational perceptions—are they feeling positive, neutral, or negative and why. A therapist using a cognitive behavioral approach can help work toward this goal. But a helpful first step is keeping a log or journal of the type of situations that trigger your child to become angry, upset, frustrated, anxious, or sad. For example, your child may erupt in anger after working on two math problems. Or your child may get frustrated trying to follow multiple bedtime instructions at once.

Why is your child feeling that way? Your best source of information is your child: Ask them! “I noticed that sitting down to work on your math homework often makes you angry. Why do you think that happens?” If your child says, “I DON’T KNOW! I JUST DO,” you can offer two (and only two) answer choices. For example, “Is math hard for you? Or would you rather be doing something else?” This will facilitate discussion and offer insight or awareness as you work to discern what thought processes are being trumped by dysregulating emotions.

Hit Pause and Break It Down

When your child’s emotions hijack their body, it feels nearly impossible to hit the pause button. As a parent and clinician, I lower the volume of my voice and speak slowly to the child or adolescent. I say, “I know this is hard for you. Let’s think about what’s going on so this doesn’t have to be so hard.” This message can be validating for your child. Even if they can’t verbalize how they feel and why, they understand that you get it, and that can be relieving.

In your slow and quiet voice, try to break down the task that your child is working on. Take out a piece of paper or small whiteboard and write down the steps associated with the task. For example, making a sandwich:

1. Take out bread, take out peanut butter and jam, take out knife.
2. Spread peanut butter on one slice of bread.
3. Spread jam on the other slice of bread. Assemble sandwich.
4. Take out foil.
5. Wrap sandwich in foil.

Because your child may be easily distracted by your home’s sounds and activities, this step-by-step approach may help them see the task of making a sandwich as a feasible progression of steps rather than a big task that takes a “really long time.” The ultimate goal: Your child internalizes this process and (after much practice) no longer needs the whiteboard.

Praise It!

We all love to be told that we did something well. We feel better about ourselves, and we are encouraged to succeed again so that we can gain that praise. As your child makes small strides, a simple “I like the way you made your sandwich so quickly and easily today” goes a long way. It’s very easy to point out all the things forgotten or left incomplete. Try “ignoring” that and focusing on what your child did do well. You may find that you’re both happier and more focused on the big picture.

Liz Matheis, Ph.D., is a licensed clinical psychologist and certified school psychologist.

11 Strategies That Improve Emotional Control at School and Home

By Caroline Maguire, M.Ed., ACCG, PCC

Executive function and emotional control walk in lockstep. Stress and emotional flooding affect how children with ADHD learn, play, engage with classmates, follow directions, and retain information. When they enter a heightened state of arousal, their ADHD brain wiring can interfere with social-emotional learning and sabotage self-regulation, making it difficult to access the curriculum, respond appropriately, reframe challenges, react with strategies, or problem-solve.

How Educators Can Promote Emotional Control in Students

Create a “pattern interrupt” by engaging in an exercise shown to reduce cortisol and adrenaline levels, increase dopamine levels, and release endorphins to induce a calmer state of mind. Shift a classroom’s internal chemistry by doing jumping jacks, jumping like a frog, walking like a bear on your hands and knees, stomping like an elephant, stretching to touch the sky, walking up and down the stairs, or touching toes.

Model emotional coping strategies by leading and posting regulation strategies in the classroom. Create a Zen corner, and engage in mindful meditation practices to demonstrate their daily utility. Give each student a code word to alert you when they are struggling.

Reflect on and talk about book characters’ emotions to build a culture of empathy. Connect a character’s emotional state, reactions, and decision-making to students’ inner emotional worlds. Build lifelong relationship-management skills by teaching students to reflect on their emotional state, recognize and share feelings, and step into others’ shoes.

Each morning, ask students to take a deep breath, then gauge and name their emotional state or point to an emoji chart. Offer calming strategies to begin the day. This five-minute exercise will pay dividends as children free up mental and emotional energy for the day’s curriculum.

When friends or frenemies clash, prompt children to step into each other’s shoes and take their own emotional temperature. Prompt them to consider whether they need space to be less reactive and suggest centering strategies like quietly repeating a mantra such as, “I am OK.”

Improve students' emotional vocabulary by posting a rich word bank for various nuanced emotional states—in book characters and in themselves. Alternatives to “angry” may be “disappointed,” “irritated,” or “annoyed.” Alternatives to “happy” might be “relieved,” “giddy,” or “content.”

How Parents Can Promote Emotional Control in Children with ADHD

Teach your child how their brain works. When the thalamus perceives a threat, stressor, or danger, the amygdala will sound an alarm and create a cascade of heightened emotions. When children understand how this flooding affects them, they can better identify the sensations of fight, flight, or fear—such as a pounding heart, sweaty palms, and so on.

Help your child differentiate a thinking brain—one that can problem-solve, learn, and pay attention—from a reactive brain that argues, yells, becomes snappy, or feels flooded with emotions. When a child understands how they act in different emotional states, they are better able to catch and reverse actions or tone synonymous with a reactive state.

Label emotions with detail. Teach your child to identify, name, and process emotional nuances, such as feeling hopeful, overwhelmed, disappointed, or frustrated. By labeling emotions accurately, children are empowered to take the first step in processing them.

Some children ruminate and catastrophize, labeling every setback or challenge “the end of the world.” This happens due to an overactive cingulate gyrus—the gear shifter in the brain. If this gets stuck, cycling from thought to thought or activity to activity can be hard. Help your child get unstuck by showing them how to do an emotional temperature body scan and asking, “Am I ruminating?” “Am I stuck?” If the answer is yes, engage in mindfulness practices to de-escalate the effects of rumination.

Challenge perceptions when your child seems reactive and overly emotional. Help them impartially compare the context of the situation to the story replaying in their head. Teach your child to double-check, not assume. Maybe they didn't fully understand the comment, intention, or act. “What evidence is there that this story is true? What else could the answer be?” Now, work with them to alter their inner story by replacing negative thoughts with neutral thoughts. Replace “I know they are ignoring my text,” to “They are probably busy and can't respond right away.”

Caroline Maguire, M.Ed., ACCG, PCC, is the founder of a Social Emotional Learning methodology that breaks down the complexity of human connection into easy actionable steps and the author of Why Will No One Play with Me?

Like Hugging a Time Bomb: How to Calm an Emotionally Dysregulated Teen with ADHD

By Brendan Mahan, M.Ed., M.S.

“My 15-year-old son just won’t do dishes, do homework assignments, etc. He just refuses, which triggers the entire family.”

“How do you get through to a child who constantly shuts down and gets angry when you question them about missed homework?”

“What do you do when kids call themselves stupid and useless?”

“What if your preteen claims they are bored every time they are not on a screen?”

In teens with ADHD, emotional dysregulation can seem to take infinite forms. Today, emotional triggers are more varied and plentiful than ever—as are the manifestations of adolescents’ stress. Puberty and too much screen time, among other factors, have left many teens with ADHD feeling heightened and prolonged anxiety, frustration, fatigue, and anger. The end result is good for no one.

Even if your dysregulated, burned-out teen builds walls to keep you out, you can help turn things around by recognizing how stress uniquely affects them, de-escalating their worries and intense emotions, and connecting with them in productive, healthy ways. Below are strategies for supporting, stabilizing, and building resilience in your teen.

Dysregulated Teens with ADHD

Puberty alone triggers emotional upheaval in the teen brain. Add ADHD, and the associated symptom of emotional dysregulation, and you’ve got a potentially explosive mix. It may appear otherwise, but your teen is trying their best. Their troubling behaviors are often masking stress and other worries. This stress often appears as:

- Resistance—“I don’t want to clean my room” or “I don’t want to do chores.”
- Tiredness/exhaustion—“I am too tired to do anything!”
- Apathy—“Why should I do my work? School doesn’t matter.”
- Boredom—often code for sadness.
- Displaced anger/frustration standing in for anxiety.
- Numbing out, mostly via screen time, to escape tediousness and find variability.

Stress also leads to emotional dysregulation—deviations from normal behaviors and moods that may look like this:

- More movement than usual (pacing, fidgeting, handwringing)
- Larger expressions of emotion (yelling, swearing, physical gestures)
- Uncontrolled emotions, which can even include unusual levels of happiness, excitement, and other “positive” behaviors
- Smaller gestures (short responses, stonewalling)

Dysregulated Teens with ADHD: Connect to Regulate

Dysregulated emotions and behaviors impair effective communication. When tempers flare (including yours), no productive conversations will follow. So how can you help your teen alleviate stress and regulate their emotions so that you can live in harmony? By creating positive experiences that build connections. The truth is, teens are most likely to fix their problems with help from parents, but if they feel they can't connect with you, they won't ask for help.

Operate under these fundamental assumptions to pave the way to productive parent-child interactions:

- Everyone, including your teen, is doing the best they can. If someone is not doing well enough, it's because they lack skills, not because they don't want to do well. Your gentle encouragement and support can carry them through.
- You and your teen are on the same team. It's you and your kid versus the problem. (Even if they caused the problem.)
- It isn't personal. Your child isn't trying to deliberately upset or disrespect you. Remember that emotional dysregulation is real. Don't let your fuse get lit, and don't light your kid's fuse, either.
- Unconditional love and forgiveness—even and especially in the toughest of times—is the only way.

Emotional vs. Cognitive Communication

Where we are “coming from” when we communicate is crucial to solving problems rather than escalating them. Generally, people use two types of communication modes:

- **Emotional communication focuses on feelings over facts.** It is often accompanied by swearing, defensiveness, shutting down, and aggression. This is a valid form of expression, and it frequently occurs when a person is close to the issue at hand. But this mode of communication is not always the most helpful. When we are dysregulated, emotional communication tends to take over.

- **Cognitive communication** focuses on problem-solving and facts over emotions. While this mode is usually the most helpful, it can lead to getting caught up in “winning the argument.” This type of communicator may appear dismissive and aloof to an emotional communicator.

Though undoubtedly difficult at times, it’s best to set an example for your teen and engage in cognitive communication as much as possible. Be aware of and try your best to regulate your own emotional state so that your child can match your cognitive approach. To ease the transition from emotional to cognitive communication for your adolescent:

- **Validate their emotions** by naming the emotions you’re detecting from your teen in a non-judgmental way. This lets them know that you “see” them and helps them identify their own emotions.
- **Use reflective listening** (i.e., repeat back a summary of what they said) to validate their feelings and show that you understand their problems. Genuine reflection and validation also help build trust and comfort around opening up.
- **Take a walk** with them to get the connection flowing. Movement and a different setting are more conducive to connection and conversation than an unproductive, interrogation-style approach.
- **Take a break from conversation** because not everything has to be said in one sitting. You can return to a tough subject later when they’re all calmer. The break may even help to get a new perspective.
- **Gestures of comfort** are powerful. No matter how small the gesture, do something for your overwhelmed teen that they will appreciate, like making them a cup of hot chocolate or giving them some time to themselves.
- **The right kind of pressure** can sometimes be the push your child needs. Firmly stating, for example, that you don’t want your own emotions to escalate can snap your child into a cognitive state. This method, however, depends on your individual child and should be used as a last resort and should not be done as a threat.
- **Recognize cursing and yelling for what they are**—surface indicators of a deeper problem. Typically, teens who resort to cursing and volatility, especially if it’s out of the norm for them, are communicating their overwhelm with a difficult situation. Keep your calm when this happens and try other ways to engage.

Dysregulated Teens: How to De-Escalate

On the spectrum of anxiety, your teen’s baseline is likely somewhere between moderate and severe at the moment. More stressors push your teen into fight, flight, or freeze mode, leading to dysregulation before your teen can return to baseline.

Helping your teen learn to de-escalate stress in the short and long term can make a major difference in their emotions and behaviors. Some helpful strategies include:

- Prioritize physical needs, like sleep, nutrition, and movement.
- Engage in temporary escapism. If you're trying to get your teen off screens, make sure you can actually offer an engaging alternative, like a fun board game, a scavenger hunt, or a short outdoor adventure.
- Connect with others (calling or texting a friend, visiting family).
- Exercise (playing a sport, bodybuilding, going for a run).
- Enjoy small comforts (eating a favorite meal, hugging a pet).
- Build skills, be it in a sport, music, or another hobby, to boost overall confidence.
- Allow your teen to identify their own de-escalation strategies.
- Turn off the news.
- Avoid conversations about personal frustrations and concerns.
- Set clear and appropriate expectations for them; remain consistent.
- Apologize when you make mistakes and lose your cool with them.
- Celebrate accomplishments and support them through difficult problems.
- Confront challenges head-on. Sometimes, accepting anxiety and leaning into fears can teach teens that they are more capable than they know.

Brendan Mahan, M.Ed., M.S., is the producer and host of the ADHD Essentials podcast.

The content for this article was derived from the ADDitude webinar titled "When Teen Stress Ignites Strong Emotions: Teaching Anger and Frustration Management," with Brendan Mahan, M.Ed., M.S.

Keep Calm and Breathe Om: 7 ADHD Relaxation Techniques

ADHD symptoms can trigger stress at work, at home, during the commute, at the PTA meeting... and so on. Use these relaxation strategies to stay cool when things heat up.

“I finally did it!” Bob, an adult with ADHD, said to himself, as he walked out of the office at 5 p.m. sharp, to meet his wife for dinner. For the first time in years, he wasn’t late.

More importantly, he was ready to enjoy the night out because he felt relaxed and in control. Bob no longer waited until the eleventh hour to complete his client reports—a stressful pattern that had affected his health and his marriage.

How did Bob cut workplace stress and learn to stay calm under pressure? By using a watch that beeped every hour, so that he made sure he was following his to-do list, a year-long calendar with color-coded client deadlines, ADHD-specific relaxation techniques, and a notebook in which he “parked” random thoughts during the day. The result: less stress and a happier life.

Many people with ADHD live in a constant state of stress. Their neurobiology makes it difficult to screen out competing stimuli, focus, and slow down, increasing frustration levels. Being unable to measure up to people’s expectations or feeling guilty about missing deadlines at work creates additional tension.

Like Bob, you can reduce stress with strategies that target your ADHD symptoms. Here are some to try:

Acknowledge Your ADHD

Stop blaming yourself for forgetting chores or missing a deadline. Recognize the real culprit: ADHD is neurobiological, and it won’t go away. Get a proper diagnosis and treatment. Sign up for a local ADHD support group or an online forum. Merely realizing that you are not alone can reduce stress.

CHAPTER 5: EMOTIONAL REGULATION STRATEGIES THAT WORK

Exercise Your Options

Exercise is a potent stress reducer. Physical activity increases the brain's serotonin levels, which combats the stress hormone cortisol. Studies suggest that one exercise session of 30 to 45 minutes can improve mood and increase relaxation for 90 to 120 minutes. Exercise, over time, raises your threshold for stress.

Measure Time

Most people with ADHD see time as a fluid thing. To better gauge time, buy a watch with a timer and set it to go off every hour. If you always need “just five more minutes,” get a countdown timer that will sound after five minutes.

My client, Linda, spent hours on the Internet, then found herself scrambling at the end of the day to meet deadlines. A stopwatch, set to go off every hour, periodically roused her from her online reverie.

Create Boundaries

Overbooking your time can raise stress. Whether the cause is pure impulsivity or an internal voice saying, “I should do x, y, and z,” stress takes its toll on your mind. Practice saying “no” three times a day. And every time you say “yes,” ask yourself, “What am I saying ‘no’ to?”

Make Structure Your Friend

A reliable routine can minimize chaos. Try these tips, both of which work wonders for my clients: Before bed, plan the next day—list what you will do, when, and how. You'll awake more centered. Also, go to bed and get up at the same time each day. This stabilizes body rhythms, increasing your chances of getting a sound sleep.

Take Time to Play

By not taking breaks from today's busy life, you set yourself up for burnout. Schedule fun into your life. Have dinner or go to a movie with friends every week. Take a drive into the country or to the beach on the weekend. Figure out what you love and pursue it without guilt.

Remain Vigilant

Many of my clients have a false sense of security once they make a few gains, and then abandon the strategies that got them there. Forgetting you have ADHD is a hallmark of the condition. Don't let down your guard!

CHAPTER 5: EMOTIONAL REGULATION STRATEGIES THAT WORK

ADHD Relaxation Responses

People with ADHD often don't recognize that they're stressed until they are in the middle of a meltdown. Several times a day, take inventory of how you are feeling: Are your muscles tense? Is your heart racing?

If so, do one of the following:

- Close your eyes and take 20 slow, deep breaths.
- Stand up and stretch for several minutes.
- Take a five-minute walk outside.

This article was written by Nancy Ratey, Ed.M., a Master Certified Coach, Senior Disability Analyst, and internationally recognized authority on personal and professional coaching for adults with ADHD.

Expert Q&A with Ellen Littman, Ph.D.

Q: “How do I respond when my emotional teen crosses the line?”

This question has been around since the beginning of ADHD. Deep down, probably all parents of explosive teens with ADHD know that no single consequence can make their impulsive, emotionally dysregulated brains stop and reassess their actions. As a result, most advice around consequences for negative behaviors is ineffective.

The best way to respond when your teen is out of control is to remove yourself from the situation. For one, your teen probably won't remove themselves if you ask them. Second, nobody—not even your teen—can change how they're experiencing emotions in the heat of the moment. With ADHD and emotional dysregulation, it is not that your teen *won't* control their behaviors, but that they can't.

Removing yourself from the situation still sets boundaries. It conveys to your teen that, while you're aware that they're not in control of their explosive emotions, you have the ability to protect yourself, which redefines the confrontation. You can say to your teen, “Even though I know that things are out of control for you right now, I can't allow myself to be treated that way. As soon as you feel more in control, come back and find me because I want to talk to you about it.”

No matter the situation, it's important that you communicate to your teen that you're not rejecting them but setting limits on overt behaviors. We know that with emotional dysregulation comes increased risk for low self-esteem and shame in teens with ADHD. Rather than label your child negatively, remind yourself that underneath the out-of-control behaviors is the wonderful child you adore.

Ellen Littman, Ph.D., is a clinical psychologist licensed in New York and co-author of Understanding Girls with ADHD.

The content for this article was derived, in part, from the ADDitude webinar titled “How Emotional Dysregulation & ADHD Transform Teen Relationships from Messes to Minefields,” with Ellen Littman, Ph.D.

Expert Q&A with Sharon Saline, Psy.D.

Q: “I feel defeated as a parent. My two kids (ages 6 and 8) and I all have ADHD. I have become that always-yelling, high-anxiety mom, and I don’t like what I see. Can you help?”

You are brave to share such an honest assessment of yourself and your parenting. It’s really hard to parent kids when you have ADHD. Remember, people with ADHD struggle with emotional control very naturally. ADHD brings with it other impairments like challenges with working memory, a key executive functioning skill that is innately tied to emotional control. When you and your kids struggle with emotional control, you’re also struggling with working memory.

You can help yourself by noticing when you start to feel dysregulated (I call it heading toward the edge). Look for signs in your body. I’m very emotional, and I admit emotional control is not one of my strengths. I come from a long line of neurotic, intense women, and I get pretty easily triggered. I have certainly lost it as a parent. Over the years I’ve worked at noticing when I’m getting upset, and I’ve learned what I can do in the moment to calm down, and it really helps.

When my emotions are activated, my stomach starts to clench. My heart pounds and I feel short of breath. Notice how your body responds when you get dysregulated and teach your kids to recognize it in themselves.

Strategize in advance what you can do to soothe yourself during those times instead of being surprised each time it occurs. This is where working memory comes in. It’s important to create a plan for success now because you need to manage yourself first to be effective with your kids. If you’re dysregulated, your kids will pick up on it and throw kindling on the fire that’s already burning inside of you.

Once you know your warning signs, think about what you can do to calm down. For me, splashing water on my face and washing my hands helps. I’m also a big fan of yogic breathing. Here’s how yogic breathing works: With the finger of your right hand, press your right nostril closed. Take a deep breath through the left nostril then close the left nostril with the finger of your left hand and exhale through your right nostril. Close the right nostril and inhale through the left nostril. Repeat inhaling and exhaling through opposite nostrils a few times until you feel calmer.

Sometimes you need to call a time-out for yourself, and that’s OK. If your children are too young to be left alone, go into the bathroom and close the door. (Kids understand that people go to the bathroom alone.) Take a few minutes to decompress even if there’s chaos on the other side.

Focus on just one aspect of regulating your emotions at a time. If you think, “I need to regulate all my emotions,” the task can become overwhelming. It’s too big of a chunk to tackle.

Ask your kids to join you in this endeavor. Help them identify emotional triggers and determine what part to work on first. Then, create a plan for when things bubble up and work on it together.

You've no doubt heard this before, but it bears repeating: Exercise is really helpful for people with ADHD. Exercise bathes the brain in endorphins, which makes you feel calm. Think about how you could bump up your daily exercise. Whether it's a 20-minute yoga session, walking around the block, or riding a bike, find some way to move daily.

Journaling is another great way to manage your feelings. At the end of each day, write down three good things. They don't have to be great or extraordinary things, just something that brought you pleasure. Maybe you enjoyed a good cup of tea or found \$5 in your pocket. Observing what's going well counteracts negative self-talk and the negativity bias that dominates our brains.

Q: "My son, 11, constantly annoys our cat by picking her up when she wants to be left alone. He apologizes but keeps doing it. How can I teach him that saying, 'I'm sorry' doesn't fix the poor choice or give permission to repeat it?"

Kids with ADHD apologize because they cannot control their impulses to do something that seems like a good idea at that moment. The reality is that, once they're doing what they want to do, they realize it's not a good idea and apologize. Can they retain information about what is and is not a good idea going forward? That's a slower process.

Working memory challenges, make it harder for kids with ADHD to learn the lessons they need to learn. They learn them, but the lessons are not encoded as quickly and efficiently as they would be in a neurotypical brain.

Institute apologies of action to help your child learn how to make sincere apologies. Instead of apologizing for the same thing over and over, have him think about how he could make amends. In the case of annoying the cat, what could your child do that would be nice for her? Perhaps the cat enjoys a gentle tummy rub or being brushed.

We want to help kids determine what it means to actually feel sorry, not just say they are sorry. Ask your son how he can show he is sorry. Share your ideas with him when he shares his.

This also helps kids learn that when they say they're sorry repeatedly, it's like the boy who cried wolf—the apology means less and less. Together, brainstorm some ideas for other things he could say. Put those responses on a refrigerator.

Q: "My almost 14-year-old lies vehemently. Even when he's caught red-handed—he denies it! Is this because he's a teenager and thinks he can get away with everything? It bothers me most when he lies about taking his medicine, and then expects us to trust him. What can we do?"

Parents often ask me what part of certain behaviors is due to ADHD and what part is adolescence. The answer is both. ADHD and adolescence are a beautiful mix—and they’re innately tied. A 14-year-old wants to get away with things. That’s a normal part of adolescence. Teens will push up against you to see how much they can get away with every time—and when they do it’s frustrating.

Why do kids with ADHD lie? Well, they lie for many reasons. One is because they want to see if they can get away with it... just like any teenager. Two is because they may feel bad about the decision they made. And three because they’re trying to figure out where they stop and where you begin. They grapple with things like what they have control over and what their independence looks like.

Your teenager is trying to assert his independence by not taking his medication and saying he did, “Oh, there I am... I’m a little independent.” It’s really important to explain trust to kids and to teach them that they earn trust—and independence—by doing good. Here’s a system that works for many families I counsel.

How ADHD Teens Can Earn Your Trust

Let your kids know that you’ve started a family trust bank account for them. When they lie, you take “money” (trust) from that account. They can add “money” back to the bank by doing what you and the child agreed to do. That’s part one.

The second part is on you. As parents, it is important to acknowledge trust-building behavior and make some deposits in their bank. You don’t have to prepare a steak dinner, but if they made their bed, picked up their room, or walked the dog without being asked, let them know you noticed. They should understand that trust is something they need to earn, not something they are automatically entitled to. This is one of the common stressors between parents and teenagers.

The way to bridge this divide is to give your son opportunities to earn your trust. Put his medication in a pill box with compartments for each day of the week. That way when he takes his medication you can see he took it. (Reminders are okay.) Acknowledge that he took his medication and tell him that taking his pill regularly earns him a deposit in the trust account.

Providing positive feedback for the effort he is making to build trust is an effective motivator. Once he earns that trust you can start doling out privileges, so be sure you decide in advance what privileges he’d like to have once you have the trust you need.

Expert Q&A with Lisa Kaufman, LCSW

Q: “Intense emotions are ruining my life. How can I control my temper?”

People with ADHD have intense emotions. Your highs are higher, and your lows are lower. So, you may experience happiness and criticism more powerfully than your peers and loved ones do. You can get frustrated and angry quickly, and it is hard to deal with everyday challenges when your responses are always extreme.

It is also common for individuals with ADHD to spend time ruminating on negative emotions. Many of my clients report that managing emotions is the most challenging aspect of ADHD. You may not feel like you have control over your emotions, but there is plenty you can do to modify their intensity before they damage your relationships with friends, loved ones, and co-workers.

To begin, a multimodal treatment plan including ADHD medication and behavior therapy, such as cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), has proven effective in helping people understand how situations and thought patterns affect their emotions.

Here are additional strategies for managing emotional dysregulation.

10 Strategies for Controlling Temper Flare-Ups

1. Understand How ADHD Affects Your Emotions

Recognize that emotional sensitivities are part of your disorder; they are common and measurable symptoms. This awareness can help you avoid unnecessary and destructive self-criticism over your hypersensitivity and intensified emotions.

2. Own Your Feelings

Coping with uncomfortable emotions is not about avoidance. Avoiding or suppressing your feelings will exacerbate them when you least expect it. Instead of putting a lid on your emotions, acknowledge them, accept them, and breathe through them.

3. Identify Your Triggers and Plan How to Deal with Them

Did your significant other's simple request to fold laundry differently, for example, set you off, and leave you wondering why you got so mad? Perhaps you perceived the comment as a personal attack. Knowing your triggers will help you gain control over your responses and reduce the number of times you feel blindsided by your emotions.

4. Be Prepared to Respond to Situations That Will Set You Off

Recognize the situations that might lead to a blowup. Think about your usual response, and consider what you can do to ensure a better outcome. Review your plan before you get into the situation again, and, if possible, make some notes or use a visual cue (perhaps a favorite bracelet) to remind you of the plan when the situation arises.

5. Replace Distorted Thoughts with Realistic Thinking

Individuals with ADHD encounter frequent and frustrating setbacks in life. Because of those setbacks, you may become self-critical and pessimistic. This, in turn, brings on negative emotions, cognitive distortions, and an unhealthy self-image.

6. Express Yourself

With a better understanding of your emotions, you can express yourself without anger. When you can articulate your feelings and say what you need, you will feel heard and understood. Let others know what is upsetting you.

7. Take a Time Out

When you are flooded with emotion, take some time and space until you feel more centered. This is a common strategy for relationships where anger-fueled disagreements cause conflict. When either person calls a time-out, both walk away from the problem and return after cooling down. Or create a mutually agreed upon verbal cue—a code word—that you use when emotions get out of hand.

8. Set Boundaries

After expressing strong anger, ask yourself, “What made me so angry?” It might be that someone overstepped a boundary. If you can define a boundary, rather than react after one has been crossed, you will feel respected and be less likely to get angry.

9. Prioritize Self-Care

Managing stress is fundamental to achieving emotional wellness. Self-care can reduce stress, relieve uncomfortable emotions, and improve physical and mental health. Basic self-care includes exercising regularly (to improve focus, improve and regulate mood, and increase self-esteem), getting enough sleep (people are more reactive with insufficient sleep), and getting solid nutrition (balanced meals help to regulate moods, focus, and energy levels).

10. Become Your Own Cheerleader

Replace self-criticism with self-compassion. When you are self-critical, you move further away from what you want—self-control. When you accept yourself, you give yourself encouragement. This is essential to building self-confidence and empowerment.

Lisa Kaufman, LCSW, is the founder of MindFuel Counseling based in Denver, Colorado.

“How I Calm Down My ADHD Brain: 14 Quick De-Stressors”

By Kate Moryoussef, UK-based well-being and lifestyle coach and podcast host

ADHD emotions are not only unstable and mercurial; they overlap, butt heads, and fight for our attention. Those of us with ADHD can feel a dozen emotions in an afternoon. We can also feel immature, out of control, and ashamed at the same time. The fight to rein in our emotions is emotionally and physically exhausting; it also chips away at our self-worth and overall well-being.

Over time, I have developed several tools to address this by reducing my restlessness, agitation, impatience, and explosive anger (to name a few emotional challenges).

The next time your blood boils or your tears flow, try one (or all) of the following techniques—which take just a few minutes—to calm down.

How to Calm Down: ADHD Emotional Dysregulation Strategies

1. Breathwork. A few moments of focused, deep breathing each day will calm the mind and body. Here are my favorite breathwork exercises, visualizations, and prompts.

- Breathe in like you are smelling a bouquet of fresh flowers and release as if you are blowing out candles.
- Imagine your breaths are like waves in the sea, ebbing and flowing.
- Picture yourself breathing in healing light and then blowing out that same light. Imagine that healing light overflowing past your lungs and through your whole body.
- Set a timer for four minutes. In that time, breathe in for four counts, hold for four counts, breathe out through the nose for four counts, then repeat.

Focusing on our breathing shifts our train of thought, which may feed into a negative emotion. If you struggle to stay present and quiet your mind, try repeating simple phrases in your head while you are breathing, like “I am breathing in. I am breathing out.”

Breathwork exercises work best when they’re practiced every hour. Set alerts on your phone or clock to remind you.

2. Perform this five senses mindfulness exercise by naming...

- Five things you can see.
- The farthest and closest sounds you can hear.
- Something you can smell. (A candle? Your deodorant? Clothes?)

- The taste in your mouth.
- How your body feels

3. EFT tapping is the practice of using your fingers to tap across points of the body to decrease stress and negative emotions. (I find tapping easier than meditating because I don't need to focus on quieting my mind.) I tap for a few minutes in the morning while repeating positive affirmations. I also tap in the shower, walking, and in the car. When I feel off, I set aside about 20 minutes to tap.

4. Give yourself a quick hand massage. Research published in *Complementary Therapies in Clinical Practice* and *Pain Management Nursing* on patients undergoing medical procedures shows that hand massages may help reduce anxiety. Try applying pressure to the Heart 7 (HT7) point, the area just below the crease of your wrist on your outer hand, for relief.

5. Compile a binaural beats music playlist and keep it on your laptop or phone. Binaural beats may encourage relaxation and decrease anxiety, while also helping with focus and concentration, according to a study published in *Psychological Research*.

6. Reach out to someone. When anxious thoughts consume you, think about someone who could use a loving phone call or text message. Even leaving a message is connecting. When we show compassion to others, it helps us do the same for ourselves.

7. List three things for which you are grateful. These can be as deep or as silly as you like. This exercise re-trains our brains to hunt for positives instead of scanning for negatives. The more we do it, the better we get at quickly locating moments of happiness, which will come in handy when we are feeling sad, stressed, or worried.

8. Create a vision board that showcases the good in your life, what you enjoy, and what you want to see more. (Mine consists of water, beaches, sunsets, and nature.) I look at my vision board for a few minutes daily.

9. Walk barefoot on the grass. This practice, known as grounding or earthing, means the bare body is making contact with the earth's surface. Research published in the *Journal of Inflammation Research* suggests that grounding may help reduce stress, among other health benefits. You can practice breathing exercises and think about what you are grateful for as you ground.

10. Do some micro-gardening, e.g., planting herbs or repotting house plants. Gardening (and spending time in nature in general) is a known stress and anxiety reducer.

11. Run yourself a bath, or, if pressed for time, fill up a bowl with warm water for a quick and relaxing foot soak.

12. Apply essential oils to specific body parts (wrist, behind the ears, etc.). Essential oils come in varieties, such as lavender, orange, chamomile, and others. A study

published in the *International Journal of Molecular Sciences* found that essential oils may reduce stress and positively affect mood. You can even blend oils for a calming yet uplifting pick-me-up.

13. Laugh. Laughing is one of the most effective stressbusters. Laughter makes us feel youthful, lighter, and more energized. If you don't have a reason to do it, fake it. Even simulated laughter has benefits, a meta-analysis published in *Social Science & Medicine* found. Or find a reason to laugh—go back to a funny video you saw online or watch your favorite comedy (*Friends* always does it for me). In general, try not to take life too seriously—even when it feels dreadful.

I'm a firm believer of stacking micro-techniques a few times a day to reduce stress and increase emotional resilience in the long term as opposed to one-off stress reduction sessions. Some of these micro-practices will speak to you one day and not the next. Allow yourself the freedom to pick and choose what works for you at any given time.

“Chill Skills: Calming My Emotional Child with ADHD”

By Penny Williams, parenting trainer, coach, and ADDitude contributor

In our household, we find ourselves saying, “Is it really worth all that?” to our son, “Ricochet.” His responses to frustration and social issues are often overdone for an 11-year-old boy. This is due to his ADHD and learning differences and can usually be tracked back to two triggers: an overly sensitive emotional reaction or the inability to handle a small amount of frustration appropriately.

Just this morning, Ricochet begged me not to make him go to school. I reminded him that it was Field Day, and he would have more fun than usual, but that only made it worse. After I got him inside the school building, I realized that the change in schedule and unpredictability of Field Day (and the last weeks of the school year) were probably to blame for today’s resistance to going to school. Not knowing what to expect (being without routine and schedule) causes frustration for Ricochet, often leading to an outburst, like the one in the school parking lot this morning.

What feeds this more is the fact that Ricochet has trouble communicating how he’s feeling in an appropriate manner. At times, he has struggled with identifying and labeling his feelings. You can’t deal with what you can’t define, so this often creates a troublesome situation for him and me. Now that Ricochet is old enough to start regulating his reactions, one of our current behavior goals is identifying, communicating, and regulating feelings and actions.

Ricochet began weekly occupational therapy (OT) again a few months ago after we took a couple of years off. His OT center works on identifying emotions and self-regulation with every patient, at every visit, through a program called The Zones of Regulation. After removing his shoes, Ricochet goes over to The Zones of Regulation chart on the wall with his OT. The chart has illustrations of emotions and feelings, categorized by color. Ricochet uses the illustrations to identify how he is feeling. Then he uses the color of the group that emotion belongs to in order to identify if he’s in a good place or needs to do some activities/exercises to move into a better zone.

Then, as his hour in OT ends, he revisits the chart to check in on how he is feeling. If he’s in an undesirable zone, his OT works with him on activities to help alleviate those feelings and regulate himself to a better zone.

We have been trying to work on this at home. I even bought a dry-erase Zones of Regulation chart and hung it on the wall in the kitchen, next to the pantry he accesses several times a day. If Ricochet is feeling out of sorts, we talk about what zone he is in, and what activities he has found helpful to “regulate” out of that zone and into a better one. Then I encourage him to do that activity. One activity we

have found effective in reducing anger is “belly breathing.” Ricochet takes deep breaths, filling and emptying his belly with air, until he feels calmer. These activities are a conscious precursor to self-regulation. Sometimes Momma needs some belly breathing, too.

I am in love with The Zones of Regulation approach, and I wish we had found it several years ago, but it’s not magic. When Ricochet is too angry, frustrated, anxious, or upset to think clearly and calmly, he can’t identify his zone and/or do the exercises to transition to a better zone. “I don’t care about what zone I’m in!” has been yelled in my face several times. This isn’t ADHD treatment, but a tool to cope with some lagging skills. The key with The Zones of Regulation is checking in on your zone frequently and consistently—and as soon as emotions begin to go south—before going off the deep end.

There are other behavior modification techniques for emotional regulation, too. Following are a few ideas to help smooth the emotional waters of ADHD:

- Many teachers use small pictures on a lanyard to remind students of appropriate behavior. This can work at home too, and possibly reduce parental nagging.
- Talk with your child about how their body feels when they experience each emotion. For example, “When I’m mad, my muscles are tight, my eyes squint, and my stomach hurts.”
- We have found some products to help calm Ricochet, too: a heavy blanket, a neck-roll beanbag, the HowdaHUG chair, a Skweezer bed sheet, compression clothing, fidgets with soothing textures (Ricochet likes Velcro), shirts with hoods, and many more.

“How Creative Self Expression Calms My Son’s Intense ADHD Symptoms”

By Carolyn Mara, artist, writer and mother of three

How do you think your child would respond if you asked them to pour a gallon of paint over you? I bet they’d react exactly how my child did: with a mischievous smile.

My youngest son loved the idea of getting to do something with his mother that would allow him to be a bit creative, a bit messy, and a bit destructive. But unknown to him, I had a motive other than fun: to help him deal with some of his issues stemming from ADHD. This creative endeavor, I felt, could teach him healthy coping mechanisms for managing emotional reactions he didn’t completely understand—and often couldn’t properly control.

Self-Expression to Manage Strong Feelings

As a career artist, I’m no stranger to using creative self-expression as a healthy outlet for my own feelings. Funneling my negative emotions into some sort of creative work has been my best and most helpful strategy for managing my mental health. I’ve also spent years teaching others how to find their artistic voice and use it to express their innermost feelings, especially when words are too difficult to find.

Creating art in any medium is a wonderful way to manage emotions. It acts as a release valve that allows you to externalize all your feelings and move on, knowing that those emotions will live on forever on a canvas or in a song, rather than inside your mind.

After my son’s ADHD diagnosis, I knew that helping him learn this crucial coping mechanism was the best way to start him down a path toward successfully managing some life-long issues with emotional regulation.

But it wasn’t going to be easy. His symptoms are vastly different from what I thought I knew about ADHD and how it manifests in children.

Intense ADHD Symptoms

My eldest son was also diagnosed with ADHD some time ago. His symptoms, contrary to his younger brother’s, fit the stereotypical ADHD mold. That’s why I was taken aback when a teacher suggested that I get my little one evaluated for ADHD. He didn’t have a problem getting his work done once he started, something that constantly plagued his older brother. Instead, he struggled with initiation—actually getting himself to sit down and start his work. My husband and I eventually learned that task avoidance is a symptom of ADHD. It turned out that it was anxiety, not defiance, that prevented him from getting started.

Now a mother to two boys with very different manifestations of ADHD, I felt compelled to find the best solutions to help them both based on their individual needs. After lots of research and many conversations with psychologists, we decided to focus on creative self-expression to manage my youngest son's symptoms.

This strategy seemed like a natural choice. My youngest has always been creative. He loves music, theater, as well as art, and has grown up watching my own artistic expression with much interest. I've often included him in my projects, something I never did with his older brother.

He is also a highly sensitive empath. He feels deeply and has an active imagination to go with it. His beautifully deep and emotionally expressive brain can take him down a rabbit hole, and his hyperfocus can keep him there, causing him to struggle to find his way back to a calm and rational state. When he faces criticism—whether it's a perceived attack or a demand to accept accountability—rejection sensitive dysphoria can kick in, ramping up his anxiety and frustration. This makes it very difficult to reason with him. His thinking becomes very narrow as he desperately tries to defend himself from feeling “bad.”

With the support of a trained professional, we have plans in place for when he begins to spiral. Step One is always to make him aware of what's happening and our intent to help. Step Two is to redirect his thoughts through creative expression. The goal is for him to independently use this coping plan down the line.

Artistic Expression to Manage Symptoms

We started a collaborative artistic project where he had all the control. I would lie down on a huge piece of paper, and have my son pour paint over me. We would use my iPhone and Apple Watch to record the experience and take photos of the result. The benefits were threefold—I could spend more time with him, allow him much-needed independence, and subtly teach him about healthy self-expression.

The task seemed simple, but it was difficult in action. The tray was sometimes too heavy for him, and the paint was not always the right consistency. But he had so much fun doing it, and he learned to manage the frustration that comes with carrying out a project. The more he practiced pouring paint over me, the better he got at controlling the tray and the paint. He learned how to create interesting splatter patterns, and he enjoyed trying new techniques. When I asked him if his cousins could join in and try, he was happy to invite them. I loved how he taught them what to do, and then guided them as they did it.

The project has since become a ritual—pulling out the huge roll of paper, choosing the colors and pouring them in the tray, discussing together the goal, while realizing the reality might be entirely different—and agreeing that's OK.

I want my son to grow up experiencing the power of creating and knowing that his mood can drastically change by pulling out paints and getting messy. Any artistic expression will do, really.

The lessons he learned throughout our project have paid real dividends. He has been exploring artistic expression on his own now, taking an interest in playing the piano and practicing his drawing skills.

We still have rough days, but he has moved forward in leaps and bounds. With small redirects, he can often choose better outlets to manage his frustrations, and I am thrilled to see the progress he has made.

“How an Angry Monkey, a Worried Mouse, and Harry Potter Helped My Daughter Understand Her Emotions”

By Brittney D. Herz, a freelance writer, and homeschool mom

At two and a half, my daughter’s anger was her most challenging symptom—even though we didn’t realize ADHD caused her emotional outbursts at the time. One day I watched as she developed all the telltale signs of an impending meltdown. Her face reddened. Her little fists balled up. In moments, I was sure the screaming would start. But then, she held up her hand, as if she were holding a flower. She pursed her lips and blew like she was blowing bubbles. She did this a few times until the tension released from her shoulders.

Mystified, I asked, “What did you just do?”

“I blew on my pinwheel like little monkey does,” she said.

For a few weeks, we had been reading *Little Monkey Calms Down* during our nightly routine. It’s a simple board book about a monkey who gets upset when he spills his ice cream and has a tantrum. He soothes himself in different ways by hugging himself, singing, or blowing on a pinwheel. I realized then that the books we read helped us with more than just calming down at bedtime.

Since I was a teenager, I have used books as an escape, a form of stress release. However, it wasn’t until becoming a librarian, and the mother of a child with ADHD, that I understood the concept of bibliotherapy for younger children. Dealing with ADHD, and other conditions, is confusing at the best of times. My daughter didn’t understand her symptoms any more than I did at first. I read nonfiction books about symptoms and treatments. Together, we read fictional stories about characters who struggled with fear and anger like she did.

When she turned three, getting her out of the car at daycare became our biggest challenge. It was a battle every day. The owner had to come out and help pry her from under the back seats where she screamed and hid. At the time, I did not know that anxiety and ADHD often occur together and that children express anxious feelings as anger and aggression.

I borrowed *Wemberly Worried* from the library because the cute mouse clutching a stuffed animal on the cover reminded me of my daughter with her stuffed bunny. As we read about this little creature, who worried about everything, my daughter sat transfixed. Then, Wemberly had to go to school.

When we read the list of things Wemberly worried about, she said, “I think those things sometimes.”

When we saw how “Wemberly worried and worried, and she worried all the way there,” my daughter sighed. “I worry like that.” She had never said the word worry before. We hadn’t used that term. It was always “I hate it.” “I don’t want to!” “No, no, no.”

The book gave her the new vocabulary to name her out-of-control feelings. What was this worry and how did it make her feel? What can we do to stop it, besides being angry? What can I do to make it better? What should I say instead of, “Stop worrying”? We read on, and, to my daughter’s relief, Wemberly’s school experience was a happy one. Some nights, when she started talking about school, I mentioned Wemberly—knowing that fear was creeping in. The book didn’t cure her nerves, but sometimes she could talk about it instead of having an angry outburst.

Through years of reading, she has learned more words to describe her feelings. We have talked about frustration, patience, and empathy for others. *A Bad Case of Stripes* introduced bullying and the importance of staying true to oneself, something many children with ADHD struggle with. The main character makes such an effort to blend in that she becomes a spectacle and is mocked all the time. That is until she admits that she does like lima beans—which she was trying to hide because she knew others didn’t like them.

Now that my daughter is going into the first grade and more children her age know about her ADHD, she has a harder time socializing and making friends. Once or twice, she has told me about being picked on or made fun of. So, we started reading *Harry Potter and the Sorcerer’s Stone*. Although she’s too young to understand most of the series, she relates to Harry in many ways. He’s picked on by the Dursleys, bullied by Malfoy, and feels alone or different for most of his life. However, he gains self-confidence when he discovers the special gift he had all along. Harry gives my daughter hope that she can feel at home with her ADHD.

Reading offers her an escape and gives us a path to address her challenging emotions. The stories help her learn about herself, and, in the process, help me learn about her.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Mark Bertin, M.D.; Rebecca Branstetter, Ph.D.; Caroline Buzanko, Ph.D.; Brittney D. Herz; Lisa Kaufman, LCSW; Ellen Littman, Ph.D.; Caroline Maguire, M.Ed., ACCG, PCC; Brendan Mahan, M.Ed., M.S.; Carolyn Mara; Liz Matheis, Ph.D.; Kate Moryoussef; Joel Nigg, Ph.D.; Nancy Ratey, Ed.M.; Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.; Sharon Saline, Psy.D.; and Penny Williams.

CHAPTER 6

Personal Stories + Additional Resources

Chapter 6: Personal Stories + Additional Resources

How to Throttle Intense Emotions

We asked our readers: Which therapy, treatment, or strategy has helped you best manage the difficult emotions that can come with ADHD? Here's what they said.

"I manage intense emotions by walking away from a situation, counting to myself to calm down, then returning to the situation."—*Nicole, New York*

"Medication and articles on the *ADDitude* website."—*Jennifer, Oklahoma*

"Support groups of other parents and the book *Parenting with Love and Logic*, by Foster Cline and Jim Fay."—*An ADDitude Reader*

"I learned some techniques in therapy, including taking several seconds to stop and **ask myself things like, 'What am I really angry about right now?'** before I respond."—*Jen, Florida*

"A combination of **Concerta and psychotherapy.** The meds help me stay focused, and the therapy helps me deal with the shame I felt growing up, thinking I was stupid."
—*Lee, California*

"I'm still working on it, but prayer, **reading my Bible,** and specifically focusing on anger is helping. Joyce Meyer's books, especially *Battlefield of the Mind*, are great, as well."
—*Terri, California*

"Talk therapy and having my therapist monitor my medication. She has also suggested **nutritional changes that have made a huge difference in my mood and focus.**"
—*Lalena, California*

"A combination of **medicine, talk therapy, executive coaching, and cognitive behavioral therapy** has helped."—*Chris, Missouri*

CHAPTER 6: PERSONAL STORIES + ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

“CBT and ADHD meds have helped, but **an understanding spouse**, with gentle reminders and strong rebukes, when needed, is the key.”—*Peter, Ontario, Canada*

“Focalin has helped me manage my emotions, along with **journaling and listening to motivational messages**.”—*Marilyn, California*

“Medication and counseling have helped, but **nothing beats a good night’s sleep** for keeping me on an even keel.”—*Lisa, Missouri*

“**Meditation has been invaluable** in helping me manage my moods.”—*Elizabeth, Texas*

“Hmmm, great question. Once I figure it out, I’ll let you know. Seriously, **my husband is a godsend**. I’d be a total mess without him to calm the storm.”—*Stefanie, Massachusetts*

“**Talking with my mom!**”—*An ADDitude Reader*

“I use **exercise and clean eating** to keep my stress levels down and to improve my concentration.”—*Lisa, Illinois*

“**Play therapy** has been great for my son. It took him a while to warm up to his therapist, but now that he trusts her, he’s willing to try her suggestions.”—*Darcy, Idaho*

“Routine exercise! **I enjoy kickboxing** three days a week and resistance training on three other days. It has been the best choice for managing my emotions.”—*Amy, Nebraska*

17 Happiness Rules When ADHD Emotions Go Awry

By Edward Hallowell, M.D.

People with ADHD have trouble controlling emotions and moods. If we don't understand how our emotions affect our lives, and we don't have ways to rein them in, our days can turn into a roller-coaster ride. We all need to be aware of our emotional triggers—and develop strategies to avoid pulling them—to stay on an even keel.

Learn to keep your feelings under control with these 17 tips:

1. **Have structured “blow-out time.”** Set aside time every week for letting go. Whatever you like to do—blasting loud music, taking a trip to the racetrack, having a feast—to let loose safely.
2. **Recharge your batteries.** Most adults with ADHD need some time to waste every day without feeling guilty about it. Call it “time to recharge my batteries.” Take a nap, watch TV, or meditate.
3. **Choose healthy fixations, such as exercise.** Many adults with ADHD have a compulsive personality or are prone to dependencies. Try to make your obsession positive.
4. **Understand your mood changes.** Know that your moods will change, no matter what's happening around you. Don't waste time figuring out the reason why or looking for someone to blame. Focus on learning to tolerate a bad mood, knowing that it too will pass—and find ways to make it pass sooner. Getting involved with some new activity (preferably one that involves people)—coffee with a close friend, playing tennis, or joining a reading group, etc.—will help.
5. **Recognize the following cycle,** which is common among adults with ADHD. Something “startles” your psychological system—a change or transition, a disappointment, or a success. The cause of the “startle” may be trivial, but it is followed by mini panic, with a sudden loss of perspective. The world becomes topsy-turvy. You try to deal with the panic by obsessing and ruminating over one or more aspects of the situation. This can last for hours, days, or even months.
6. **Plan scenarios to deal with the inevitable blahs.** Have a list of friends to call. Select a few videos that always engross you and get your mind off things. Have a punching bag or pillow handy if you have angry energy. Rehearse a pep talk that you can give yourself, like, “You've been here before. These are the ADHD blues. They will soon pass. You are OK.”

7. **Expect sad feelings after success.** People with ADHD complain of feeling down after a big success. This is because the stimulus of the chase, the challenge, or the preparation is over. The deed is done. Win or lose, the adult with ADHD misses the conflict, and the stimulus, and feels deflated.
8. **Develop sayings as shorthand** ways of putting slip-ups, mistakes, or mood swings into perspective. When you turn left instead of right and take your family on a 20-minute detour, it is better to say, “There goes my ADHD again,” than to have a six-hour fight over your unconscious desire to sabotage the trip. These are not excuses. You have to take responsibility for your actions. It is good to know where your actions are coming from.
9. **Use time-outs.** When you are upset or overstimulated, leave the room, take a walk around the block, and calm down.
10. **Learn to advocate for yourself.** Adults with ADHD are accustomed to being criticized, so they wind up being unnecessarily defensive in putting their own case forward. If you find ways to stand up for yourself, you won’t be as defensive when someone has a beef with you.
11. **Avoid premature closure of a project,** a conflict, a deal, or a conversation. Don’t “cut to the chase” too soon, even if you want to.
12. **Savor your successful moments.** You’ll have to train yourself to do this because people with ADHD soon forget their successes. Remember that ADHD includes a tendency to hyperfocus, which can be used constructively or destructively. Be aware of its destructive tendency to obsess over an imagined problem.
13. **Exercise vigorously and regularly.** Exercise is one of the best treatments for ADHD. It works off excess energy and aggression, quiets the mind, stimulates the hormonal and neurochemical system in a therapeutic way, and soothes and calms the body. Make the physical activity something fun, so you can stick with it for the rest of your life.
14. **Learn to joke with yourself and others about your various symptoms,** from forgetfulness and getting lost all the time to being tactless or impulsive. If you handle mistakes with a sense of humor, others will forgive you more quickly.
15. **Schedule activities with friends.** Stick to these schedules faithfully. It is crucial for you to stay connected to other people.
16. **Find and join groups** where you are liked, appreciated, understood, and enjoyed. On the other hand, don’t stay too long where you aren’t understood or appreciated.
17. **Pay compliments.** Take time to notice other people and talk with them. Get social training if you need it.

“I Felt Guilty for Feeling Guilty... and Overwhelmed... and Angry... and Inconsolable.”

By Caylin LeFevre, ADDitude contributor

Here’s a childhood experience that still makes for a great story at family gatherings, and one I often use to make a point about intense emotions in ADHD brains like mine: Standing over the metallic sink in our kitchen, I rolled up my sleeves to muster up all the elbow grease I could in my small arms. The clattering and sloshing of the dishes muffled my siblings’ laughter a room away.

Something shiny suddenly caught my eye out the kitchen window. A dull light flickered in the dark windows of our garage. Instantly, fear throttled my throat, and a whimper whirled out.

My little figure whipped around, and my feet went flying out of the room. Soon the muffled laughter of my siblings turned into discordant sobs. Our four little hearts beat very fast—Mom was currently at the store. We were alone at home with the ominous light.

“It looks like a flashlight,” I said, my voice hushed and solemn.

My siblings’ eyes grew wide. We gathered around to scheme about where to hide as the image of robbers with dangerous weapons darkened our minds.

The sound of tires against gravel soon filled the night air and before long, four hysterical little voices enveloped our mom. Shamefully, my sobs rose louder than even my youngest siblings’ did. It seemed to me that our lives were in danger. Mom said that she was going to investigate. This soothed my siblings, but I desperately grabbed hold of her.

“Don’t go, Mom. They will hurt you,” I cried. “Mom, we need to hide now. Call the police!”

My mom gently resisted and continued to speak in a soothing voice. After investigating, she announced that the light was merely the reflection of the dog’s silver water bowl gleaming in the garage window.

Emotional Dysregulation and ADHD: What’s the Connection?

Not all my moments of emotional dysregulation are quite so humorous. I have ADHD and can tell you too many embarrassing stories about my tantrums, outbursts, and intense emotions. But I probably don’t need to, because you already understand—emotional dysregulation is common in individuals with ADHD.

Fascinating research has uncovered more details about emotional dysregulation and ADHD, with brain differences in some individuals with the condition appearing to be the core of this linkage. Research suggests that a significant subset of people with

ADHD have an overactive amygdala—the parts of the brain that attach emotions to experiences. In other words, some ADHD brains ascribe too much emotion to an experience, as my brain tends to do—when I saw the light through the window, for example, my brain unconsciously defaulted to interpreting it in the “worst light possible”(so to speak).

Many other factors apart from brain differences, however, can also heighten emotional dysregulation in those with ADHD. These include environmental factors, lifestyles, and comorbid mental health conditions like anxiety.

Still, the intense emotions that often accompany ADHD for many people, including myself, can make life difficult because they feel real and justified. My amygdala shouted at the rest of my brain that I needed to be afraid in that moment many years ago. My brain listened, and even found a scary, unlikely explanation for my fear: We are being robbed!

It seemed logical at the moment to respond with hysterical pleas and frantic plans to hide, believing we were in immediate danger. My surprised mother, meanwhile, struggled to understand how I jumped to such a conclusion. But I am sure that you can probably relate to others finding your reactions disproportionate to the situation.

Emotional Dysregulation: Don't Hold It Against Us

The decades that I spent struggling with intense emotions made sense once I learned about emotional dysregulation and ADHD. I now know, for example, that I was not “misbehaving” every time I threw a tantrum as a child.

Understanding that emotional dysregulation appears to be rooted in biology, and that my brain is wired differently than most, makes all the difference. The problem, I know, is no longer me.

It is time to let go of the guilt associated with emotional dysregulation. I encourage anyone with ADHD to research their own symptoms and seek professional help to better understand themselves. We need to speak openly about our challenges. They are real. They are explained, in part, by unique differences in our brains.

“I’m So Sensitive, But I Wouldn’t Give It Up for the World”

Caroline Westlake, naturalist, conservationist, and writer living in Hanoi, Vietnam

I was diagnosed with combined ADHD at the age of 13, and dyspraxia at 23. My mum always said I was a sensitive, gentle child. I rescued drowning bugs from the swimming pool on holiday and made sure the new kid at school didn’t feel left out.

Being sensitive is a blessing and a curse. The world may see you as overly emotional, someone who takes everything to heart and who needs to lighten up. Or it may see you as having a gift or special insight.

Being a woman with ADHD, I fell out of the “sensitive tree” and hit every branch on the way down. When I am criticized or make a mistake, I look back and assess all the negative remarks I have received in my life. I often conclude that I’m a disaster in a matter of seconds.

Trying to hold back my tears in front of a hard-nosed boss, who has made it clear that he finds crying women irritating and uncomfortable, is as difficult for me as trying not to laugh in church. Once the floodgates open, there is no stopping it. The only way to avoid the humiliation is to find a quiet place and gather my thoughts.

What is it about having ADHD that makes me so sensitive? Being reminded that I’m different contributes to it. Being corrected by others when I make a mistake or do something differently makes me take everything to heart. I also lack emotional filters. Because I can’t focus on just one thing, I am tuned in to everything in my surroundings, including the body language and emotions of others, their strengths, and weaknesses. I am unable to shut out what it must feel like to be them.

I can be a good friend and a big comfort in a time of crisis. I can reel off all the positive things I have noted about the person/situation that others hadn’t noticed. I am deeply moved by injustice, and I will passionately defend those in need.

My sensitivity extends to animals. At work, as a zookeeper and a naturalist, I am the first of my colleagues to notice if something isn’t right with an animal.

“We can’t call the vet just because you have a feeling there is something wrong with him,” my boss said, after checking over a meerkat I was worried about.

“But his fur is fluffed up, and he is moving gingerly,” I replied.

“Well, the other guys have looked at him, too, and they say he seems fine. Just keep an eye on him.”

Sadly, a few days later, the meerkat took a turn for the worse and suddenly died.

“The autopsy revealed that he had heartworm,” my boss said, while handing me a pen and paper. “I don’t know how you saw that, but I want you to write down all the animals you have been worried about and we’ll get the vet to check them this

afternoon.” Pretty much every animal that I listed that day had some form of subtle ailment and was treated.

Being sensitive doesn’t just help others. It gives those of us with ADHD our creative flair. We absorb the world around us like sponges and take note of the subtle details. Sensitivity is often linked to creativity and problem-solving skills. By being sensitive to our surroundings, we develop unique observations that give birth to the ideas that can lead to our success!

There are many examples of entrepreneurs, performers, and brilliant minds who were diagnosed with ADHD, and who have used their sensitivity and observation skills to tap into the needs of others and make the world a better place. For example:

- Being sensitive to what makes people laugh is what made Jim Carrey a comedy legend. Growing up, his mother battled depression. To lift her spirits, he would wear tap shoes to bed in case she needed cheering up in the middle of the night.
- Being sensitive to the ways of the universe and constantly questioning and exploring how the world works is what made Albert Einstein a unique kind of genius. He once said: “The most beautiful and profound emotion we can experience is the sensation of the mystical. It is the sower of all true science. He to whom this emotion is a stranger, who can no longer wonder and stand rapt in awe, is good as dead.”
- Richard Branson’s sensitivity to the needs of others led him to discover gaps in the marketplace and to create products and businesses to fill them. He is one of the most successful entrepreneurs in the world today.

Sometimes the flood of emotions is distressing—and embarrassing. I have learned to deal with them, but not to ignore them. Our feelings are valid; otherwise, we wouldn’t feel them. They let us know when something isn’t right. They guide us out of situations that are unhealthy and lead us to places, people, and things that make us happy.

The following *ADDitude* experts and authors contributed to this chapter: Edward Hallowell, M.D.; Caylin LeFevre; and Caroline Westlake.

Additional Resources

Books

Mindful Parenting for ADHD: A Guide to Cultivating Calm, Reducing Stress, and Helping Children Thrive

By Mark Bertin, M.D.

<https://amzn.to/3VCaeas>

Smart but Stuck: Emotions in Teens and Adults with ADHD

By Thomas E. Brown, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3fnaDgS>

Taking Charge of ADHD: The Complete, Authoritative Guide for Parents

By Russell A. Barkley, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3rgTGHl>

The Explosive Child: A New Approach for Understanding and Parenting Easily Frustrated, Chronically Inflexible Children

By Ross W. Greene, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3qK6zo5>

The Highly Sensitive Person: How to Thrive When the World Overwhelms You

By Elaine N. Aron, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3KVxZqN>

The Mindfulness Prescription for Adult ADHD: An 8-Step Program for Strengthening Attention, Managing Emotions, and Achieving Your Goals

By Lidia Zylowska, M.D.

<https://amzn.to/49bq9ni>

Your Brain's Not Broken: Strategies for Navigating Your Emotions and Life with ADHD

By Tamara Rosier, Ph.D.

<https://amzn.to/3qInO1K>

CHAPTER 6: PERSONAL STORIES + ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Online Support Groups

- ***ADDitude* ADHD Support Group**

(<https://www.facebook.com/groups/additudemag/>)

This *ADDitude* Facebook group offers positive connection and support—without judgment or criticism.

- ***ADDitude* ADHD Support Group for Parents**

(<https://www.facebook.com/groups/adhdparentsgroup/>)

This *ADDitude* Facebook group offers positive connections and support for parents of children with ADHD and related conditions.

Organizations

The A.D.D. Resource Center (addrc.org)

Attention Deficit Disorder Association (ADDA) (add.org)

Children and Adults with Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (CHADD) (chadd.org)

Child Mind Institute (childmind.org)

The Centre for ADHD Awareness, Canada (caddac.ca)

Directories

ADDitude's ADHD Directory (directory.additudemag.com)

The ADHD Coaches Organization (ACO) (acoo.memberclicks.net)

The American Professional Society of ADHD and Related Disorders (APSARD) member directory (apsard.org/portal/directory)

ADHD Expert Webinars & Podcast Episodes from *ADDitude*:

“How Emotional Dysregulation & ADHD Transform Teen Relationships from Messes to Minefields”

>> additu.de/emotionteen

The ability to regulate emotions exists on a continuum, and teens with ADHD have been shown to be twice as likely as their neurotypical peers to struggle with emotional dysregulation, which is identified as one of the most common and yet most impairing symptoms for teens with ADHD. Emotional dysregulation has been shown to decrease the quality of life for teens with ADHD more than ADHD alone. Here, Ellen Littman, Ph.D., provides a better understanding of this core symptom, and its relationship to ADHD. When both parents and teens are better educated and prepared, they can focus on coping with the emotional tsunamis together.

“All the Feels: An ADHD Guide to Emotional Dysregulation and Rejection Sensitive Dysphoria”

>> additu.de/webinar-rsd

Among the biggest emotional challenges facing adults with ADHD is rejection sensitive dysphoria (RSD), an extreme sensitivity to criticism and judgment that seems to exist only in those diagnosed with the disorder. Here, William Dodson, M.D., LF-APA, explains why RSD may be unique to people with ADHD and how out-of-control emotions undermine relationships, self-confidence, and a strong sense of self. The good news is that there are effective treatments that address it head-on. Dr. Dodson discusses treatment options, such as medications that can prevent emotional impulsivity, behavioral therapies such as CBT and DBT, and more.

“You’re So Emotional!’ Why ADHD Brains Wrestle with Emotional Regulation”

>> additu.de/webinar-316

One of the most difficult—and under-appreciated—challenges of ADHD is managing the intense emotions and moods that hijack our everyday lives. Emotional dysregulation—or the inability to properly modulate and regulate feelings—is often seen in people with ADHD, starting in childhood and lasting into adulthood. Emotional instability is not unique to people diagnosed with ADHD, but it presents a unique source of impairment in patients with ADHD. In this webinar, Joel Nigg, Ph.D., breaks down recent research studying the role of emotion in managing ADHD and dispels common clinical misunderstandings about emotions and ADHD, and the challenges of distinguishing between those emotions and other conditions, such as bipolar disorder.

FREE ADHD Newsletters from *ADDitude*

Sign up to receive critical news and information about ADHD diagnosis and treatment, plus strategies for school, parenting, and living better with ADHD:
additu.de/newsletter

Parenting Children and Teens with ADHD

Behavior, discipline, positive parenting, social skills, impulsivity, organization

Living with Adult ADHD

Getting things done, time management, food & nutrition, careers, organization, emotions

Treating ADHD with Natural Remedies and Medication

Food and nutrition, supplements, natural treatments, medication, alternative therapies

ADHD and LD at School

Learning strategies, accommodations, 504 Plans and IEPs, homework help

Weekly Round Up

The best articles of the week on ADDitudeMag.com

For Women with ADHD

Managing a family with ADHD, organization/clutter, time management, shame and emotions, more

Special Newsletters

Everything New This Week

Don't miss a single news story, blog post, or Q&A published on ADDitudeMag.com

ADHD/LD Learning Series for Educators

Realistic, effective solutions to the specific academic and behavioral challenges associated with ADHD and LD in the classroom

8-Week Parenting Class

The very best ADHD parenting strategies, one email per week

5 Weeks to Healthy New Habits

Strategies for defeating clutter, increasing productivity, strengthening relationships, and more

ADHD Research Digest for Clinicians

Informed summaries of the latest in ADHD research and news

The Adult's Guide to ADHD Diagnosis and The Adult's Guide to ADHD Treatment

More **ADDitude** eBooks Available Now

additudemag.com/shop

Inattentive ADHD in Adults

An Essential Guide to the Underdiagnosed, Undertreated Subtype

People with inattentive ADHD often lack symptoms of external hyperactivity. They may be considered daydreamers or appear disinterested and disorganized. Sometimes these individuals make “careless” mistakes because they have difficulty sustaining focus, following detailed instructions, and organizing tasks and activities. Because of this, inattentive ADHD often complicates relationships, finances, and work. This downloadable eBook is here to help, providing ADHD-friendly tips from *ADDitude* editors, readers, and experts.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/inattentiveadultsebook

Declutter Your Life (and Home! and Office!)

ADHD-Friendly Hacks for Purging, Organizing, and Maintaining a Clutter-Free Home

How can we declutter our ADHD lives when we're paralyzed by our paper piles or unsure where to start? What if we are emotionally attached to objects we no longer need or become so oblivious to our surroundings that we cease to see that our homes are in disarray? When do collecting habits border on hoarding tendencies? This downloadable eBook answers those questions and more.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/declutterbook

Positive Parenting Strategies

How ADHD Families Can Improve Self-Esteem, Emotional Control, and Communication

Standard parenting approaches are not only ineffective but may exacerbate behavior problems in children with ADHD. By learning a different parenting approach, you can make a positive impact. This eBook is here to help, providing ADHD-friendly tips from *ADDitude* editors, readers, and experts. This eBook explains why positive parenting strategies work better than traditional punishments to improve your child's behavior and how to foster your child's self-esteem, confidence, and emotional regulation. Above all, you'll learn how to change your child's problem behaviors, teach better ones, and create a happy, safe, and supportive family environment.

>> Learn more about this eBook: additu.de/positiveparenting

FREE *ADDitude* Downloads

Evaluate Your Teen's Emotional Control

A quick temper can harm friendships and get teens in trouble in school. Uncover your teen's emotional weaknesses and learn ways to build emotional control.

Get a Grip on Tough Emotions

Strategies to understand your feelings—and get them under control.

Understanding RSD

Learn how to identify and treat rejection sensitive dysphoria

Emotional Regulation & Anger Management Scripts

Boost your emotional regulation skills with these metacognition-building scripts and questions.

Free Guide to Health & Fitness: Lifestyle Changes for Adults with ADHD

Learn which healthy eating habits and foods support ADHD brain health.

73 ADHD-Friendly Ways to Organize Your Life Now

Learn how small daily changes can lead to less clutter—and less stress.

Your 10 Toughest Discipline Dilemmas—Solved!

Does your child melt down, act up, or outright refuse to comply? Here, parenting experts provide discipline strategies for defiant or otherwise challenging children.

13 Parenting Strategies for Kids with ADHD

What does it take to be a great parent to a child with ADHD? A few adjustments in your parenting skills and the way you interact with your child. Find out what works, and why.

Find these and many more free ADHD resources online at:

additudemag.com/download